

The Black House

Edited Working Edition

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Edited working edition assembled from standalone story revisions.

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Prelude

What qualifies a vision? What makes it what it is? What could possibly be its composition? Is a vision of something, what one gleans from it, the same content as a dream? Such questions are difficult by design, yet comparatively easy in a sphere of rational thought. As for me, I do not have the answers. It could be because I do not spend my time dwelling on such topics. I just accept the dreams for what they are, enjoy the feelings, no matter how odd they may be. I cannot help, though, wondering where these *mind pictures* originate. Maybe it is just transference of distinct images, collected in day living, from the subconscious to the conscious and visa-versa. It is a fact that your brain has already made a decision by the time you are conscious of it. So do the visions, the dreams, the images come from within or without?

I do not know what to think or believe, but I do know that I am continually haunted by demons of the night. When a topic such as this affixed itself in my mind, I was not quite sure what I should write, but I felt that I should try to communicate that part of me that is seldom discussed. So here goes.

My visions on that night of October were, to say the least, nightmares. So vivid and full of color were they that upon my waking, I felt that I was still beyond the wall of sleep. I wish I could illustrate my images fully, but I have trouble describing them, since they are clear in my mind but not so when I put them on paper.

I will begin by prefacing that this vision was quite perplexing, which, in turn, makes translation difficult. A good portion of it was spoken in Latin. I took a course at University in it so I could read ancient texts. So I will admit I would be *conscious* of hearing it, although not to its explicit meaning. I hope I can convey this vision in a clear diction and format. I do not want any meaning, implied or otherwise, to be lost. I feel I have covered everything needed to understand what I am about to reveal.

It was almost nightfall and I appeared in front of a house of some kind...a large structure hewn out of grey stone that was unrecognized by me. Four tiers towered above, reaching to the sky, yet the others had fallen from the weathering of the passing of time. Dark, cavernous windows glared down at me, withholding the blackness within. Magnificent gargoyles hunched on the roofline did no more than to stare at me with their gritty eyes. All was in an advanced state of disarray. There were loose bits of carved stone lying sporadically on the paved surface. Paving that once was neatly divided into octagonal shapes now scarred with deep crevices lead to the depths of the earth. I knew the place, as if I had lived there in a previous life, but, of course, this is all in my mind.

I made my way across the littered courtyard and inspected the rest of the grounds. It was forested with numerous large gnarled oak trees. The trees were quite dead as their barks were peeling and their large, droopy branches cried out for a saving grace that

was not present in this forsaken landscape. As I moved close to one, I witnessed something I will not easily forget. For not only was the wood of this tree twisted, but there also were human faces, faces embedded into the composition of the tree. They expressed much pain and suffering as I have not seen before. As I stared at the images, I could almost see their anguished faces moving and changing shape. Then, all of them looked at me in unison. Their jaws fell open and they uttered low, excruciating moans. Moans of such a magnitude that the dusty sound rattled the bones in my ears and pricked the hairs upon my neck. I jumped back from the tree so as not to be drawn into it.

A sharp wind then whisked its way through my hair. A cold wind, carrying with it the moans, as well as the smell of the life that had been before. An odor so pungent that I tore myself away from the tree and paced back to the front of the grey stone building. As I stood there facing the enormous structure, what I thought was a voice called from its interior. A hard, dry, crackled voice that I indeed recognized from my own past. I dare not say what the voice was or what it resembled, since writing about it makes me feel uncomfortable, and I could lose my train of thought in doing so. The voice beckoned me to enter the house. I kicked up the sand at my feet and ventured slowly to the mammoth entrance.

As I moved closer, I peered through the open doors. Blackness belched its musty breath at me and enveloped my senses. I was now inside the house, black and foreboding, but not by my own locomotion. It was as dark as the deepest abyss. I felt along the grainy walls and found a candle sitting on its stand by a window. It lit itself, by a means I know not of, and I followed the voice to a small chapel. I walked down the aisle, past rows of overturned pews,

to the altar. All I had was the lone candle to cut my way through the almost complete darkness. I managed to avoid stumbling over most of the larger debris, but I had that nagging feeling that I knew where everything was. As if I had been paraded down this eerie hall in some earlier time. I could extinguish the candle and still find my way, that's how well I knew where I was. But my sanity wouldn't allow me to. As my eyes focused on the marble altar, thunder began raging outside and bolts of lightning illuminated most of the pith in which I stood.

The sound of that familiar voice still echoed within the hall, and I noticed that it was not emanating from the altar, but instead from its side. It directed me to it. This is the point where I fail to describe fully what I heard since the voice was speaking phrases in Latin, which I understood at the time, but upon waking I found that the words had dissipated. Although my walking was slow, I quickly arrived at the source of the voice. It was then that I do remember exactly what was said. The same phrase was repeated endlessly, over and over, insuring my memorization. I was standing only a few meters from a large, polished, black onyx sarcophagus. I stood next to it; hundreds of decayed flowers and thirty or so exhausted candles littered its surface and the granite floor it rested upon. I set my candle in one of the copper stands that encircled the tomb and placed my hands on the smooth lid of the chamber. The voice was issuing from its interior. That voice that had dug its way through my entire mind and body was now calling to me; it repeated again and again,

“Requiem aeternam dona eis, Domine.”

By now I was at a loss what to do next. Terror had long been ingrained in me since my entrance into the black house. I peered

at the inscriptions carved into the surface of the lid. They shot through me like the lightning that was riveting its way across the frozen sky outside. I lifted the mighty lid and fearfully observed its contents. The leathery face that gazed back at me with its glassy eyes and yellowed teeth made me scream. I was still; I couldn't move. The face just looked at me, and as it opened its mouth to smile, its decayed skin cracked and split. I dropped the lid and ran screaming through the dark house. I never heard my screams, they were silent.

I tripped several times over the stony debris. I overturned several things and billowed up great amounts of dust, but I made my way out, only to be greeted by a group of people I realized I had known, but they are dead. Archaic laughter expelled from the grey stone house as I stood face to face with a barrage of animated bodies in various states of decay. Their gleaming white bones shone through their dripping, mud-stained flesh; they smiled wide, paralyzing smiles. I turned to run, but was surrounded, for the giant wooden doors of the church had now become the iron gates of the white marble mausoleum. Laughter continued from its interior, and I turned and faced the horde. Their eyes gaped as they lunged themselves at me and tore at my flesh.

I abruptly awoke in a cold sweat. I prayed that when I opened my eyes that I would be in my own room. Luckily, I did arise in my own dwelling. As I collected my senses, I reviewed what I had just experienced. I grabbed the notebook that was close to my bed, and as I wrote out what I felt, I realized what was in that shimmering onyx coffin, and terror struck me once again. For what I saw in the depths of that dark vault, what I heard as that voice rang through the long deserted halls of the structure, and what I read on the top

of that lid all had something in common. What they revealed to me was something that I never wanted to come to terms with, they did everything for one single purpose. They foreshadowed my own passing to the realm occupied by death.

The scene changes, first at a slow pace, then rapidly becomes filled with light. I've seen one kind of ending, one way to deal with my place in the world. Now, another vision, another memory, one more fitting, and one I would find myself more likely to believe in.

Back in the days when I was younger, my parents used to take my younger sister, my brother, and me on long drives from where we lived to visit family. Sometimes on these long trips, we would camp at grounds a few kilometers from the highway. I remembered eating baloney sandwiches noticing how the bread would become drier more rapidly than when at home. The campgrounds were sylvan with areas of isolation where a child's imagination could take hold and find itself filled with lucid fantasies. After several summer trips, the multifaceted experiences coalesced in a dream.

I was back at one of the campgrounds a substantial distance from the highway. I was alone and the trees seemed to emanate an unspoken monologue as they swayed in an invisible wind. Moving away from the campground deeper into the forest, I heard a faint mewling in the distance. It was broken and desperate, its cries echoing. I thought to call to my parents to draw their attention to it, but remembered I was alone. A wave of fear gripped me, but it dissipated as quickly as it rose. Instead of being afraid, I possessed courage with a distinct purpose. I navigated the unknown terrain drawn onward by the sound. As I got closer, I recognized it could have been a small animal, perhaps a cat, which sounded as if in trouble.

As I passed over a rise and into a small sunken area of the forest, the mew rose to a fevered pitch. It was definitely a cat, I was sure of it. I quickened my pace, the trees wavered above me, the grasses pushed me forward, and soon I would be on top of the sound. On the approaching horizon, a large, old tree, its trunk thick and gnarled, drew my attention. As my eyes focused, the sound emanated near it. I started to run. Branches became tendrils, pointing feverishly toward the sound; the forest was alive with cries and bristling overhead. I arrived at the gnarled tree, put my hands on it, and looked for the sound; it was close and just on the other side of it. I spun around and found the source of the sound. At its foot was a newborn kitten, small and frail. In the moment that I gazed at the creature and the scene, its oddity swelled in me like a rising tide.

The kitten was flailing to release itself from the shell of an egg, blue and lustrous with black spots; it was a golden white, and its hind legs crammed into the shell. I thought who would do such a thing to such a tiny animal. Then I noticed there were two other unhatched eggs, the three of them packed into makeshift nest cradled into the tall grass at the base of the tree. Some creature had made the nest but seemed to have abandoned it. I knelt down and picked up the kitten. Gingerly, I removed the shell from its hind and cradled the small creature. The mewling ceased, and it purred in my arms, nuzzling in the corner of my elbow. It had definitely come from the egg, I was certain of this because mucus clung thickly to its pallid fur. Nevertheless, how could a cat come from an egg? Even at my age, I knew mammals birthed live young, not like birds who propagate with hard-shelled eggs, so there was something fundamentally wrong with what I was experiencing. As

these thoughts raced through my mind, the trees rustled overhead, their branches drooping all around me, the wind picked up. The branches of the gnarled tree surrounded me and the dream ended. I woke and sat up in my bed. I was sweating profusely. My heart was beating nervously in my chest. With the dream fresh in my brain, I hastily scribbled what details I could remember. A cat hatched from an egg. What was this? As I was finishing my written detail of the dream, a single word drifted through my head...

Boagaphish.

Boagaphish? What is a Boagaphish? It sounded nonsensical and impugnant but I knew Boagaphish was the name of the small, strange creature that hatched from the egg I had cradled in my arm. I could still feel the sensation of wetness from saliva of the cat on the inside of my elbow, which as I habitually brushed at, a jolt of electricity ran through my body causing me to shudder. I had experienced something profound, I thought, and although I did not understand and could not even conceive of how to understand it, I knew it represented something terribly important. Although I had misplaced the importance of the imagery for a number of years, I could not ever expunge it from my emotions or from my memory.

A Forgotten Memory

A radio played softly in the distance, two voices intertwined with the music under a heavy grey sky.

“What do you think ever happened to Don McLean?” He asked.

“I think he’s dead.” She smirked.

He walked over and turned the music down; he picked up a glass of iced tea on the stereo and continued. “What usually happens is they take too many drugs and end up working in a sandwich shop somewhere in the outskirts of a wilderness.”

“Yeah, I suppose,” she said looking between the thin curtains behind her and out to the ocean beyond.

“I really like this song,” he started singing along with the music.

“Great,” she said to the cold glass of the window as her eyes trailed to the quiet street below. She cracked the window open and let the rush of ocean air in. She smiled as it struck her face. “It’s a nice day out.”

“Yeah,” he rattled the ice in his glass. She turned from the window and faced him.

“Why did you come here?”

Kyle set his glass down on the floor and fidgeted with his nails; he twisted the dull gold ring on his finger eyeing her carefully. He walked to the window and peered out.

“The ocean always reminds me of you, reminds me of how it used to be.”

“But it’s not like that anymore.”

“No, it’s not.”

She got up and went to the kitchen, she stood in the doorway.

“This is a nice place, Maria, too bad we didn’t live here when we were married.”

“Kyle, if you don’t have anything to say to me, then please leave I have lots of things I need to do.” She walked into the kitchen.

“I saw him today,” he yelled to her.

“Who?”

“Gary.”

The sound of silverware falling to the floor echoed through the small apartment. She came out of the kitchen.

“Who?!”

“I spoke with Gary today.”

A loud car struggled on the street; she ran and looked out the window.

“He was over near Golden Gate Park, I met him and we talked.”

“You met him?...But we haven’t seen him since that night...”

“Yeah, I know, but I felt we owed him something.”

He went to the kitchen and to the refrigerator; he came back with a beer and sat in a ragged chair across from her. He took a deep drink of the beer. She continued to look out the window at the ocean; a thick haze covered the horizon which washed out the sun. Large, portly grey birds strutted along an oily beach.

“There were times when we were really happy,” he said to her back. “Times when we loved each other.”

She turned and glared at him. “I can’t believe you. You promised you wouldn’t ever speak with him again, lying bastard.”

“Hey, I’m sorry. Besides, it was almost nine years ago, let go of it.”

“No, I will not let go of it.”

He sighed loudly and finished off his beer, he reached into his shirt pocket and pulled out a crumpled photograph. She turned and sat on the couch. “What’s that?”

“He gave this to me, look at it.”

She unfolded the photo. It was one of her, Kyle, Gary and her friend Cindy. The four of them were standing in front of Gary’s red Buick, Gary had a twisted smile on his face and his arm around Cindy.

“It was all so long ago, I can’t believe he’s still around.”

“He surprised the hell out of me, I never thought I’d see him again.”

“But you did, why?”

He finished his beer and sat next to her. "I don't really want to talk about it now."

"You brought it up."

"Forget about it."

"You come over here and tell me about a man I haven't seen for the better part of nine years, telling me all about him and now you don't want to talk about it anymore?"

"That's right."

She closed her eyes and held herself. He got up and paced the room. He looked at a picture of him and Maria one summer at the Cliff House; he traced his finger around the edge of her face.

"I'm sorry...I didn't mean to remind you...it's just that, he's back."

She glared at him. "What do you mean, back?"

"He wants to see you...us."

A loud car went by on the street below. She jumped and looked out the window.

"Is he coming over here?"

"No. I agreed we'd meet him. At the Legion of Honor in Lincoln Park...about now."

She stood up. "You're telling me this now? When did you see him?"

"Last week."

"Dammit," she walked past him.

"I didn't know how to break it to you."

"Don't bother trying to protect me," she paced back and forth. "Are we going?"

Kyle fidgeted with his nails, digging some loose dirt from under them. She glared at him.

“Let’s go.”

She passed him and went into the bedroom. He looked again at the photograph of him and Maria. He ripped it from the wall and crumpled it in his hand.

She drove to the park; Kyle looked out the window at the sunless grey scenery as it went by, he tried not to think about the meeting with Gary. If there was one thing on his mind that he was not set on doing it was digging up the past, he kicked himself a few times forever mentioning Gary’s presence to her. He wanted to be away from what happened years ago, detached so that he might never think on it again—he wished this to be the last time he would ever see Gary.

She pulled the car into the parking lot behind an empty fountain; they got out and walked through the brisk air. He put his arm around her.

“Things will be okay. We can work it out.”

“Yeah.”

He released her and put his hands into his pockets. They waited sitting on the stairs in front of one of a pair of stone sphinxes, she gazed at him a couple of times, then turned herself away. He crossed his arms and stared off; in the distance a loud car struggled up the hill, Kyle quickly stood up hoping to catch a glimpse of the car on the road—maybe it was Gary in his brilliant red 1955 Buick Special hardtop—as the car rounded the blind curve, he relaxed and sat down.

“He’s changed, you know,” Kyle said to Maria and the sphinx behind her. “A lot different than he was.”

“I’m sure...”

He had the sudden urge to smoke but had no cigarettes. He had the urge to leave, but had no means from which to go.

"It doesn't look like he's going to show, maybe we could get something to eat."

"I'm not hungry."

"Get something to drink?"

"I'm not thirsty."

"Go do something fun?"

"Knock it off," she half-smiled and Kyle felt ecstatic. He stood and pulled her up to him, she seemed content to be with him, he thought, her brown hair dangling in front of her green eyes made him feel closer to her than he had in years; he wanted the feeling to last as long as it could.

A loud car came up the hill; Maria looked at him, his expression faded as the sound increased.

An oxidized red Buick rounded the turn and stopped; the exhaust was loud and trails of bluish grey smoke billowed out from under it. The passenger door was thrust open, Gary leaned out.

"Get in."

Maria got in first. As Kyle shut the door he was immediately assaulted with an odor he could not stand. It was the smell of death, decaying flesh, he thought, and although he had never smelled it before, he imagined that this was what it would smell like. He wrinkled his face and rolled down the window.

"Rock and roll."

Gary let the brake out and screeched the tires taking a corner with great speed. A long silence passed; Maria squirmed on the rotted upholstery and Kyle held close to the open window. It was then, unlike before when he saw him in the park, that he noticed

Gary's incredible thinness, he seemed to have wasted away even more.

"You look very nice, Maria. You've been keeping yourself all these years."

"Ten years." Kyle said.

"Why'd you come here?"

A signal ahead changed to red, he put the accelerator down and ran the light in a flood of beeping horns. "I reached the age when I realized, hey, I haven't been keeping in touch with my friends. When I heard you and Kyle here got married, I figured I'd come and congratulate you personally."

"And you waited this long?"

Gary ran his fingers through his thin silver hair. "Yeah, I waited this long."

"We're separated now..."

"Imagine that. Funny how life is sometimes."

He turned the Buick onto the Great Highway which ran along the Pacific coastline, the traffic was light. Maria looked at the car, the memories of her youth were still evident in the pallid fabric of the back seat, she felt sad, the weight bearing hard on her heart.

"I know you guys think I'm crazy for coming back after all these years but..." He pressed the accelerator, the engine roared. Kyle noticed the increasing speed.

"Where are we going?"

"I don't know, I thought we could ride around until we settled things."

"What things?"

"Well, Cindy...for one..." He glared and evilly smiled at Maria.

"What do you mean, Cindy?"

“I mean Cindy.”

A brilliant red Buick was screaming through the turns on a highway that snaked its way from San Mateo on its way to San Francisco, Gary had the gas pedal to the floor and his three passengers gazed anxiously out the window. A thin, dark-haired with traces of silver, Gary pulled the wheel in and out of the coastal highway turns. He tightened his grip. Maria was sitting next to him—Kyle and Cindy in the back, all the windows were down and a chilled late summer breeze whisked through the car. Seventeen year-old Kyle straightened himself and leaned over the front seat.

“Where are we headed?”

Maria turned to face him and looked at Gary. “Where are we going?”

“The old armory by the ocean above Skyline.”

“Battery Davis? This time of night?” Kyle sat back in his seat.

“Unless you’re afraid,” Gary rasped.

“No, no, fine.”

Lights flooded the sandy landscape at a base of a hill, beyond it was dark. Gary got out and unlatched a gate that blocked a road. The Buick continued up the hill and around, it pulled and stopped inside; they parked on top of a half-buried base for a gun turret.

“Let’s go,” Gary jumped out and the others followed. He walked between some stout bushes and down a dune, the ocean roared in the distance. Kyle felt the salty mist of the night’s fog in his face, he swallowed hard and mimicked Gary’s steps. Cindy and Maria followed.

“Going down?” Gary turned on his flashlight and walked along the edge of a cliff that led straight down to a small beach and the

ocean. “Now nobody slip, it’s about five hundred or so meters down.”

They followed. Kyle found himself wondering where Gary was taking them but was afraid to ask. He felt that he knew what he was doing.

“Hey, slow down!” Cindy yelled. She slipped but regained her balance with Maria’s help, a cascade of sand crashed on the beach below.

“Watch yourself,” Gary yelled from some distance. It was dark and Gary’s flashlight was far away, there was no moon and a heavy fog surrounded, it was hard to discern where the exact footfalls should be. Cindy tried to keep up but her dress wouldn’t let her. Sand was filling her shoes.

A light bobbed along and turned away from the cliff back towards the armory, three followed the light; a shoe was lost and dangled off the edge of the cliff hanging onto a small plant growing out of the side of the sand.

“Wait up,” Cindy called out and reached for her shoe, her fingers barely touched it, she had to stretch herself out over the edge. She stood and put the shoe to her heel, she balanced on one leg.

Three figured entered the old armory, the light did little to cut the pitch blackness of the chambers. Gary smiled.

“My plan is to...”

Screams echoed throughout the armory. Kyle ran to the cliffs, he heard something heavy strike the side of the cliff and come to rest at the bottom.

“Cindy! Cindy!”

Kyle hit his head against the window of the car, Maria looked at Gary, his knuckles were white on the red wheel; he was biting his

lip, blood trickled down his chin. She tugged at the fabric of the seat. Kyle slammed his head on the glass almost breaking it, he sat back.

“So, what are we going to do?”

“You think of something, Kyle, my man.”

“Why the hell didn’t we go back and try to find her? Instead, we relied on you to take care of things.”

“Her neck was broken, already dead when I found her later on. Yeah, I took care of things, because you guys couldn’t.”

She glared at him. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

“Just what it means, you guys never gave a damn about Cindy or me, you weren’t concerned at all, you just forgot about it and went on with your lives while I did all the work. I saved both your asses!”

“Gary...” Kyle leaned over.

“I took care of her, yes I did, took care of things real good, kept her death a secret and all (I made up a great story) everybody bought it...now it’s time for us to repay you, for all your wonderful help these last years.”

“But...but...”

“No need for thanks. I know you wouldn’t mean it anyway. It was such a good plan, having me take care of her body and vanish, I did it so well, never saw me again,” he glared at Maria. “And I thought we were in love, kid. Nope, should’ve known, do somebody a grand favor and they screw you over.”

“It was your idea,” Maria pleaded, “to bury her and all, concoct the story say she packed up and ran away from her family, great, you did all that. We had nothing to do with it!”

“I never got a damn thing from either of you, goes to show your true loyalty to your friends.” He pulled the Buick hard around a corner. “Now you must know the truth, you must go see her.”

“What?” Maria screeched. “Are you fucking crazy? Where are we going to see her?”

“She’s up at the armory, I buried her there.”

Kyle and Maria looked at each other. “Christ.”

“I know it’s hard to accept but we know we killed her and I guess you got over it pretty quick but I never did.” Gary laughed to himself.

“It was an accident.” Kyle whined.

“You should’ve seen her,” he laughed harder. “Lying there, it was hysterical, her body all mangled and all...I never reported it, did you?”

He glared at her. She looked to Kyle and to the seat.

“Didn’t think so.”

Gary focused his eyes on the hood of the car, slowed down and turned up a small service road that led up a hill, the ocean crashed in the distance. A bar blocked the road, Gary got out.

“Now, don’t either of you go anywhere.”

He went to the trunk and brought out a large pair of cutters, Kyle and Maria heard him laughing and a strange giggling that echoed his laughs. She tried listening harder, he shut the trunk. He snipped the chain of the lock and opened the gate; he threw the cutters in the bushes and got back in the car. Maria half-smiled at him. He eased the Buick up the hill. Kyle stared wide-eyed out the windshield.

“She’s here?”

“Yep, all these years.”

“My God.” Maria pressed her hands to her face. Kyle swallowed hard. Gary brought the car around the hill and stopped at the entrance, he smiled a thin smile and parked the car on the turret. He bounded out and opened the passenger door. He motioned for them to get out.

“Last stop.” He pulled a flashlight and a shovel out of the back seat. “Move,” he pointed at the opening; Kyle and Maria walked slowly towards it. He flicked on the flashlight and followed them.

“She’s here, everywhere.” They continued walking and were enveloped by the darkness. “You should have been here, that night, when I carried her lifeless body down this corridor to the third chamber on the left. She was so young, so innocent, she didn’t deserve to die, you did.” He pointed the light at Maria’s face. “You, you’ve killed everything. Anything that came within your sights you slaughtered. You killed Cindy, you killed me, and you killed our unborn child.”

She sobbed as she walked.

“Do you still think about it? Dream about it? Does Kyle know about it?” He glared at him. “Well, do you, man?”

Kyle shook his head.

“Fucked over everything. That poor poor child, he would be about nine or so now, reading, playing, laughing...instead his broken body lay in the bottom of a trash bag hauled out as garbage, not even knowing what it would be like to do the simple things you and I do.” He smiled at Kyle.

“So what’s your story? Been trying to get into her pants since that night? Ever get any? Oh, excuse me, you guys were married. Oh, yes...tell me Kyle my boy, was it worth it? Did it feel good? Did she make you..?”

“Shut up!” She screamed at the top of her voice. “Shut up, shut up, shut up!!!” She turned to strike him but he caught her.

“No, no, no, wrong move.” He clenched his fist and hit her in the middle of the face, she fell to the ground. Kyle moved towards him.

“Okay, boy, you want to make something out of this? C’mon.” He threw the shovel against the wall and set the flashlight at his feet; the beam shone on their wrestling figures. Maria scooted back as the two men fought, she sat against the wall and wrapped herself in her arms rocking back and forth. Kyle was knocked to the ground and kicked at Gary’s ankle, there was a sharp snap and he fell. Kyle scrambled up. Gary winced and rolled on his back.

“What the hell?” He gazed down at Gary.

“I’m going to get you, my boy.” He tried to get up. A scream echoed through the length of the dark corridor, it was a scream that was very familiar to Kyle, it was Cindy’s scream. Kyle quivered with fear. Gary managed himself up and lunged at Kyle. The scream sounded again, Kyle threw Gary back and kicked him in the ribs, they cracked under the force.

“Cindy! Help!” Gary yelled down the corridor. Kyle looked back, a shuffling of feet echoed in the distance and they grew louder with every step. He picked up Maria and pulled her towards the exit away from the sound.

“Move!”

As they reached the car, they heard Gary moaning and laughing; echoes of Cindy’s voice rang in their ears. Kyle saw the key dangling in the ignition of the Buick; he thrust open the door and they slipped behind the wheel. Maria rolled down the window and peered down the tunnel. She saw Gary stumbling out. He was pointing at them.

“Get...get ’em!”

Kyle turned the key and the car rumbled to life. It spit as he threw it into reverse and gunned it. He backed out to the road. He veered off the pavement and lodged the Buick in a hill of sand, the trunk flew open. He looked down the road, put the car into drive and floored the accelerator—the wheels spun and the Buick refused to move. Gary was limping down the hill towards them, he was dragging his leg and his arm was wrapped about him, he reached out for them. Maria cupped her hand over her mouth.

“Oh my God!”

Kyle rocked the car and found traction, they took off; Gary stepped in front of them. The Buick clipped him with one of the large bumper bullets, his body sickly twisted around and fell into the sand, his silver hair blew in the chilled night wind.

Kyle slammed on the brakes and the trunk lid flew open. Maria gaped at him.

“What are you doing?!”

“He might be hurt. We...”

“Go! Go!”

He pressed the pedal and the lid slammed closed. Kyle turned the car hard onto the highway. He gunned it and sped as fast as he could towards the city.

A sign announcing the entrance into San Francisco went by in a blur. Maria curled up near the door.

“I can’t believe he still has this car, after all that happened.”

“Well, now we have it.” His eyes were frozen to the road.

A car passed almost hitting them. Kyle lost control but managed the car back onto the highway swerving viciously several times. A dull thump was heard in the trunk. Maria and Kyle stared at

each other, neither breathing, Maria stared out the back window. Another thump. It sounded as if someone was pounding on the lid.

“Kyle.....Maria.....?” It was Cindy’s voice. “Let me out!”

Kyle screamed and the car swerved. Back and forth across the surface of the road. He almost hit another car, swerved and drove towards a light pole. He tried to turn the wheel but it wouldn’t budge; he slammed the brakes and hit the pole with the right front of the car. The fender folded and the hood was pushed over. A blood soaked chrome bullet from the bumper rolled down the embankment.

Time passed, he didn’t know how much. Maria lay still in the seat, shards of glass glistened on her body. He sat up and adjusted the skewed rear view mirror, he couldn’t see behind him, the trunk lid was open. He lightly smiled and helped Maria out. They walked, the still cold air enwrapped their huddled trembling bodies and chilled them to their souls. Kyle’s teeth chattered as he walked, carrying Maria’s unconscious body; he looked to the sky, the chill seemed to move almost on its own with some kind of purpose. It struck at his spine, moved up his back to his neck where it paused momentarily. Then, without any presage, the chill enwrapped his head—his hair froze.

Things went black for a while, how long he did not know, but as he opened his eyes and gazed at Maria, he knew he was never going to see her the same again.

He awoke next to her; in her apartment by the ocean. A window was open and a cold wind was ripping through the place. He kissed her shoulder, her skin was cold; he climbed out of bed and stared down at her. The smell of rotting upholstery hung in the air.

“You and your goddamned past, all you ever cared about was yourself, you were the only one, I might as well have never lived.”

Her body lay twisted.

“You don’t believe, you never have! I know! Never believed in me, that maybe I could do something important on my own.”

He yelled. “I have!” He knelt and violently shook the bed. Maria’s head fell lazily towards him, her body remained stationary, a small pool of blood began flowing from the back of her neck.

“Just like Cindy...” he whispered.

He breathed deeply, put on his coat and walked outside. As he crossed the street her phone rang, he looked back once. He got into the oxidized red 1955 Buick Special; a small comforting voice whispered in his ear. He turned the key, the sound of the rotted exhaust pulsated off the buildings.

Absolution

If I could just get away from them, then I would be okay. And it isn't as if I haven't tried. I've sent them to my friends, people I don't like, and to anybody who I felt deserved them. I even tried selling them—at garage sales and pawn shops—but no one would take them. One guy at *The Divine Head* seemed interested, but when I came back to make the deal, no one knew where I could find him. So, I'm stuck with them and they are stuck with me. But I haven't given up. In fact, last night with the help of my friend Dana, I sent them away to the other side of the universe—to Marduk, she said—but I don't think it worked.

They're very feisty, the demons. There are nine in all. Four are pretty quiet, I don't have much of a problem with them. Three are always asking me if I'm okay, did I have a good day at the office, how am I feeling and all that. But it's the last two that cause me the most trouble. They're always hanging around me, it doesn't matter if I'm awake or asleep. They flush the toilet when I'm in the shower, they make the lights flicker when I have guests over, and they cause my car to stall if I happen to go out with my girl. I

find them irritating, the worst thing that could ever happen to a person. Once, at the office, the most annoying one, Azag, changed the radio station on my boss' desk. When he came in, he glared at me, I felt his stare on the back of my neck, and I was surprised he didn't ask me why I had changed it. But seeing I was practically hiding under my desk, asking me must've seemed stupid. Besides, if he had asked me, I don't know what I would have told him. But whatever it would've been, it wouldn't have been the truth.

I wish I could be away from them, I wish I could wish them away. Then things would be okay, I know it. But Dana promised they're on Marduk, the 10th planet on the far side of Pluto, she said. So, I'm hoping she's right. She should be, she's done readings for my brother-in-law and he says she's right on the mark, so I know she's good at what she does. The only thing I have to remember to do is to keep wishing them all away and make sure the nine statuettes—effigies—stay tucked away in a birdcage hanging in the attic. And I can do that, that's easy.

Every night when I get home from work, I pull down the ladder from the ceiling in the hall, climb up, and check on them. And every night they remain in their cage. And lately, for the past two or three nights, I've been able to get a good night's sleep and go to work fresh. My boss told me yesterday he's noticed an improvement in my performance on the job. He also told me that profits are finally going up seeing that they've been going down since I started working there. And I'm happy, I'm proud of myself that I've finally got this thing beat, that those demons are finally gone.

Patricia came by last night. She's my girl. We met one Sunday, in church. I asked her out to breakfast after mass and we've been going out ever since. She's real nice to me. Anyway, we watched

TV and ate popcorn. She even said that she noticed I was in a good mood. I remember smiling a lot and that's something I never used to do since I always was thinking about the demons. I put my arm around her and kissed her many times. I felt good about us, that's why I kissed her, because before I thought we were going to break up after only three months. But that's all changed now.

I asked Dana if I could tell the story of how I got the demons. She said it shouldn't cause too much trouble talking a little about them. She knows I feel better when I write these things down. I want to tell Patricia, but not yet. I need to figure it out for myself first.

I was thirteen when I first remember them being around. I went to a summer bible camp with our church; actually, I think it was with my friend's church and he was a Seventh Day Adventist. One afternoon, about two days into the stay, Jason and I sat in the chapel praying and the priest told us we need to make a lifelong commitment to Jesus. I remember feeling uneasy since in my church Jesus, God, and the Holy Spirit were already in me. I didn't know if I should take the oath. But Jason pressured me. Soon, all the kids on the pew were urging me to save my soul. The priest talked us into a frenzy and after kneeling, we stood with our arms in the air. I felt warm all over and felt perfectly at ease speaking the oath softly to myself. I felt as if my soul were wrapped in a warm blanket. Jason said that it was the love of Christ, that he was happy that I had accepted him into my life and was reborn in him.

I slept well that night, much better than at home. I don't remember if I dreamed or not, but I must have and must've dreamed so hard, I rolled in my sleep because the next morning, my left eye was swollen shut. There was no bruise, my eye just felt lazy. As I

looked in the mirror and tugged at my eyelid, I faintly saw small, dark, chiseled figures dancing behind me. I thought I still might be asleep since it was early morning (faint bluish light lit the bunks where the other kids slept) and since everybody else was asleep, it seemed I could have been right. But that morning, later that day (my eye opened in the afternoon, no one said anything about it), and ever since, when I stretch open my left eye, I see the demons dancing.

Their dances are erratic, I think that's what Dana called it. They danced without music, with themselves, and without rhythm. Dana says their dancing is playful, that they are celebrating, but what they possibly could be celebrating, I don't know. They never did include me, but now I suppose they only danced when I was happy.

Later, when I got an 'A' on a test, or cleaned the garage for my patents, or did well at my jobs, they would dance the same dance. For a while, I used to like to watch them dance—it was pretty harmless and all—but when I turned 20, they started doing other things.

If I ever got upset or mad, one or two would go after the person who made me mad. Dana says that kind of thing starts when the person wishes for it to happen like that. But I don't remember wishing like that. One day at the junior college, Jason started talking about his church. He said I should convert to his faith since I had already taken the oath. We had had this kind of talk many times, but always I told him I would do no such thing, but that day something was bothering me. I don't know what it was. Anyway, I said no and he got mad, which was strange for him. I'd seen Jason get mad, but not really at me. He said I was slapping his face for

not completely converting. And when I told him I didn't want to take the oath in the first place and was forced into it, he said,

"But you took the oath. You have to live up to your word."

I started walking away from him telling him no again and again. He followed me and grabbed my arm and that's when I saw the demons out of the corner of my left eye coming at him. I shut my eyes not knowing what might happen. Soon, Jason was shaking me, telling me not to be so stupid and when I opened my eyes, they were gone and Jason's hand still held my arm. Nothing had happened, except that I felt funny. That warm blanket around my soul felt like it had fingers in it. They pressed into me so hard I felt as if I couldn't breathe. I pulled myself away from Jason and ran to my car and drove home.

A couple of days later, I heard that Jason had broken his arm. What was odd about it was that I vaguely remembered just before I closed my eyes, them jumping and biting into the arm that was later broken. I went to Jason's house and told him what I saw that day. Even with his arm slung in front of him, he tried to punch me.

"The devil has gotten you! If only you had followed through with your oath! God has punished you, God has forsaken you! You're at the mercy of the devil!"

That happened almost fifteen years ago. We haven't spoken since.

I didn't believe that stuff Jason told me. Not a word of it. The demons were not the devil's work. Maybe they were annoying and hurtful and caused me a lot of trouble, but they were definitely *not* evil! Even on this, Dana agrees with me! Maybe they came out of me when I was at camp that summer, when I was forced into believing something I didn't want to. They were only protecting

me. Sometimes I think that they were created by God himself as my guardian angels. People in my church say they've seen guardian angels, but I don't think they have. They talk like the angels are white and fluffy, with feathery wings and long, flowing gowns—like pajamas. But if I were an evil spirit out to get someone and I saw those angels, I would laugh at them and mock their singing and praying. Now my demons, they are very scary. They drive away evil spirits before they have the chance to get near me. Now my demons, I would be afraid of and I would stay as far away from them as possible. Especially when Azag growls his deep growl and bears his teeth. Sometimes you can see him drooling as he's waiting to pounce on the spirit. Nothing ever happened to me as long as Azag was around. Bullies would try to pick on me, my bosses would try to intimidate me, but they would soon stop because Azag was ready to tear them up. All I had to do was let go of the leash and tell him to "sick 'em". Nothing would ever happen to me. Not nothing. Ever.

* * * * *

Dana says I've been thinking too much about the demons. And maybe I have. It's been almost two weeks since they've been gone—Dana had cast a good spell—and I'm wondering how they're doing on Marduk. I imagine that planet, four times the size of Jupiter, cold and blue and grey with many barren mountains and valleys and caves—my demons hiding in one from the cold, huddled together. They are shivering and wailing. Four figure I don't need them anymore, three wonder why, and the two are out for revenge—especially Azag. I see him in my dreams, he talks to me and tells me he can't wait to sink his teeth into me. Then he growls fiercely and *I* shiver. Maybe I shouldn't have sent them away. I'm starting

to regret what I have done, I'm starting to feel guilty. They didn't do anything really wrong. It's my fault. I should have been more patient with their playing. They meant no harm to me. They were only trying to protect me, to make me happy. And I had Dana send them away! I should be in the cave, cold and hungry and lonely and abandoned! But Dana say there isn't much I can do so I might as well stop thinking about them. She says doing that only makes matters worse, it only complicates the spell. I asked her one day, if I wanted them back, if I could reverse the spell. She said I shouldn't even consider backing out. Who knew what the consequences would be? As the days and weeks passed, as Patricia and I grew closer and closer, as my job got more and more tedious, and seeing that people at work were really starting to pick on me, I thought of them more and more, but was afraid to take the big step—to wish them back. To want old Azag in my lap as I sat in front of the TV. I want to stroke his stiff, rough-hewn fur and feel his cold, wet nose in my ear. I want it all back. I want them back. Dana has tried to make me change my mind—she's even tried scaring me by saying my whole life would come undone—but I don't believe her, just as I don't believe Jason. Just as I don't believe in anyone or anything anymore.

I dreamt of Marduk last night. The nine demons cornered me in a shallow ravine, the crystalline rock formations blocking me at every turn. Azag lunged at me and held onto me on the back of my head. He dug his sharp claws deep into my shoulders, staining my shirt thick with blood. He stuck his nose in my ear, it was iron-hot.

“Breathe the air, taste the dust, look for the sun amidst the putrid bluish light. Live as we have, as you have forced us to, an

eternity in this wasteland. Feel the wind clawing at your back, freezing your body to the quick.”

The other eight grabbed different parts of me, digging in as Azag was. I screamed.

“Yes, my friend. I will have my revenge. *I am coming back with you.*”

Azag pushed his nose further into my ear. Soon I felt him in my brain. And then in my mind.

I awoke screaming. My fingernails dug deeply into the sides of my head.

It wasn’t until late afternoon when I shook off the dream. It had taken so long to do so because after calming down and going to the bathroom, I noticed in the mirror that my left eye was lazy. Immediately, I heard a soft voice,

“As you are, as I am. As you become, I already have.”

* * * * *

I was glad it was Saturday. I was lucky I hadn’t been called into work to catch up on paperwork. I spent most of the day pacing through the house, the yard, and the garage. I must’ve passed the attic ladder at least thirty times. And each time, I thought to go up there and check on the effigies in the cage. I had to hope the dream was just a dream and that nothing was going to come of it. But, as Dana had warned, if even one of the effigies is out of its cage, then big problems are sure to follow. I told her I had no intention of removing them, but she cautioned that they can jump out of the cage all by themselves—if I wish them to. And Dana seems to think I have wished and wanted too hard for the demons’ return. She said I have moved from possibility to probability. There was nothing I

could do to reverse the process. All I could hope for was that the probability wouldn't move from low to high.

Most of the day was quiet and later on I had forgotten about the effigies. But, after I had finished my dinner, I had the burning urge to check on them. Enough though—action. I yanked the ladder down and scrambled up. I fumbled for the light and snapped it on. Moving as quickly as I could toward the cage, I stumbled, nearly putting my foot between beams through the sheet rock which was my ceiling downstairs. Regaining myself, I lunged for the cage. Grabbing it with both hands and desperately peering into it, I counted: One, two, four, five, seven, eight...eight. Eight? I counted again pointing at each as I rattled its number off. Eight. How did one get out? The cage door was still securely fastened. I searched the area under it, finding it nestled in a heap of fiberglass insulation. It was Azag. I knew it. It was just a feeling, but the closer I looked at the figure, the more strange it appeared. Each figurine looked exactly the same as the others, stamped out of a mold—Azag felt heavy. And warm like he had been lying in the sun. I brought it to the light and noticed a detail that sent an electric chill down my back. The left eye was lazy.

The phone rang. I had to answer it, it was Dana. If anybody could get me out of this mess, she could. I got out of the attic as fast as I could. The phone was on its ninth ring when I picked it up.

"Dana?"

"You're demons are coming."

"Only one, Azag."

"No, they're all coming back. Not just your nine, but all the other demons that have been cast out, tossed like flotsam when people grew tired of their antics."

“They’re far away, on Marduk, you promised. They can’t come back.”

I felt a sharp pain in my temple.

“I don’t know how. But you did it.”

I frantically rubbed my head. Someone or something was jabbing the inside of my head with a sharp stick. “How many?”

“Thousands and thousands.”

A voice spoke for me. “That’s all I needed to know.”

With that, I felt Azag leave me. The line was dead. In the minutes that came after, I don’t know what happened. All I knew was that I had a phone in my hand and nobody was there to talk to me.

“Hello? Hello? Is there anybody there?”

I heard someone breathing. They were moaning, too. I hung up quickly, yanking my hand away from the receiver.

* * * * *

I knew something was wrong when I found in my pocket, one of the figurines from the cage in the attic. I knew it was supposed to be up there, Dana had put it there and I was told it had to stay in the cage or else something bad would happen. I got scared. I wanted to go up to the attic and check on the figurines and to put the one in my pocket back. How did it get out? I stood below the ladder in the hall. I couldn’t bring myself to go up and check. The statuette stayed in my pocket.

I slept pretty good and got up in time to get myself dressed and go to church. Father Frente told us about Armageddon. He said that we were all doomed unless we confessed all our sins and were truly repentant. I knew I was. I was happy with myself, my job,

and with the people around me whom I loved. And I was happy with my soul.

There was a breakfast after mass and I sat across from Father Frente. He kept on looking harshly at me as if he was thinking I had done something bad and hadn't confessed it. I didn't like being looked at that way. I wished I had Azag to protect me. I reached into my pocket and held the figurine.

"Things will be okay. If I can just get away from him, then I will be okay."

I gripped the statuette tighter. I closed my eyes. In the dark, I saw Dana at her table with her cards spread out before her. She turned over one after another. She was talking, but I couldn't hear her. I leaned closer to her.

Her eyes were hollow, vacant. I could smell the scent of burning hair. Camphor candles surrounded her; a short, fat one was behind her head which gave her a golden aura—like the Virgin Mary in the pictures on the walls around the altar at church. Her mouth moved again.

"We are all doomed," she turned over the cards in succession. "Confess your sins. Be truly repentant. Then you must provide a sacrifice to prove your loyalty."

She sat still—motionless. Suddenly, I was yanked back into the dark. I opened my eyes slowly. Father Frente was staring at me.

"Is there something troubling you, my son?"

"No, Father."

"I can tell you have something on your mind. Something which is so bad, it's hurting you to be let out. You wish to confess?"

. . . Confess your sins. . . Be truly repentant. . .

"Yes, Father."

“Come with me, my son.”

He led me to the place where I usually made my confession. He led me in one door. As I knelt, he drew back the screen.

“Bless me, Father, for I have sinned. My last confession was two weeks ago.”

“Yes, my son. I missed you last week.”

“I didn’t keep my house clean and I didn’t help my parents with the yard-work like I promised. Also, I coveted another person’s things.” I reached for the statuette in my pocket. “I coveted their power.” I rubbed the figure harder, stroking the rough-hewn, pewter fur on its head. “I coveted their vision. I used them.”

Father Frente gasped. I saw him cover his mouth with his hand as if to mask his contrived astonishment. “My son, these are mortal sins. They might not have gotten so bad if you had confessed last week. But as it is. . .”

The figurine was warm in my hand. “I don’t much want to hear it right now. I don’t want to hear you spew your pseudo-religious banter. You always patronized me.”

“I can see you’re quite distraught, my son. You must be penitent before I can absolve your sins before God.”

The demon in my pocket grew in size. It was iron-hot—pulsing.

“You ever think much about Armageddon, Father? You ever truly believe it’s really going to happen when you preach to us? You ever think how you will be judged?”

“I can’t do anything for you.” He got up to leave.

“Well, it’s going to happen. You too. The destruction will fall more on your shoulders than anyone else’s because you have not received true absolution. Let me enlighten you toward things unseen and unknown and undone. It’s awe-inspiring.”

Azag jumped out of my pocket. He knelt before me, growing in size and bearing his teeth—drool flowing out of the corners of his mouth. As he tore through the confessional, I smiled proudly. The first sacrifice to prove my loyalty.

* * * * *

I find myself lying in bed; the sun is setting, casting long shadows against the walls. I can faintly recognize crouching demons—gargoyles; contorted, twisted, repulsive, chaise. People are terrified, I can feel it, the close of the millennia draws near. Their fevered pitch is a deafening decibel. It is the unknown, the uncertain, they fear—and it is this ancient fear that binds them tight. Wouldn't they feel as if they'd been duped if they ever realize those terrifying beasts that now invade their minds, were actually angels? White, fluffy with white, feathery wings. And don't forget those flowing effervescent gowns with their golden halos above their heads.

It would be the joke of the millennium if all this were a hoax, an irony perpetuated by one man who's powers exceed the bounds of what's expected in being human. I can't be blamed for what's happening, I only respond to my environment, draw in those powers others are only too afraid or too stupid to exploit. But isn't it a joke. Why? Because I believe in Armageddon, in the concept of Judgment Day. It has been drilled into me from day one. Repent, repent, confess, on your knees. Pay homage to the Lord else he will strike you dead. I hear the millions; no, tens of hundreds of thousands of millions begging for their lives, paying homage to whatever God they believe in—praying for their souls. Those who seem to be unaffected, those who will survive, those who will rise from the ruins of the society to rule are those who worship not the Christ figure. The vicious circle is complete—closure is at hand.

I lay my hand on Patricia, she is lying next to me. She wanted the comfort of a man—me—before the end came. She held fast to her beliefs, and died for them. To each his own. For myself, another sacrifice—yet this will go unnoticed. Hardly anyone will remember the one, Patricia or Father Frente, upon the realization that millions have perished.

I see my demons dancing on the floor at the foot of the bed. They seem content with their world. Actually, I'm surprised to see them back so soon. Azag tells me my four sacrifices expedited their journey: Dana, Father Frente, Patricia, and myself—that annoying part of me that couldn't wipe its own ass, much less patch things up around here after they go to hell. . .

Azag also tells me the other demons will be here within a couple months. I asked him how all of them were going to get here, I couldn't possibly make enough sacrifices to provide for their passage. He said that since they can't come back from Marduk, Marduk is coming here. I can hear Dana now, spewing her monotonous, pedantic bunk.

"You must stop the demons from accomplishing their goal. Marduk will destroy the Earth."

Granted, this passing of Marduk will be substantially more devastating than when it last passed through the system oh, say, 3,000 or so years ago. Floods, no big deal; we're talking continental upheaval, the crust fracturing, sending waves of water into places people never imagined it would be. The fate of New Atlantis sealed.

A small part of me wants me to get hold of myself and stop it before it's too late. I take one of the steak knives from the kitchen and thrust it steadily and firmly into its heart. Silence.

That part could never understand. It never knew the call of the demons, the thirst for change, the thirst for justice—nature reclaiming herself, washing the slate clean, starting fresh.

It's all for the best, you know. It's inevitable that people must die by the droves for them to understand. Humanity must evolve. Time to kill off the old so that the better may survive—Darwin and all that crap. Besides, you haven't considered that this Armageddon exists because their God demands it? Obviously, they're doomed. We all are. Even this God is. Marduk will cleanse the planet; much of nature, of humanity and all it has constructed and fabricated and raised in worship of itself—of trophies erected to celebrate man's conquest of man and nature, will be destroyed. And of God, well, he will be destroyed too. So will any and all vestiges.

The day draws near. I have buried myself within them. There isn't a doubt that I will be okay. I'll be fine. Just peachy.

Testimony of a Loved One

This place is ennobled with pith and despair; I have found myself consumed by it. I hadn't been here long when I came to realize this, perhaps it has been the season of rains that has eroded my better self. Or maybe it was the pallid, disdainful looks on passersby that caused my mind to think of strange, odd pieces of philosophy and reason. Whatever had happened, I had come to a point in my life that things were starting to change.

Nothing could quell the sinking of my nature, not even writing which had always helped me to cleanse my thoughts. I was in a different place at an indifferent time in the world, there was no place for thought or expression, just an acrid sense of slipping away amongst the tourists and permanent population. I could have put myself on high and held comfort in the notion that I was somehow above it all, but this in itself only contributed to my falling away.

In the decade before, I had been a fan of planning my life, it took me ten years to realize what I wanted to do with my career and even now as I am carrying out this task, it seems more trite as each day passes. How has the world at the dawn of the 21st

Century used knowledge like the one I espouse? All bombs and wars on philosophies. There is no middle ground, only a balance between extremes.

I have always fancied myself as a writer; in the times between short stories and novellas, I have found myself miserable for having not done enough to contribute to the world. So, I shifted my focus to science, physics primarily, and for a time it filled the void with equations and interesting problems for my mind to solve. The solutions I devised didn't necessarily agree with the repose of the intellectual foundation and I quickly found myself a pariah in my own culture. I published several papers on my results but they have been largely ignored by the annuals. I do not bear any malice regarding my fate but find myself wondering my place and position here. I realize I know something profound, something that could alter the very nature of space and time but I dare not construct the machine. I had built a prototype once and it did exactly as I had predicted but the consequences I dare not publish; it's enough to be ignored but quite another to be considered a hack—venturing from a point of no return back to reality is something quite impossible. So I have been careful with my methodology and pointed with my words. Nevertheless, I still cannot shake the ennui that is slowly engulfing me.

I arrived in Europe about two years ago. I began with a stay in Paris for half a year and eventually wandered to the east. Since that time, I have lived in Amsterdam, Minsk, Kiev, Vilnius, Budapest, and Moravia before finding myself in Prague. The premise for these journeys was that I was looking for a suitable graduate school to undertake my Doctorate in Physics. But I wasn't really looking for a school, I was looking for a new home. I feel as if I have been

rejected by my people and my culture—perhaps this isn't exactly true. When I think about it, I think that I don't want to have my work being used in the systematic killing of wide swaths of peoples I would never get to know. My work should try to rise above the putrid wars and if not offer a solution or alternative, then force the change on the global society by proxy. I don't feel that it is my place to perform such a feat, but can feel it in the small spaces of time where it slowly drives me crazy.

The only pleasing times in my life are when I dream. It is in dreams that I get the sense of my position relative to my work and desire; it is also the place where my subconscious tries to make sense of the waking world. Sometimes dreams protrude in this way. Sometimes they show me what direction to take and less often what decisions to make. I have been thinking about one in particular.

I am standing in a circle of men. They are wearing snappy, pressed uniforms of tan ribboned with green; beyond them I can see the darkening room become smaller, the walls pulling in until they stop just beyond the circle. This action is followed by an eerie scraping noise carrying an enormous mass. The room shakes. As my eyes return to the men, I notice all but one are wearing hoods with blindfolds stitched in them. The hoods, green in color and striped in a solid white band, fit just on the crown of the skull and the blindfolds are made from small pieces of grey fabric fitting just over each eye. The unhooded man presents me with a small red velvet case,

“We want to present you this,” he begins slowly. “As a token of our appreciation.”

He places the case in my hand and I notice it is relatively heavy. Not really heavy but weighty as if something of compacted metal is

resting within. I start to open the case and as I look to the man, he is pulling the hood over his eyes. The case lid creaks as I try to fold it open and inside a crudely made medallion peeks out at me, gleaming greyly in the dim light of the now small room. I squint to read the inscription on the rough surface but can only make out '*kde je dale?*' (where is the way?). The medallion seems to get heavier in my hand and soon I am trying to hold it with both hands. The men stand motionless in the small, squat room; a loose piece of fabric is blowing in an invisible wind on the wall just behind the one facing to my front. Soon the case is too heavy to hold and I drop it on the floor. The medallion jumps out and shatters on the floor. A wind tears though the room and the walls blow back away from the circle. The men stay fixed, each facing in to me, motionless as the wind turns from breeze to gale. They are fixed, unmoving, able to neither see nor affect the world only I am participating in. The case is broken, its lid unhinged, the medallion in shards, the pieces now orbiting the circle of men, dragging across the floor in a sickening thump. I hear voices on the wind.

"Kde je dale, kde je nassim..?"

For a moment a source of light appears in the stretched darkness. It is one star, then another, then a bright one far off, then two very bright ones very near. Around the two bodies a series of five planets orbit. One of them is blue and has water on its surface. The scene focuses tightly on the planet and it has taken the place of the blindfolded man just before me. I see it is rather small, two moons and a debris field surrounding it. The debris field is made of the shards from the broken medallion, some objects still carry the writing but it is twisted, convoluted, unutterable. I quit the shards and look closely at the planet, it has continents and stone

cities and breathable air. If I squinted, I could see large movements of population across its surface. But I can't see it that well, it is pulling away from me and the wind is dying down, the room is becoming dark and the men are disappearing into the fabric of space where the planetary system resides. The walls are returning to their first position and I feel as if I'm about to wake...

The world is black and black, a vast uncharted landscape devoid of light or objects. I can feel its oiliness over my skin and the smell of putrid diesel in my nose. There is a feeble green light emanating from some unknown source; it is flashing as regular as a ticking clock. My emotions are calm, as the still waters on the small planet. I am the source and the fruit of all labors. I am the architect staring at a blank piece of engineering paper, what I etch will stand for a thousand years. I am history and I am not exactly a piece of it; I flow between history and space and time. I am the ancient people who populate all the planets in the galaxy and I am no one. I am tangible and I am a wraith. The blackness is fading, the green light vanishing into some unseen horizon.

I am standing in a ruined flat in an unkempt part of town. Dust and debris, bits of concrete, plaster, and decay cling to the corners and lay out in large unbroken sheets across the floor. The room is empty save a small rickety table and a computer. I am at my laptop watching myself typing furiously at the keyboard. Torrents of letters, sentences, and paragraphs assault the screen. A swirl of smoke is rising from the top of my head, my hair is white and long and standing on end. I try to see what I am writing, to at least catch a glimpse of the title. My eyes strain to read the words, I believe they are in English but I cannot be certain.

Annals in Physics, The Glide-Stream of Space-Time and the Journey to its Far Reaches

What about the first sentence, can I read that? I must move closer to the screen. But I find that I cannot move closer, there is an invisible, almost magnetic force that is repulsing me from approaching. The force is coming from the other me at the computer.

“In times such as these, man must consider the what is beyond the limits of his science...what we know today is what was known two thousand years ago...we cannot escape our fate unless we look somewhere completely different...where is there new excitement that holds high promise...not here, not anywhere near here...but in the depths of space and time where our thoughts must inevitably coalesce with matter...the mind is the boundary dweller, the machine the bridge leaving this world commencing an era of discovery not dared dreamt before...this design I proffer exists beyond the limit of what is known to that which is unknown and unforeseen...beyond time is what awaits us...”

I am fairly close to myself now, I am pushing with all my might against the repulsive force. As if sensing my presence, I at the computer turn to look at myself. He smiles wryly and winks knowingly.

“If you only knew what I know, then you’d have something to worry about.”

But I am not me, he is somebody else. Me, yes, but a shade something different. He doesn’t even really look like me but I sense we are the same. Perhaps from a different time or a different set of circumstances, but nevertheless, we are identical. He stands staring at me.

“You know what the answer is, you have always known. Why must you not see it?”

“I have no idea what you are talking about,” I croak feebly.

“Don’t give me that. You have read my work and you have founded my work. Without you I could not have done what I’ve planned to do and what I’m going to do.”

The computer moans, its fan beating rhythmic, incomprehensible phrases.

“You have brought life where there once was none,” he continues while patting the computer which is now beginning a slow crescendo to a wail. “You have seen the future.”

The computer is wailing loudly now and is slowly assembling a tune from the random utterances. It is regular and systematic, organized. He smiles at me, his eyes a dark brown, almost black like the fabric of space but without pinpoints of light. I can feel the vastness behind his gaze.

“Look to the mirror and find the answer, my friend. And we’ll both be better for it.”

I quickly thrust my eyes open to the wail of the alarm. I must have forgotten to turn it off from the week before when I had a teaching job.

While traveling through Europe, I have filled my waking hours by performing research projects I feel test the limits of my intelligence and imagination. If, according to the Greeks, everything has been done there must be some interesting work in the small spaces in between. After a few weeks in Prague, a paper was nagging in my brain. I ignored the impulse and instead filled my time by hanging out by the river and in subterranean pubs in Vinohrady. But my neglect was to manifest revenge in the form of piercing headaches and I found that I had to write the paper.

Thoughts and Reflections of a Man Caught Between Himself and the World he has Created

Between the past and the future lies what is undone. Despite the obviousness of the statement, it remains, in terms of physics, that this is all that there is—there is no more. Time is the only vehicle of change. It is an inescapable conclusion that will be reached in any discussion. But what is time, this phenomenon we experience so linearly?

Einstein in the early 20th Century said that time was relative. In his paper on the Twin Paradox, he noted that the flow of time is dependent upon the point of view of the observer. In his argument, one twin sets out on a voyage into space at the speed of light. He travels a set distance, ten light-years out and ten light-years back. When the twin returns to Earth, he discovers that many centuries have passed and his twin has long perished. Minkowski, Einstein's professor, agreed with him and, as a consequence, was the first to devise the higher order of geometry necessary to understand the paradox. Greeted with great skepticism at the time, their contention relies on the premise that the observer is participating in the omnipresent flow of time upon a space-time manifold. Wigner, more specifically, speaks of a spatial-temporal manifold where time is a property of the system just as the spatial coordinates are. What if, for the sake of a tangible argument, the observer could remove himself temporarily from the manifold and freely extrapolate positions in space independent of time and in time independent of space? What if he could retain this theoretical removal from the manifold and manipulate its properties? How could such a thing be accomplished? In the paradigm of language this may be hard to devise. But conceptually it is not unreasonable to assume that a

machine could aid such a feat. It has been written in antiquity that Buddhist monks could remove themselves from time and see the future and visit the past. Now this distinction is interesting. They *see* the future and *visit* the past. Assuming there are no errors in translation, this means that the past is fixed and the future is not since it is dependent upon the past.

A scientist of recent fame in the late 20th Century named Samuel Uncler constructed a device called *The Cipher* which was reputed to remove a person from his temporal trappings allowing him to navigate time and space. He argued his machine was based on earlier archaeological evidence of other machines. The story goes something like this.

Around 1935, a team of archaeologists from Britain accidentally discovered a temple while exploring some ruins in Tunisia. The temple was relatively unremarkable and fit the time when it was constructed, about 2100BC. In one of the chambers deep inside the temple was a door embossed with a seal of the pharaoh, Markidu, warning the contents of the room should not be disturbed on his order, under penalty of execution. Breaking the seal and pulling back the large, stone door, an elongated room spread out before them. In the center of the room lay artifacts not from the time of Markidu's reign, save a scroll in situ. The scroll spoke that the artifacts were found in the lands to the North on a military conquest by an unnamed officer.

It was reported by one of the archaeologists, Arthur Johansen, that the artifacts were constructed out of a type of metal not known to the time and not known to current science. There were 40 polished rings—three 4 centimeters in diameter, fifteen 12 centimeters in diameter, and twenty-five between 14 and 16 centimeters in diameter,

graduated in scale. Also, there were six metallic tubes and a strange metallic sphere that flaked large sections off if scraped with a tool. It was noted that the sphere absorbed light and glowed brilliantly when brought in from exposure to bright sunlight into the dark chambers. There were three bands across the surface of the sphere as if it were mounted in the set of the smaller rings. Johansen made a drawing of what the machine might have looked like if it were to be reassembled.

Shortly after discovering the artifacts, the British military was called to the site and the contents of the chamber were taken to University College London for study by government scientists. Johansen's report was classified and the artifacts disappeared from sight. It was rumored they were shipped clandestinely a few years later to the University of California for further study. At the time the laboratory was working on the research related to the first atomic bomb, and was reputed to have the most modern equipment to study the metallic properties of the artifacts. A leaked memo dated 25 March 1938 noted that the metallic objects were crystalline in structure and could not have been naturally occurring. It was concluded it must have been synthesized and recommended that a query into the work the Nazi scientists should be considered. That if they had constructed the artifacts they could build weapons of great power. Shortly after the memo, or so the story goes, the artifacts were shipped to an undisclosed location and quietly buried.

Dr. Uncler found Johansen's report while rooting through the archives of the British Museum. He also found the 1938 memo on a fragment of microfiche. In 1990, he published a paper *Means of Travel in the Ancient Stellar World* where he detailed the ancient machine and what its theoretical purpose might have been. There

was no script reported on the artifacts but nevertheless argued that they comprised a machine that could create a pocket of independent, or in his words, null space-time where an individual or collection of individuals could use the pocket to move within the entirety of time and space. He said that such a machine would allow the traveler to travel in time or in space independently, but not both. He exemplified that the machine could be directed to open a pocket where the distance say between here in Prague and Cydonia Mensae on Mars would be only a few meters instead of 75 million kilometers. Alternately, a pocket could be opened at a single point, say again in Prague, to a point in the past of hundreds to thousands to millions of years before. He did not detail if the future could be navigated in such a fashion and I would expect that such a feat is truly impossible since there is no real point for the machine to resonate with. Uncler noted that there is logic and a formed higher geometry to the space-time manifold which defines specific properties. It is the higher geometric system that allows a series of differentiated metrics whose complexity increases with time. He argued that a lower complexity metric of sufficient order can be specifically identified where the traveler could determine where or when he wanted to go. He called this process ‘time dilation’, in that time is not truly manipulated but dilated, opened up and made passive upon the manifold. In late 1992, Dr. Uncler constructed a prototype *Cipher* that was tested at a laboratory on the campus of the University of California. Although I suspected the work was classified and not be able to glean much information, I had the unique opportunity to conduct a phone interview with one of his associates and reputed Cipher project manager, Dr. Steven Sanderson. Dr. Sanderson, although vague in his answers to my questions, detailed that Uncler had

conducted three unsuccessful tests and two successful tests with two unnamed colleagues. I asked him if he could provide any details about Uncler's Cipher but he passed over my request with 'Sorry, it's classified.' He directed me to Uncler's last publication regarding the machine; an article in the October 1993 issue of *Physics Today* from which the information for this article was obtained. There were few details about the machine itself, instead, the article framed Uncler's argument of a dynamic, controllable, space-time continuum. After this article, there is no further mention of Dr. Samuel Uncler except for critical reviews of said article where he is lambasted and ridiculed for his theories. Not even Carl Sagan would come to his rescue.

I searched the public records for Samuel Uncler to determine what may have happened to him. I performed this research on the new grid internet, a powerful version beyond the old internet of just a few years ago. I discovered he was born in Chicago in 1965, went to the University of Chicago where he got his undergraduate degree in Theoretical Physics in 1986. He then studied at University of California, where he received his doctorate in High-Energy Physics in 1991. He was last employed by the University from 1990 to 1993. There is no mention if he was transferred or fired or if he resigned his commission at the government facility. I had filed a request under the Freedom of Information Act for employment and assignment records but so far there is no word. I then turned my attention to marriage and death certificates. Apparently, Dr. Uncler was married in 1987 to Jenine Goddard and had a daughter, Emilia in 1988. He was divorced in 1990 and there is no record of another marriage. Also, there is no record of death. Dr. Uncler held a passport that was not renewed after its expiration in 2002.

Between the past and the future lies what is undone. As with the tenet of physics, this is all there is regarding Dr. Samuel Uncler. If it begins with the Greeks and the Roman conception of time and space, it seems to end with Uncler in the only recorded time dilation experiment. Did he create a pocket whereby a person could travel to the far reaches of space and time? What has happened to him these past fifteen years? Was he reassigned to a classified project and his identity erased in a cloak-and-dagger Cold War style coup? Did he successfully travel to a far point in space where I am the twin in Einstein's paradox waiting until old age for his return? Or did he perish in one of his experiments and his death not recorded because of the nature of his demise? Many questions but few answers. It remains for time to uncover these mysteries...

That's about as far as I have gotten with the paper. I had originally conceived of this paper while dining at Tartino's on Fisherman's Wharf in San Francisco some ten years earlier but never pursued it. I thought I had forgotten the work until very recently. I was riding on the tram during what was supposed to be the summer. Instead of hot, sunny days, I was greeted with cold and rain. In my lingering depression and finding myself staring at the scenery passing by, the paper ebbed back into my thoughts and soon I found I was becoming obsessed with finishing it. I immediately went home and started writing in earnest; I should have been teaching a private lesson with a client named Daniela but I quickly canceled it. If I go on like this, I won't have any money at all. But right at this moment it doesn't matter. Besides, it seems my client is looking for more than just English lessons and being recently divorced, I wasn't looking for a new relationship in this foreign land. There were too many answers to questions in contrasting languages.

It is a Wednesday like any other here, the city calls to me. In the deafening roar of silence, the past and the present mingle like two lovers recently estranged. I have the urge to wander the streets, to walk upon the same cobbles Goethe had and see myself as a twisted, post-modern Faust—sans tragedy. Today the sky is a deep grey, there is no distinction of clouds stretching to the horizon. Rain pummels the roofs of yawning buildings where the tourists take refuge and me, well, I stare blindly into the monochrome watercolor.

Of Something I Once Knew

Philip Easby religiously washes his car every Saturday afternoon. It is a habit he has dutifully performed for the past twenty-nine years—ever since he’s known the noble machine. The car once belonged to his father who had bought it new. Phil remembers the cloudy day when Maggie came to be with the family. His father was extremely particular about the kind of car he wanted to be seen in; he didn’t want a Cadillac, it would make him seem too rich and a Chevrolet or Chrysler was out of the question. He remembered his own father’s car, it was a fine Buick Roadmaster, it had wide running boards, glistening wood-spoke wheels and whitewall tires—the car a deep maroon—it was the epitome of class, wealth, and prestige. Perfect, the only way to describe the car for him!

Phil opened the garage, the car his father decided on was a Robin’s Egg Blue 1961 Buick Electra 225 sedan, chrome wire wheels, whitewall tires; a V-8 engine, four-barrel carburetor, automatic transmission, power steering, power brakes, air conditioning, power

windows, and power seat. Phil knew exactly what options were on the car, his father had ordered every conceivable one, including a tissue dispenser mounted under the center of the dash. Now the veteran Buick was his, it gleamed in the dim light of the garage just as it did on the showroom floor in 1960. Phil was very young then, he could barely touch the glistening chrome on the fender, and when he was finally able to do so, his father would slap his hand and wipe the smudge clean from it. Soon after, before he did anything else, his duty on the weekend was to wash Maggie, giving her a fresh waxing every spring. His father would often check on him and if had made a mistake, perhaps he would forget to vacuum the interior or wipe the vinyl dash or remove the streaks from the windshield, he would be punished by having to spend the time he had wasted by being so careless the next weekend.

He walked next to the car, careful not to rub against it, pulled down a folding chair, the kind with the straps of multi-colored plastic strands crisscrossing each other, and set it on the front lawn. He sat and stared, watching the people and the cars pass on his native Poplar Street. How life seemed to drift by him, the people moving as if they knew where they were going; it was supposed to relax him, seeing the world go by in a gentle whirl, but it only reminded him of his lethargy, of his inability to gain control over his life. In a wave of depression, anger and animosity, he found he hated the car not to mention the house he lived in; he also hated his dead parents. When they passed four years ago, he couldn't bring himself, perhaps out of some haphazard sense of duty, to sell the house or their possessions—or Maggie.

Phil spent nearly two hours staring. He smoked a half-pack of cigarettes.

“Dirty habit,” he said to himself while snubbing the butt in the full ashtray. He hadn’t even started on the car, he couldn’t bring himself to, he was feeling defiant—a first—and he smiled. He looked to the sky, the warm afternoon sun winked at him through the alders. Fall was approaching, soon to be followed by an unbearable winter in which the snow would block the garage door—a time when Maggie was confined to her space. The garage was kept warm then by a space heater, she was in no danger. His father had insisted on either the bus or others for rides to work, he couldn’t bear to take his baby out to face the harsh weather or the corrosive salts that lay waiting on the streets.

A car drove by blaring its horn, it snapped Phil out of his daydream and he decided it was time for the ritual.

He gathered up all he would need: wash bucket, special car soap—no dish soap, he’d already made that mistake once—new sponges, one for the upper body, one for the lower, a fresh chamois and the portable vacuum. He dragged out the hose and began his task.

Across town and out, beyond Jamison’s farm, past Fitz’s meadow and into the woods another three miles away, the thing burrowed through the dry leaves tossing them high into the air; it stopped and peeked with muddy green eyes into the bright light, looking about itself. It was on the hunt, sniffing wildly into the brisk breeze; smelling something delectable, it shrieked out.

Phil was putting the finishing touched on Maggie, a strange sound in the wind tickled his ears. It was similar to an animal caught in a trap, yelping in fearful anguish. He through a moment about it and shrugged his shoulders. Maggie was clean, he ran his had a few inches away from her surface feeling the energy of such an intensive job.

“Time to put you in now, old girl.” As he shut the garage door, he looked toward the sunset, watching the horizon for the coming of night.

Several months passed. He heard the sound again. He knew it was the same one he had heard that September afternoon; maybe he should have went chasing the sunset to see exactly what kind of animal had made the noise. Then it would’ve been easy but now it was in the dead of winter, ten below most of the time except by God’s good grace when the sun came out. But he hadn’t seen it in six weeks; he figured this was probably the worst winter the state had seen for the better part of fifteen years. He went to the window and peered out, snow was falling, the time almost tranquil flakes formed a flat grey terrain that covered everything masking the eclectic topography of his lawn. He couldn’t even see the street, the only way he knew it was ever there was because of the drooping elders that lined either side. He looked to his neighbor’s house, searching for lights, some sign of life perhaps, but it was snowing much too hard to see past the small circle of condensation he hard breathing made.

Phil fancied he’d heard scratching, maybe a popping noise in the garage. His ears told his mind they acknowledged the odd sound just as they had assured him they had sensed the one that had first aroused him. He paced slowly toward Maggie’s room and quickly pulled back the door. Taking a deep breath, he thrust his head out. Maggie sat quietly, her paint winking at him, the chrome sparkling; she probably wondered what the hell he was doing. The only sound he heard was the gentle purr of the heater. He let out a relieved sigh and shut the door, leaving the light on.

It saw the light. It was drawn to it. It had to find shelter from the cold it was trapped in. Heat, all it could think about was finding heat. And food. The thing looked at the warm light, the snow was melting in the path. It got close enough to feel it; it's pupils dilated.

* * * * *

The morning paper had not come but the storm had passed; little comfort, snow blocked the front door and was piled up to the base of the windows—ice freezing them shut—and there was nothing to distract his attention from the eerie sound that was still echoing in his head. He turned on the television and settled into an easy chair. He flipped through the channels and stopped on a newscast that flatly of a recently revived devil-worshipping cult in California's central valley.

Damn Californians," Phil mumbled to himself. "Eighty percent of the people on drugs the other twenty alcoholics. I hate 'em."

He remember his father saying something similar. He had been to California and came back warning his family and friends to stay clear of the destitute place. Phil knew he would never go there, wouldn't be caught dead there.

He must have fallen asleep because the next thing he remembered was a loud bang at the door. After struggling with the knob, he pulled it back and saw the paper at his feet. It read: *A Special Afternoon Edition*. Picking up the paper and just as he was about to close the door, he noticed something—or the lack of something. There were no footprints, neither on the walk nor the sidewalk nor the street. In fact, the snowplow hadn't been by yet. Nothing of life to been seen, only the dull glow of the sky upon the tundra—flat, white and expansive.

Like the noise, the oddity before his eyes bothered him. But, as with the sounds and the chill, he passed them off as best he could and closed the door. He fell back into his chair, broke free the rubber band, shook off the ice and opened the paper. He set the front page on the floor going straight for the sports, classified, and comics sections. He became lost in the columns of state, words, and funny characters.

“A job would be nice,” he said to himself. Anything to get him away from what his whole body felt. He was constantly tired. He hated the winters, the off-season for construction. A time when he sat in the house for weeks at a time, paranoia creeping up on him from every corner; every creak a crash, every whisper a shout, his sense lying a cold greasy hand on his shoulder. Last winter was really bad and when spring had finally arrived, Phil ran practically screaming out of the house, kissing the ground, dancing in the sober light. He could see his neighbors shaking their heads at him, he didn’t care, his torturous time alone was over.

But this winter had just begun, it was barely December and Phil spent many hours worrying if he was going to survive at all. He tried to think of summer, seeing himself working; in the past he had a clear picture but his thoughts now were almost a complete blank—almost blackness. It only worried him more. He set the paper on the floor beside him, glancing at the blaring headline etched across the front page.

TOWN SHOCKED BY MURDERS, it read. He picked it up and read through the article. A tragedy at Jamison’s farm; old man Jamison, his wife and two children were found brutally murdered. “Arthur Fitz found the bodies this morning. Police suspect the assailant came in through a window and killed the

family in their sleep, however, they have no leads. They are asking if anyone has any information about the crime, to contact the LeMars Sheriff's Office". Phil set the paper down and stared blankly into the TV.

He fancied the noise he heard last night was one of a beast gloating over its victims. He pictured its fur coated with blood, its teeth yellowed, its tongue lapping up the warm flesh of the kill. The howl a warning to those who would be next. He sunk into the chair trying to make himself smaller, trying to hide himself within the recesses of the upholstery.

He got up suddenly and went to the kitchen, he rifled through the cabinets finding a box of tea. He needed something to calm his nerves. The cup into the microwave and tea bag into the hot water, he added some vodka for texture, then some more. Forget the tea, vodka will do. An hour later both the chill and the noise were gone from him, all Phil felt was a profound sense of passivity. He knew from experience that this could be the beginning of the end but he cared little, he wasn't concerned about himself. The house, he wasn't concerned about that either, his job—no. What about Maggie? You've been a team for a long time, you rely on her she relies on you. What about her? Who's going to take care of her after you're gone?

Phil shook his head.

Can you honestly say you don't care for her? After all she's done...

"Shut up!" His voice echoed through the empty house.

Blocking won't do you any good, Philip; you know escape is a temporary thing, the problems you create only more virulently backlash. To Maggie: She wants to be let out, she's tired of dying,

she wants to experience life. And what about you? You've always wanted to live, to be as much as unlike your parents as you can. I'll tell you a secret, you're just like them. Just like your father.

He threw the mug across the room, the crash ringing in his ears, "I told you, shut up!"

That's it, Philip, release your anger, express yourself for once. Make a commitment, take the upper hand, end the torture. You have it within you.

He put his face in his hands and cried; he thought of absolutely nothing.

Later, sometime in the afternoon, Philip had gotten a hold of himself and planted his distraught self before the television. Soon, his eyes were ablaze from the images portrayed on the odious small screen. He watched the news, then gazed at travel and dish soap commercials, sports scores, diaper commercials, stories of happy people with absolutely no character flaws and perfect lives, joyous family reunions for the holidays and car advertisements before he decided to react to what he was seeing.

His first thought was of Maggie. Perhaps he should sell her, he could get a good price; he had taken as good, if not better care of the car than his father had. He could sell the car and move out of the Midwest, maybe go someplace where the climate was warmer and the people nicer, maybe fewer, a place where he could hide away from not only his responsibilities but from himself. A place where he had always been forbidden to go. As far as he knew, he was still forbidden but his father was long dead. It no longer mattered what he thought—his ashes in a decorative, traditional yet mildly expensive urn on the mantle above the fireplace. A good joke, Phil thought, for that's how the old man went. . .his attention was

immediately drawn to the window. He had the faint impression something had been watching him, its greenish, watery eyes peering, seeing the fire, feeling the warmth, wanting more than anything else to be curled up before it.

The thing, he thought. The very same that had been wreaking havoc throughout the small, frozen town. Now, it had found him, and fear wrapped him like an icy blanket. He wanted to cure it but knew—somehow but he wasn't sure how—he felt he was directly responsible for it. As if he had dredged it up out of his deepest fears. But that had been long ago, when his father was alive. Now he was dead and there was no need for the creature.

"I've got to get out," he said to no one.

Phil was caught in the sweeping motion of his thoughts. In the blink of an eye, he was in the past.

Suddenly he was eleven and shaking with fear in the back of the dark closet. His father had just finished "correcting" him for an insurrection he didn't understand. None of it made sense; the beatings were for his own good, and he would be a man someday and needed to learn discipline. Phil had heard it many times and he knew what was right and what was wrong but this time he hadn't done anything. He had simply wandered off and forgotten his chores. It had been a beautiful Sunday, the sun was shining and his neighborhood friends beckoned him to play. His father needn't had been so angry, he hadn't done anything.

He was filled with rage and hate. He gathered his strength, climbed out of the closet and to the window. He gazed endlessly out it, wishing, praying in a mockingly church sense that his father was gone, that someone or something would save him, and that the pain would subside. His shoulder hurt bad, he couldn't move

it—maybe it was broken—he sobbed a little and continued staring out the window.

His parents were arguing downstairs, his father was yelling about how the devil had possessed his boy, how he wouldn't listen, adhere to his duties, how lazy he was. Phil covered his ear and continued his mock prayer into the night.

He never stopped praying. In fact, as the weeks went by, he was only more adamant about it, he never stopped believing, never lost faith in his dark savior. But as time went by and the beatings got worse, his desperation painted a savage creature that would sneak into the house and devour his father, sending him to a place where he would relive all the horrors, all the pain Phil had been forced to endure. Weeks stretched into months and months into years; finally, at the age of fifteen, his prayers were answered.

The savior came in the form of an animal, a nightmare, as Phil came to later describe it. All he can remember about it was it woke him as he lie in bed. It had perched itself on his chest; it wasn't very big, only about the size of a cat but it sure didn't look like one. It was almost like a mole or hedgehog or otter but a hundred times more menacing. It had large yellow teeth that filled its relatively small mouth. It was cold and wet, its cropped fur matted to its body; its nose was warm. He doesn't know how he knew that detail but his sense told him it had nuzzled his ear as a sign of affection and loyalty to the one who had conjured him. Phil would stay up and talk with it, it spoke in a chattering language that, at first glance was indistinguishable but he knew what was said. He came to love his new friend that had no name he could pronounce. Soon things were to change.

Later, Phil came to realize he had created the beast out of his imagination. It was perfect in every way, true to what he thought a horrible being should look like. The only regret he had was that he wished he had taken the time to learn its name, pronounce it in its language, become a real friend. But there was no need for it—all he had to do was think about it and it would appear. He grew to know he had power over the beast but he never knew how much until he sent it after his father.

The television continued to burn Phil's eyes; although his fear had him, he felt he ought to change the channel for yet another distraction. But he couldn't move. It was from being afraid or anything, he told himself, he just felt like sitting, sitting and doing nothing. Just sitting here watching the TV, watching happy people, silly, trite comedies—everything's well and good in the world—not a thing out of place, not a damn thing.

But he knew he was lying to himself. If he wasn't so gripped with fear then why was he shrieking back from the thing before the fire? His old imaginary friend had come to call.

"Hope it's a nice visit," Phil said between his teeth.

"It is." The thing chattered. "I've missed you, Philip. It's *so* cold out there, coldest winter in what? Thirty years? Ever since you sent me away."

He sat, frozen and speechless.

"Of course you had no choice," the thing continued. "You send me to fulfill your deepest desires and what do I get? Sent back, back into the cold, dark, and nothing."

"I, uh..."

"But I'm not the kind of demon to hold a grudge. You called me, I answered."

“I...I called you?”

“Don’t play ignorant. You thought, I appeared. Simple as that. And if you don’t mind me saying, you’ve got quite a bit of power in Absu. You’re a god of sorts. If you ever decide to acknowledge yourself, that is.”

Phil covered his eyes. “You’re not here. You’re not real.”

The thing nuzzled his ankle, he kicked it away. There was a rouse of meaningless chatter then clear speech.

“Take it easy, pal. So who do you want me to take care of now?”

“No one!”

“Oh, c’mon, I’ve been pretty bored randomly killing people. Let’s get someone like dear old dad. Now, that was fun, you should of heard him scream when he knew I was upon him. Hey, what do you say?”

“I had nothing to do with that.”

It stood on its haunches and glared at him. “Wait a minute. *You* are responsible for *me*. Never forget that. I do as you will. Don’t blame me if the things I do are too difficult to stomach. You brought it upon yourself. Out of the bile of your hate I sprang. And that hate acted swiftly. Your father, the townspeople, that guy in the paper—nice photo by the way, don’t you think?—that’s your bidding whether you realize it or not. Every murder or disfigurement or deathly fright, it’s all from you. You and I are one.”

“Go back to hell where you came from!”

“Apparently I can’t convince you...there is another way.”

It turned its back on him then, over its shoulder, turned and smiled. “We go together.”

Phil closed his eyes and screamed. He felt the thing climb his leg, he blindly kicked at it. The thing bit him on the ankle and held on.

Phil frantically shook his leg and felt the thing release. Phil fell off the chair, cowering beside it. The thing screeched a high-pitched chatter then was silent.

Later, he opened his eyes and peered around him. The house was still save the slight howl of the winter wind. He looked to the window, nothing. To the chair, empty. To the floor, no trace. The mat before the fire where the thing had been resting, couldn't tell it was ever there. But it was the telltale proof in the fire that caused him to ultimately lose control of himself, to find himself prone to irrationalities and more and more irresponsibility. It was the charred carcass drawn tight over the blackened bones that sent what shred of humanity Phil had left careening away from him into the maelstrom.

* * * * *

I arrived from Omaha on the twelfth of August. It had been a long trip and the old car I drove fried its generator in Laramie, Wyoming. I had been stuck there for two days before they could find the parts to fix it. But I had made it to California, thank God. I was away from the Midwest, out of the cold and into the sun. It was a dream come true.

I met Rick, we had been friends since childhood, almost 35 years; he reveled in the West Coast lifestyle and finally, after all this time, convinced me to come out for a visit. But I was thinking of making things a little more permanent, setting up a life out here, eventually forgetting who I used to be and where I came from.

He agreed to let me stay with him for a week or so until I could find a job and get my own place. Three weeks have gone by now, I haven't gotten up the energy or ambition to find a job and Rick can't seem to tolerate me any longer. So, I've got to get out and

make my own way—if I could only get up the courage to leave this apartment.

Soon I will have to find it, though, the stress of living here is getting worse every day. I'm finding the need to escape increasing steadily with the stress. Yesterday, Rick didn't speak to when he came home from work, today I find myself in my room, lying on the bed and staring at the sparkling specks on the ceiling.

When things really bother me, when reality is too much for me, I like to dream of faraway places where the landscape is more picturesque; a place where the air is cleaner and the horizon uncluttered. A dreamscape that is totally devoid of people. I like to think of it as a basic anti-social tendency, found in just about anybody, but I've been told my fantasies go beyond that. They're more than just strange and irrational trivialities, they seem to extend much further, into places where random people and things sometimes come to harm. But I don't think about that. I'm perfectly at ease with myself and the world.

Around six, Rick dragged himself in. He was exhausted and we sat on the couch.

"I'm so busy at the office since they fired two employees, they expect me to take up the slack but I can't handle all that work."

We stared at each other for a long time and Rick asked if I had any luck finding a job.

"No."

He sighed. I knew I should be looking, but trepidation and loathing of jobs kept me in my room all day and night. However, the money from my savings and from the sale of my car had run out five days ago. I was now borrowing from Rick. And I knew he was tired of loaning it to me.

“Damn tired of it,” he said.

I didn’t know the first place to look for work. I’d been out of the job market for what seemed an eternity.

“What am I supposed to do?” I asked him.

He sighed again, obviously frustrated with my question. I smiled thinking I could maybe get a twenty out of him.

“If you weren’t in such a hurry to sell your car, you would have an easier time finding a job.”

“I didn’t need that old thing any longer, besides the bike does me just fine.”

He put his head in his hands.

“Stubborn to the end. I tell you what, we really need the help at the office. I could pull some strings and get you on.”

“Doing what? I don’t know the first thing about working in an office.”

Again, he sighed, this time more loudly. “Data entry, filing or something. It needs to be done and I don’t have the time for it.” He leaned forward. “Do anything, it doesn’t matter as long as you’re making money.”

“Money isn’t an issue. Except when I need it and I rarely need it.”

“Then why do you always borrow from me?”

“At that moment, I need it, other than that...”

“You start tomorrow.” He got up and briskly walked out, leaving a ten on the coffee table. I stared blankly at the wall, following the cracks in it. There should have been questions going through my head about details, where in the office I was going to work, who else was there, how much I was to get paid, and all that. But there was

nothing, just peaceful bliss. I picked up the bill and folded it neatly between my fingers.

The land spread out in all directions around me, flat and distant, dry and dusty, barren and unpopulated; I set my food into the hard earth and walked toward an unknown destination. Perhaps I could find a tree to sit under where I could gaze with wide eyes at the limitless blue sky speckled with clouds the texture of stretched cotton, breathe the air that was impregnated with the omnipresent odor of Honeysuckle, and think of nothing save how far away I was from the city that caused me inexorable anguish.

I woke early. The phone was ringing, distantly and quiet. It was Rick.

"A little early to be calling me," I told him.

"It's your first day on the job, get ready. I'll see you in fifteen minutes."

I let the receiver fall to the floor, I would have to disconnect the phone; this was not the way for me to live, waking up early and all that. I rubbed my eyes, they stung as if something were irritating them, in the bathroom mirror—they blazed red. I opted for Visine.

I washed up and was dressed when I heard a knock at the door.

"Who is it?"

"Let's go or you'll be late." He said through the door.

I had on a shirt, tie—it had been so long since I'd worn one—dress slacks and a coat. To the car and to the office; before we went in, he straightened my tie and fidgeted with my coat.

"Got to make a good impression," he said.

Me, I didn't much care. All I looked forward to was going home.

* * * * *

Almost a week has passed, today is supposed to be payday. Work has been an awful experience, Rick has been waking me up every morning, practically dressing me. I can't figure why he feels so responsible for me, he owes me nothing; all I can figure is that he doesn't want to look bad if I screw up, so he's doing his best to make sure that doesn't happen.

Also, he could be cursing me, getting back for something I did or didn't do in the past; stuck me in this banal office of ten people designed for six, no ventilation except for the air conditioner and the ones "in charge" turn it off because it gets too cold. But then it gets stuffy and more complaints then it's back on again and then the whole process repeats itself. I sit and watch the spectacle, laughing inside; one day, when I feel more comfortable and stable in this job, I'll be able to drift off while doing the work they expect of me.

The weekend came and went, so did the loose change they called my reward for a good weeks' work. I did little, couldn't afford to go out or buy anything because Rick decided it was time I pay rent and the loans he had extended me.

Thanks for nothing, old friend.

Now it's Tuesday and the week is already dragging. I haven't spoken to anybody in the office; I've only replied to the hellos and good-byes, nothing more, I won't allow myself to. I can feel anger building within me, anger tapped from an unknown source. It's unexplainable and a little unimaginable not to mention slightly psychotic, but no matter, no sense fighting it, it will only promote more of the same.

Finally, on Thursday, I was able to relax. I managed to channel the anger into a more constructive and reasonable outlet. This way I could tolerate the work and the people and be able to mentally

disappear from both—besides, with their mentality, they would never notice. The only person I would have to worry about was Rick, I knew he could spot my mental wanderings in an instant. I would have to contend with him.

When there's my will, there's always a way to circumvent the others.

After lunch, on a full stomach and a throatful of bile, I saw outside myself.

Just to let you know, you're being watched. Yes you, the one sitting at the table surrounded by your coworkers pretending to read the computer training manual. You are being watched carefully, peered at with muddy green eyes hell-bent for revenge. I have to keep an eye on you, have to make sure you don't come to any harm. I cast you from your dead winter paradise into the world of the living dead. But don't get too caught up in all of it. You have things to do, responsibilities noteworthy of the being that you are. But I fear you're beginning to lose it, with this job and out in society, your grasp of reality continually in question, the threads loose in your head. You can't even focus on a single thought. Once upon a time this behavior struck you as funny, something to be encouraged. But now, since you tried to destroy me, the fantasies have taken on new meaning, lodged deep in your mind eroding what rational sense you have left, slowly converting you to a raving lunatic. You have no one else to blame but yourself. That's why I have come, to make sure you do not deviate from your destined path.

It's good to see you communicating with the natives; they're such clods, eh? Such beady-eyed, number crunching little bastards. You think you humor them with your conversation, and they think you're so clever, trying to impress them with some vast knowledge; their

stripes of insecurity bleed through their pallid, verbose, overcompensated, plasticine facades. Only they hold the torch of enlightenment here, the ancient urn of truth and a plebe such as yourself has no place speaking to them in the manner that you do. Doesn't the thought of devouring them tickle your gut, send electric shivers throughout your body? It does me. But, wait...you're human and above primal urges such as these. One so sophisticated and advanced such as yourself shouldn't be pondering what you find you are. My dear friend, Philip, provoke the human response, be ashamed of yourself and wish to lock your soul away for the remainder of your days.

I walk. Down a dusty piece of land that is now a road; tall brown grasses straggle alongside twisting themselves around dilapidated fence posts masking the visible flatness of the plain. In the distance, a large house blends with the fantastic blue of the limitless sky. As I pace closer, I see the building is trimmed in white with a black, shake-tile roof; black wrought iron adorns the turret, several porches and alcoves, and on the widow's walk along the roof. There are no signs of life, the reflected glare of the sunlight on the windows winks blankly at me. I remember seeing this house from other mind-wanderings, but I've never been this close to it, nor so absorbed by the overall loneliness of the place. It's as if something is inviting me in.

"What do you think you're doing?" A voice speaks into my ear.

"What..?" I shake my head and the vision dissipates. Rick is hovering over me.

"I see you have drifted off again. You've got to stop that, especially if you want to keep this job. You do, don't you?"

"I suppose. The money's nice and all. . ."

“Good, then pay attention or else, Sandy will call a meeting about your inability to perform your job and you’ll be in trouble.”

“Gee, I could lose my job?”

“Yes.”

“That would be a good. . .”

“Shut up.” He looked crossly at me. His tone became meaner. “I’ve done a lot for you over the years. I’m giving you a break. Don’t screw this up.” He shoved the training book at me and huffed off. The book fell to the floor. I let it sit there for a few moments before deciding to pick it up.

This office reminds me of high school, with all the politics that go with it: the power struggles, the backstabbing, the front stabbing, the giddy flirting and the ill affairs. The immaturity is what affects me the most. But I suppose it’s all they have. I thought Rick was beyond it, but as the days go by, I see he is completely immersed in it. He said working for the small town, piss-ant paper was more of a burden than a blessing. I think he’s the one who is losing it.

This job is certainly boring, there’s no denying that; but for them what else is there to do but cultivate animosity and occasionally have sex with each other in the back seat of one man’s Oldsmobile in the parking lot? These people have no room for thought or dreams, they never have and probably never will. They are dead to the world of life. But, if I have anything to do with it, I’ll change this place for the better.

Friday, the money—a little more than the week before—and the weekend. I went to the store for some essentials and settled into my room.

I’m living in the large Victorian, the one painted wholly in blue. I am sitting in the Brown Room, on a comfortable couch, reading.

The Brown Room is exactly as the name connotes, the walls done up in brown, the carpets, the furniture upholstered in chocolate-brown leather, the curtains, light fixtures, all in a pleasant shade of brown. The evening sun is streaming through the curtained window casting amusing shadows on the wall. The shadows play with the pattern on the wallpaper, black melting into chocolate, chocolate into tan and tan into yellow. I smile at the spectacle, my attention off the book; in the kaleidoscope of tempered colors I see figures dancing, smiling, laughing, trying to jump from the pattern and onto my lap. They want me to dance with them, to join in their merriment so that I may forget the horrid week I had in the outside world. I smile back and refuse their invitation; I need to unwind more, not ready for movement just yet. They seem to be sad for a moment then dance again, taking the dark red-velvet flowers from the wallpaper and throwing them to the floor—just to get my attention. But I'm back in my book, trying as hard as I can to ignore their childish antics. One flower bounces off the floor and to my feet, a shadow from the window grabs the flower with black transparent fingers and hands me it. I wave it away.

"Not now," I say. But they refuse to listen. They want me to play. It's been months, perhaps longer, since I've visited with them. I'm glad to find they are overjoyed to see me.

How long can I stay? They ask. I don't know, hopefully long enough to satisfy them, I hate to see them upset or depressed like the ones in the other world. Which reminds me, Rick, he's always lonely and depressed and upset all the time. Perhaps I could kill two birds with one stone, so to speak. I'd have to talk to him but maybe he'd like to come here, meet my friends and have a good, relaxing time. The shadows are continuing to bother me, they are

starting to throw the flowers at me; I set the book down and walk through the house.

Just outside the room is a short hallway leading to the staircase. It is circular in design, polished oak banisters extending along the stairs to the library door. I lean over the railing and peer down, rich crimson carpet with hints of sapphire fold down the stairs stretching to each of the three floors. I lean over further trying to catch a glimpse of the next floor down, the carpet appears as a wave, flapping against the dark mahogany paneling and glimmering doors. I lean over even further and out of the corner of my eye see the shadows running toward me. These figures, no bigger than a foot tall, grab my ankles and send me over the railing.

I'm falling, looking at the ceiling full of mosaics. I see one floor then the second then the third. I land on something soft and firm and am rebounded into the air. When I reach the second floor, I see the tables dancing around each other, galloping from one room to the next, racing in one door and out the next. Some figures trying to mount the tables, riding them bareback hooting and hollering. I fall again and land softly, the carpet had folded itself up to catch me. I lay on my back looking to the third floor. They are laughing hysterically, cackling, pointing at me in a wonder of divine amusement. I hear the floor creaking as if some distant earthquake were approaching, it subsides, fading away; I notice it is just about dark. It's impossible to deal with them at night, their antics and all, seeing that I can't handle them now, I'd better not stay. As I head for the door, there is an awful wailing, they don't wish to be alone and seeing that evening and night is the only time they come out, they try to press me to stay. The carpet tries to pull itself from under my feet but I am stern. I must leave.

I close the door to the world behind me and set my feet to the earth. One step is as to twenty meters and in a few moments the house is barely visible on the near-dark horizon; it, like the night, has turned to black.

* * * * *

I wake hearing someone pounding on my door, the sun is filtered through the curtains but still does not hesitate to blind me. Again, the pounding.

“Hold on,” I say, rise and try to dress.

“C’m on, we’re late!” It is Rick. It must be Monday.

We were at work in a record fifteen minutes, he said nothing to me. As he went careening through the traffic, I only stared out the window thinking how incredibly short my stay had been and that I would have to find a way to as Rick if, this weekend, he would like to join me.

Someone struck up a conversation with me for the very first time. Her name was Anna; although she had annoyed me in the past, she seemed as if she were trying to be a friend now. As if she were my friend, my true friend, then I would take her on a journey of the most unimaginable proportions. It was the least I could do for my friends, the least I could do for those who took the time to care for me.

We had lunch together, at a sandwich shop; it was a well-balanced conversation. I smiled frequently and she spoke in long intervals talking of her new life in California, what she used to be like when living in New Mexico and how she was glad to meet people who were, at the very least, casually friendly. She said she knew Rick from years back, they had gone out but the relationship was long forgotten in the melee of the workplace.

"We were thinking of getting married. Did he ever tell you that?"

"No. He doesn't tell me anything anymore. In fact, I hardly see him."

"He's your friend, right?"

"Yes."

"Friends should tell each other everything. That's what makes them friends."

"And they should be willing to do just about anything for each other?" I asked.

"That's right."

"And if one friend is down, the other should try to cheer him up?"

"Exactly. You would be less than a friend if you didn't." She smiled. I smiled.

"I'd like to think of us as friends," I told her.

"Yes, we are," she said without giving it a second thought.

With the day finally over, I said good-bye to Anna. I prepared for the journey home with Rick hoping he would drive a little less crazy this time. We were halfway to the apartment when he spoke.

"You and Anna had lunch today?"

I nodded.

"You guys talk about anything important?"

"No, not really."

"Nothing?"

I didn't know what to say. He continued.

"She didn't tell you we went out once?"

"She told me."

"How much?"

"A little, nothing much."

“Great.”

I snapped off the radio and turned to him. “What do you think of her?” I asked him.

“She’s fine. Why do you want to know?”

“I’m thinking of...”

“Put the thought out of your head. Now!”

“What?”

“I want you to stay away from her.”

“Well, if she and I going out bothers you...”

“It does.”

“If you can’t see me dating her, if you’re jealous...”

“It had nothing to do with that. And you know it.” He pulled the car into a parking lot and shut off the car. “Remember about a two years ago, when you came out to visit? Remember Tracy? Remember what happened?”

“Of course I remember her. What does she have to do with this?”

“Do you remember what happened to her?”

“She got sick or something, shortly after, I went back to Nebraska.”

“She didn’t just get sick, she went into a coma.”

“Okay, what are you getting at?”

“I know you had something to do with it. When Tracy came out of her coma, she told me about this place you took her to. She told me a strange story about a house and the morbid creatures that were living there, she told me about you, how you left her there. I didn’t believe a word of it until the doctor asked me if she’d been in a car accident. Seems she was all cut and bruised up. By the nature of the wounds, she couldn’t have done it to herself. The funny thing was she said you did it to her. You and those creatures.”

“I think you’ve lost your mind, old man, making all this crap up...”

“Don’t you even,” he grabbed me by my jacket. “Don’t you even mess with Anna or so help me, I’ll kill you, Philip.” He released me and resumed the drive to the apartment.

Poor Rick, he really is stressed these days. It was my responsibility as a friend to see he got the opportunity to relax. His mental health was at stake; it’s painfully obvious, accusing me of such things, threatening to kill me. As if he really could. We’d been friends for 35 years, how could he accuse me of something so erroneous and utterly ridiculous?

My thoughts were on Tracy. She was a nice girl, hard-working, ambitious; she used to be an artist in college but got sucked into the corporate rat race, trapped in a lifestyle that dictated twelve hour days plus a couple of hours more and another job. Sure, she had the nice things: flashy new car, house, expensive nights out and all that but it ate at her life. The treadmill took away her life, squelched her ability to be happy. She was very sweet, I couldn’t bear to see her perish in the jaws of society’s monster. She deserved more, a life which required little, if any, effort from her. I knew her thoughts and desires would set her free—and they did. No matter what Rick or anybody says, I had nothing to do with her illness, her desires overwhelmed her; I only applauded her release from the travesty of a putrid existence and hoped one day she would get fed up with the outside world and rejoin me.

And I see a little of Tracy in Anna. I know she’s unhappy; I feel it’s my duty to help her anyway I can. We’re friends and besides, I owe Rick one.

Tuesday, Anna and I had lunch again. I had to tell her what Rick told me.

“He sounds pretty silly,” she said.

“That’s what I think.”

“I know he’s jealous. Ever since we broke up, he can’t stand seeing me go out with anyone else. Rick’s the kind of guy who forces himself on you. I know he wanted it to work out between us but in the end got cold feet, like most men. He said he wanted to make me happy, but never lived up to his promises. This isn’t the first time he’s acted like this. He did the same when Stan asked me out.”

Another coworker.

“But that was an innocent ‘friends only’ kind of deal. Stan’s like a brother or father figure to me. If Rick had lived up to what he promised me, then, maybe things might have been different.”

I looked pensively at her. “I hope that doesn’t happen with us.”

She smiled. “I don’t think it will.”

I took her hand and stared longingly into her eyes.

The day is bright yet cloudy. I’m in an alley full of small shops, their large pane glass windows display the store’s best merchandise; some herbal goods, dresses, others food and other sundries. They alley appears distinctly English. One shop at the end—a small sidewalk leads to the entrance—has kitchen utensils, appliances, and assorted trinkets. I stop to peer in the window pretending to shop; I see myself, I am dressed in black jeans, black shirt and black leather vest. I appear tall and thin, dark hair slicked back. In the store I see a young woman behind the counter, she looks about the store with her deep brown eyes and smiles at me, her long black hair drapes over her shoulders. She is still smiling. I turn to leave, she runs out from the shop to greet me. We meet each other on the

small patch of sidewalk that leads back to the main alley. She is familiar. It is Anna.

"I know you," she says. "You live in that old house just outside of town."

"Yes. I've been there for a while now."

"I've heard of you. My father told me to stay away from you. He says you're dangerous."

"Maybe I am." I smile.

"I don't believe it. My father is insane."

I grabbed her hand. "Well, if you can get away, perhaps you can come up to the house someday and see the place."

"That's not going to happen as long as I'm around," a voice called out. An old man was only a few paces from us. Anna let go of my hand and stood next to him.

"This is my father, Stanley."

I already knew that.

Stan walks to me, standing only inches from my face. The sun lights up his features.

"Listen you, I don't want you talking to my daughter, got it? I know who you are and where you're from. You live in the old Easby place and I don't mind telling you son, that place is evil and so are you for living in it. I know what goes on up there. That house is cursed, that makes you cursed too. Now get out of here." He points the way back to the main alley. I smile at Anna and walk away.

I released my hand and took my gaze from her. She shook as if she'd been hit by an electric shock. She squinted her eyes.

"What, what was that?"

"Did you like it?"

"It was weird, what happened?"

“My world.”

The rest of Tuesday dragged. Sandy, the boss, gave me an assignment that had to be finished by the end of the day. Occasionally, I looked up to see Anna spending more and more time glancing off, absorbed in deep thought. I knew I was making a difference in her life. It wasn't until it was time to go home that I noticed Stan had been doing the same. It was good to see people experiencing a peaceful bliss for once in their lives.

Thursday. All morning I was held up with work. But by the afternoon...

I'm sitting on the love seat by the window. The midday sun warms the large room. I'm back into the book I couldn't finish the last time I was here. Finally, I had some peace, the playful figures only seem to bother me at the approach of night and in the depths of night itself. I remember one time, I overstayed and witnessed how the quaint blue Victorian changed. It changed into something I really can't explain. It was almost as if all the bright colors of red, blue, and yellow turned into varying shades of copper, grey, and black. A sense of intense fear seemed to emanate from every corner of every room, surrounding the soul, enwrapping the essence of the person with complete, unbridled terror. It was quite a struggle, I remember, to get out that time. I'm very reluctant to stay past evening, when I can at least tolerate the antics, much more than that, forget it.

The curtains blew as if moved by an invisible breeze. I hear scratching on the walls, light pounding as if someone were on the other side playing some coarse joke. At first, I ignored it but it became progressively louder. My curiosity got the better of me, I got up to search out the noise.

Out of the sunroom into the main hall leading to the front door; the scratching moves to the floor then up the right wall where a series of portraits hang. They move behind one, the next, the next, then stop behind the fourth. I notice it is a portrait of Tracy, her blonde locks dangle just above her eyes. I smile, remembering her.

She came here last winter, when the sun was gone and you couldn't tell day from night. Her life in the other world was a shambles, her parents had recently died and she was looking for anything, anywhere to escape to. I brought her here and she was more than happy to lose herself in the house. Completely ecstatic, she was.

Her excitement began in the front room, moved to consecutive floors, the attic, the small concave room with bay windows at the top of the turret until she finally ended up bewildered in the basement. All the oddity of the place capturing her full attention, heightening every sense. I thought I had finally made her happy—until one grey-lit afternoon as we conversed in the library.

"This place, it amazes me." We sat in opposite chairs facing each other, a brisk fire consuming driftwood in the fireplace. "The more I see, the more I hate it. I want to return."

"But you said you loved it here."

"For a time, yes, but that time has passed. I think *you* love it here. I can't stay here any longer. It's too much to bear."

"Don't say that..." I looked around seeing if ears were listening.

"Why not? I'm being honest. You like it here and I don't. I hate it, really hate it."

"Tracy..."

She rose from her chair and spoke with her arms stretched away from her. She glared at me. "If anybody's listening, I want to leave. I hate it here. Let me out of here."

"Tracy, I, I..."

"What the hell is wrong with you?"

She must've noticed the fear on my face. I knew what was going to happen, I could feel it. The forces that ran this house took too easily to offense. And if offended, they would take action. The fire roared and for the first time since I'd been there, fear gripped me. I wasn't afraid for myself but for her, what they would do to her.

"Talk to me, damn it." She yelled at me.

The floor shook, curtains swaying, books flying off the shelves, the zing I heard as one passed dangerously close to my ear. I quickly got up and hugged her tight. The curtains, golden, their light a reflection of the fire, rolled out from their hangings and wrapping around her, wedging themselves between us. I tried to hold on, screaming it was all a mistake, a simple misunderstanding but the invisible ears were now deaf. They took her from me, dragging her kicking and squealing like some sick child, wailing like a pig who knows its fate as it stands before the slaughterhouse. Her form was pulled into the wall, the paper opening a berth for her, with no more than the sound of a pebble thrown in a still pond. And the scratching, the terrible scratching, it echoed through my head. It is a sound I will never forget. I pounded on the wall, begging and pleading for her return. I had stayed well past dusk and into the night, watching the brilliant colors turning somber, more menacing, more black. I pounded on the wall all night, not stopping, the pain in my hand, once sharp, slowly subsided until it was numb, watching the fire until it had burned out, the books gaping with hungry,

toothless mouths; the walls of the stately manor into the rough-hewn cockles of an endless black cavern. The crimson Axminster carpet a mixture of blood, bile and macerated chunks of flesh. I saw a gangrenous mélange at my feet, the stench of it overpowering me, and the shrieks, the horrid shrieks, the final ingredient in the nightmarish exhibition. I held onto my precious sanity as a man clinging to a life preserver in a tempest—it was the only thing that kept me alive.

I found her the next morning, when a trickle of sunlight had crept over the horizon, peering in the window with piquant curiosity; she was in the Bay Room in the turret dangling by the neck—a thin, golden hair-like cord attached to an invisible beam in the ceiling. Grey wispy fingers clamped around her throat. On her face was affixed a permanent smile, teeth gleaming, dead eyes probing my damned soul.

I pound on the wall beside her portrait and look into her sparkling eyes. She seems to still be alive, trapped, the scratching, her scratching tapping furious rhythms behind it. She is trapped here, for as long as this house remains standing, as long as I continue to come here, keeping it alive, bringing others. But I can't leave, I must come here for if I neglect my proper duties, they will take and imprison me just as the others. I have agreed to be caretaker and nothing will negate the pact I have made. Nothing. No matter how many others visit, no matter how many are sacrificed, no matter how many remain, I cannot pass the responsibility onto anyone else.

Something I haven't noticed in the portrait. Tracy's locks, her golden locks, appear to drape around her neck as if strangling her. Her smile is still innocent and without pain. She, at least, appears happy now.

* * * * *

Friday. I went into work with a headful of apprehensions, my face displaying a two hours' night's sleep. My hair hastily combed and my cheeks unshaven, nobody took much notice, even though I moved through the day like a somnambulist. It wasn't until late in the day in the hallway when Anna spoke to me.

"I'm still thinking of that place you took me to. Can we go back? This weekend, maybe?"

"I don't know if that's the best..."

"It'll be fun. You can't turn me down," she peered at me with warm brown eyes. "After all, I know your secret place. I think we could have a good time. How about us meeting tonight. My place. Say seven?"

"I'm not going to..."

She hurriedly wrote directions on a torn piece of paper and kissed me lightly on my gruff cheek. I smiled childishly.

"Make it eight."

She handed me the note, giggled and bounded back into the office.

It was well past eight when I finally made myself ready. I could barely read her spidery handwriting on the note and got lost on my bicycle ride to her apartment. Sometimes I wish I had never sold Maggie. My watch read 9:15 when I arrived. She was all smiles as she pulled back the door.

"Well, hi there."

"Sorry I'm late."

"At least you're here, I was beginning to worry." She led me to the living room, the TV was on. She shut it off. "Can I get you anything? Coffee, tea, a glass of wine?"

“Tea.”

She walked into the kitchen and a moment later brought me a mug full of hot water, the tea bag string twisted in a loop dangling over the side. She had wine.

“So what do you think?” She looked at me longingly with her deep brown eyes, her brown hair dancing lightly on her shoulders. She wore a tan shirt and blue jeans. I looked at her shape under the clothes, I wondered what she’d look like without those clothes on, my hands caressing her feeling the small of her back, her breasts and her middle. Seeing her hair resting on her naked shoulders, her warm skin against mine, my fingers tugging at the tuft of hair between her legs. But it was too soon, I only casually knew her, it was far too soon.

“So, are we ready?”

Or was it?

I embraced her and we began our incredible journey.

She stands before me, we are in the house, in the bedroom aptly named the Green Room. It is furnished totally in the color; emerald curtains and tapestries, jade green carpet and upholstered chairs, a verdant canopy bed with matching silk sheets. A fire is burning in the fireplace, it is the only light; we are both naked, our clothes left in the other world. She steps close to me and kisses me lightly on the lips. I open her mouth with mine, my tongue probing her, I can feel her excitement heightening, the space between her legs warm and moist. I feel her hands on my back, pulling me toward the bed; we sit down and slowly move up the rich dark green comforter to the headboard—our lips never separating. The fire is burning brightly, embers popping, I can feel its warmth on my back. I am on top of her, her hand guiding mine, and I enter her. My emotions

are a flurry, my mind a torrent of random, confused thought. I have not taken her, she has taken me.

She quickly rolls me over, grinding into me, her hands holding my wrists to the cherry headboard. Her motions are fierce, I cannot hold out, cannot make it last. I feel the presence of a second set of hands near hers. They grip me tight; I hear the embers in the fire, they pop as if corn, they jump from the fire onto the carpet, the smolder forming shapes. I am just about to completion, my mind un-concentrated, my eyes blind to the two figures which have appeared at the foot of the bed. They reach out to Anna's back, gently caressing her spine. I look into her brown eyes, they have turned green; a brilliant smile forms in her mouth, her tongue licking her lips. I sense incredible desire from her, unquenchable desire. But I am almost finished.

She kneels above me, I fall out of her, my semen shooting onto my stomach. I attempt to move with her and find I am bound tight to the headboard—wooden digits wrap around my wrists. I can only watch her.

She bounds off the bed to the two figures. She wraps her hands around their hard-ons, smiles again at me and takes them into her mouth. I watch as both the figures change to resemble me, flesh wrapping their dark essence. Anna's energy is fierce, her motions erratic; one of myself mounts her from behind. They both smile fiendishly taking what they can of her, forcing her body to accompany their large members. She screams in a mixture of pain and satisfaction, her middle buckling, waiting, wanting the one in her mouth to give her the liquid she craves. The fire is roaring uncontrollably, consuming everything.

I pull against the headboard, I expend every bit of energy I have left in me. But I can do nothing. Anna has left me weakened and worthless.

One of me comes, she pulls him out of her mouth, milky-white spurts and pops as the embers of the fire soaking and scorching her face, creating and quenching the searing heat at the same time. Her tongue, now long and serpent like, licks up the drops and flows of the smelted iron of their brand. They have her, all of her. She laughs hysterically, maniacally, gripping her behind pressing the other further into her. His nails claw her flesh, her blood pooling the carpet. He thrusts and finishes inside her, her body jerking to the shots of his inflamed orgasm. She comes to rest.

I have closed my eyes. I hear her walking across the room, the fire has died down, the air is cool—sweat glistening on my exhausted body. She climbs on the bed, straddling me, I open my eyes.

“Oh, it’s not so bad,” her face is covered with semen and patches of burned skin, the wounds bleeding raw pus. “I love it.” She smiles. “Have some of yourself.” She leans down to kiss me, the bitter taste of ash and bile pours into my throat, brandishing my tongue. She sits up and smiles again, her teeth gaping.

“Got to go now, love. But I know I’ll see you soon. We are one.”

I could feel the hold on me loosening.

She jumps off the bed to the two mes. They are massaging themselves. She leans over to one and sucks its flaccid length into her mouth. She waves.

“Thanks for the great time. I won’t be going back.” She laughs. It echoes throughout the place, throughout my mind.

I am just about free.

The three of them, hand in hand, skip toward the fall wall. I break loose and run to them. Just as I have the tips of my fingers on her, she disappears into the wall.

“Anna!”

I pound the wall, tearing bits of emerald paper with my nails, kicking the polished paneling.

“Anna!” I yell. My voice echoing, pulsating off all the walls in the house.

I close my eyes again and immediately notice the light surrounding me is now much brighter. I shake my head trying to clear my thoughts of her, turn around and slowly open my eyes.

I am outdoors and clothed in black. I have to shield my sight from the glare of the bright sun. I am in the alley, the alley where I met Anna for the first time. The shop is down the small patch of sidewalk. I turn and walk. Attached to my wrist is a leash, at the end of it is a small, mangy dog; it looked more like a mole or raccoon. I kneel to look more closely at it then see the old man, Anna’s father, behind the counter.

He walks out and meets me on the sidewalk, his tired grey eyes glaring. I forget about the animal I am apparently out walking and stand.

“You, I told you to stay away from my daughter. Now she’s gone. Lost.”

I, I don’t know what...”

“I know she’s dead, murdered, her body left to rot...somewhere.” Tears streamed down his wrinkled face. “And it’s all because of you, you and that cursed house. You make it appear all lovely, like gingerbread, candy for the little girls, so you can tempt them to go

there with you and kill them. I won't let you get away with it. I'll see you dead."

He raises his hand to strike me, I catch him by the wrist.

"It wasn't me, I had nothing to do with it."

"Stop your filthy lies. You are just like your grandfather. All you Daragins are evil, like demons—to the core." He pulls his hand from my grip and walks into his shop, slamming the door. His tears like pure water, drown my heart. The thing at the end of the leash tugs at it then speaks in a chattering voice,

"Two down, eight to go."

The slam resounded through my head, leaving an echo which I followed back into reality. I was back in my room, someone was banging at the door. I rubbed the vertigo out of my mind, quickly looked around for the thing, and opened the door. It was Rick.

"Hey, what's up?" I said in a contrived groggy voice. He pushed past me throwing the door shut.

"What the hell have you been doing?"

I wanted to say nothing but it slipped out.

"Dreaming."

He crossed his arms, ready to strike me. "With Anna?"

I quickly composed myself, the thing had gone. "No."

"You've been here the entire weekend?"

I wasn't about to tell him what had happened, if he already didn't know. Besides, I wasn't sure if the visit to the house was real. I had originally been at Anna's place, I usually return to this world in the same location. But I wasn't about to tell him that. The vertigo hit again. I rubbed my brow.

"What day is it?"

"What's been going on?" He raised his voice, tightening his fists."

"The day!"

"Sunday. Afternoon. Now, are you going to tell me?"

The vertigo worsened. It was as if part of me were still in the other world and my existence here were slowly ebbing.

"There's nothing to tell."

He grabbed and shook me. "Don't give me that! I know. . ."

"You don't know anything!" I screamed and he let me go. He sat down and looked pensively around the room.

"I thought for sure you had something to do with it. It smelled of Tracy all over again."

"Rick, what has happened?"

"There's been some sort of accident. Anna's in a coma. I stopped by her place Saturday night and I found her lying in her room, by the bed."

I nodded.

"All I could think of was you, how you had somehow screwed with her as you had screwed with Tracy. At least that's what I first thought. But, later, after the ambulance left, the place seemed weird, I can't describe it. I could swear I saw your bike by the door but when I looked closer at it, it wasn't a bike at all, it was a couple of boxes stacked on top of one another. Then I thought I saw Anna, but it was just some of her clothes hanging in the closet. And it got stranger. As I was ready to leave, I smelled smoke. Then I saw it. It got so thick, it was as if twenty people had just rushed in and lit cigarettes at the same time. Moments later, I could almost *feel* their presence, as if they were watching me from afar. I called out several times but there was nothing, only an odd silence. No echo or noise from other apartments, only silence. As I said, I figured this a repeat of what happened to Tracy, but it was nothing like that."

More and stronger vertigo. I was starting to lose my hold on reality—and fast.

“You have to leave.”

He stood, yelling incoherently.

“Leave me. Go.” My voice became a low moan. I was losing sight of him and the room, the forms were fading. The last thing I saw of the world was Rick running out.

Walking down a pleasant street, ranch-style houses on either side, the sun warms my back. I find I am smiling, blissful for such a beautiful day. The houses are spaced far apart, one catches my attention, a faded green one with vermilion trim, on the left side. The house looks to be one story; the entrance square in the middle, two pane windows on either side, but as I walk to one side, I see the bottom floor jutting out from a man-made hill which the top floor (the main entrance) rests on. The bottom floor has multi-paned windows linked together forming a greenhouse appearance. I peer into the windows, a screen door opens.

“Come in.” I only hear a voice. I enter anyway. An arm wraps around mine, I see it is Stan, Anna’s father; he appears much older, most of his white hair has fallen out, only small patches above the ears remain.

“I’ve been wondering when you’d visit me,” he pats my hand. “I want to show you around.”

We walk arm in arm past the windows, up a short flight of stairs to a door. He pulls a key out of his pocket and unlocks it.

“This is my daughter’s room. She loved to play all around this house.”

He opens the door and leads me through.

The room is long and narrow, it extends only three meters each side of the doorway. There is another door at the far end. On the right side of the room is a child's bed, a desk with some dolls on it, some books, and an armoire.

"Now here's what I want to show you," he points to the left. On that side is a candy rack running the entire length of the wall, it is filled full of all types of candy I have ever known—neatly stacked, neatly organized.

"I put this here for her. She loved candy, especially gingerbread and ginger snaps. I put this variety here to satisfy her. I tried to wean her from the ginger, but you know kids...I knew her appetite for ginger would get her into trouble one day, and it did." He releases my arm and steps back.

"Did you think I would not recognize you? I know it's you. You and that damn blue gingerbread house. You killed her. You killed my daughter! But you will not escape, this is my domain!"

He lunges at me and we both fall to the floor. His hands are on my throat. I feel his hatred of me running through him like a whitewater. But he is not very strong, I easily push him off. He falls back through the door, reaches in his pocket and pulls out a knife.

"I'm going to kill you Daragin, so you can't take away anybody else's children anymore. I'm going to cut your black heart out!"

He jumps for me aiming the knife at my chest. We wrestle. I knock the knife from his grip and kick it far from him. My anger builds, like a pot of water heated uncontrollably on a stove, it boils over. I am cast far from myself.

He is under me, I sit on his chest like a incubus, my hands to his throat feeling his feeble, miserable life force assimilated by mine.

One last breath he tries to grab the knife. I snatch it away. He is dead.

I stand shrieking to whoever will hear, whoever will fear me, to whoever will become my minion. The thing is standing at my feet, nuzzling my ankle.

We get up to leave, my soul brazen with sacrifice, I feel invincible. I have taken what is entitled to me by birthright. I have taken what I desire to take, not to the opposite.

We stand on the street, my back to the house. I hear it collapsing under its own weight. The sound of breaking glass and crunching wood pleases me; Stan and Anna, they are mine.

I do not turn to look as the wall fold out and the roof crashes to the ground. The thing chatters with ecstatic delight.

Monday. Morning. I am alone. I waited for Rick to pick me up for work but he never showed. I was already dressed and waited until 8:30 before taking a bus into town.

When I arrived at work, Rick was nowhere to be seen. The office had a somber atmosphere to it, it was wonderful. Anna was absent and Stan was gone too. Sandy, the boss, announced it would be a slow day in the hopes that Anna would recover. It was too little concern too late. Besides, their concern lasted a record twenty minutes, the office politics resumed the second Anna left their minds. And they were in full swing. Hillary started the beginning of the end. She turned from her computer to another employee, Sidney.

“You know, I read this story by this guy, a local writer. Someone told me it was good but I thought it was trash.”

The conversation caught my attention.

“You know, I can’t see the purpose of writing. It’s done by a whiny bunch of men who can only think of sex. You know what I

mean? Anna used to read a lot, especially that horror stuff, I think that's what did it to her. She paid too much attention to the books and not enough to God."

Sidney nodded and cast a careful glance at me. Hillary spoke to me.

"Do you know anything about it?"

"God? No, I make it a habit not to."

"No, Anna, I mean."

"Why do you ask?"

"She talked a lot about you, about this strange place you took her to. Did it have anything to do with what happened to her?"

"I can't see how it would." I was tiring of the conversation. Didn't she have anything else to talk about? Maybe the evil in TV or something? She pressed on.

"I think you know." Her irritating line of inquiry was wearing thin. "I think you know damn well." I felt the hatred building, like the pot on the stove. I tried to stop it.

"Everybody," Sandy called out. "I need to call a meeting."

She stated babbling and I didn't hear her. I was consumed with myself. I was getting to the point of not caring, not concerning myself with what would happen to these people if I took them to the house. I wanted to take them away...

"Stan passed away Sunday. Apparently he died in his sleep."

Hillary shot a look at me. Brutal anger gripped me wrapping itself around my heart making it beat furiously. Why don't they leave me alone? Hillary spoke, pointing her bony finger at me.

"You, Philip, I know it's..."

I quickly stood. I chose my words carefully. "Shut up, all of you! You think, you believe I had something to do with Anna and Stan.

You don't know." I glared and smiled evilly at Hillary, extending my arms away from my sides, making sure to encompass each and every pathetic one of them. "But you will."

He threw open the door, screaming my name all the while. The vertigo that was just forming wrapped behind him.

"No!"

All those who were in my sight, within close proximity—

"No!" The word echoed into the next world.

We all stand in flux. The bland walls grow wallpaper, the computers become fixtures. The carpet a hardwood floor, and the skylight a plasticine ceiling. They all stand in complete bewilderment. We are in the Black Room, on the third floor.

"Sit. Relax." Many do as instructed, Sandy and Hillary don't. Neither does Rick, he's standing only a few meters from me looking around the room. "I would listen if I were you. I rule here and if the sun sets, you are all committed here forever." They sit.

I pace the room, my hands folded behind my back. "Now, what am I to do with you people? I can't let you go back. You'd all blab and I know how none of you can keep a secret." I glare at Hillary, fear is starting to take hold. She cowers into her chair.

"Is this where you took Anna?" She asks looking to Sidney who only nods.

"Yes, she's here somewhere. Anna! Your friends from work are here for a visit. Why don't you come and say hello."

Out of the wall by the fireplace, she comes out. Her naked skin is more badly burned this time. Blood and pus oozes from her wounds, running down the length of her leg. But she is still smiling, enraptured, that's all that counts. She walks to me, I put my arm around her.

“Are they treating you well?”

“Yes, very well.” She smiles to the group.

“Anna!” Rick rises from his chair and runs toward me.

“Stay seated!” I point my finger at him. He stops dead and slides across the floor into his chair. Anna strides over to him, straddling him. He reels back, disgusted.

“Don’t you love me anymore? Don’t you want to be with me forever?” She nuzzles his ear, he pushes her away, she falls to the floor, her skin folding under her buttocks.

“Always a man,” she cackles, bounding off to me. “You’ll love it here, darling, I promise.” She whispers in my ear,

“Isn’t it time?”

The sun is setting.

“What are you going to do with us?” One who’s name I never learned yells.

“Show them darling.”

The chairs under four of them open up, they are pulled screaming between the seat and the back. The sound of their bones crackling resounds throughout the room. Four are left; Rick, Sandy, Sidney, and Hillary. Sandy gets up and runs, grabbing Sidney’s arm along the way, she only nods. To Sandy: Her body expands beyond its already tremendous girth. She blows up like a balloon. Sidney tries to break free of her grip but can’t. Sandy’s flesh is scattered around the room; one of her arms, the nails on one hand sharp as blades, cuts three-quarters of the way through Sidney’s neck leaving her spine intact—she forever nods.

“We’re in hell!” Hillary exclaims. “May God save me! Save me, my Lord!”

“No need to pray, you’re in God’s Kingdom.”

A light radiates from all directions, from an unspecified source. It becomes brighter and all consuming. It shoots into Hillary. I can hear her innards searing from the heat, the light burns through her, poking perfect circles; the light then exits and she vanishes in a wisp of smoke, her screams of eternal anguish reverberating through the halls.

Rick, fear stricken, bolts out of the room and into the hall. He runs up and down the floors, ducking into the Green Room, the Yellow Room, the Blue Room, the Red Room; his terror captures him by the study, increases as he leaves the library and billiard rooms, constricts him as he exits the conservatory and has his soul by the time I meet him as he passes by the Brown Room. I know he's seen Anna's adultery in the Green Room and Tracy's lifeless grinning face as she hangs from the ceiling in the Bay Room. His eyes are wide and his mouth gaping, his temperament is that of a cornered cat, its tail pinched in a door.

"Get," he snarls. "Get away."

I look to see the evening approaching, shadows casting long fingers over the floor.

"Accept your fate, my friend..." I smile. Anna's laugh echoes. He clenches his fist and hits me in the jaw, knocking me to the floor. He pulls me up and hits me again, I taste blood in my mouth, the iron assaulting my tongue. He's got ahold of me with one hand and repeatedly hitting me with his fist, his arm, his elbow; I am pushed toward the spiral staircase railing. I can feel the smooth banister pressing into my back. The thing jumps on his back and clamps its teeth into Rick's back. It wails in the spirit of the fight. Rick pays little attention and he hits me again and again. He is spewing profanities, his hatred manifested in violence. In one motion, he

shoves me almost all the way over and throws the thing from his back, its form hitting the wall with a resounding thud. I at once become concerned for the poor creature, my friend in the maelstrom. I care little for myself but am hell-bent for revenge. The shadows are making their way across the floor and are almost to his feet. I struggle with Rick, but I am weak, he has hit me too many times for me to resist any further. He picks me up, hits me one last time, and sends me over the railing.

I'm falling. Looking at the ceiling full of mosaics. I see one floor, then the second, then the third. I don't think the carpet on the ground floor is going to catch me this time. I see Rick's face full of satisfaction, feeling as if he's killing off the 'evil force' of the house. Dreaming he's won some sort of immortal battle waiting to claim the laurels of his victory. He doesn't understand—doesn't understand anything.

I hit the floor, the sharp snap not coming from the wood floor but from my own back. Pain engulfs then subsides, I cannot feel anything. I am helpless, mute, in shock.

I see in my haze, Rick pointing and laughing, but he will know the bitter taste of his victory. The shadows have reached him, I see a red-velvet rose fall at his feet. He looks casually at it. Figures grab his by the ankles and pick him off the floor. He is carried back to the Brown Room.

His screams, his terror filled screams resonate, they are only masked by the sound of shattering glass, his mass striking the grounds outside. I can see him now, hear him thinking his last thoughts; how he's wished he'd never been my friend...wishing he'd never taken me in...wishing he'd never insisted on the job...and wishing he'd never known me at all...

Silence.

* * * * *

I lay in the enveloping darkness. My spine is shattered, my entire body numb. My heart beats feebly in my chest. I know if I go back to reality, I will be a cripple—if I manage to survive at all. There isn't much for me, I've lost everything; the cost paid by confidence in a friend.

In the creeping blackness I see Anna. She is as she was, when I first met her—wearing blue jeans, tan shirt, long thin brown hair and deep brown eyes. I see Tracy too—her glowing blonde hair caressing her shoulders. They kneel over me.

“Be with us, you don't need to go back now. There's nothing for you there. All your family, all the ones you can truly trust are here. We are dead.”

The figures, my true friends, huddle around me. Their small faces filled with concern and admiration...and love. The thing, solemn-faced, stumbles over and sits next to me, nuzzling my ear.

My fate has been decided for me and I have decided my own fate. It is a goal I have worked for and it is a goal that has, ultimately, consumed me. I conjured the thing to remind me of my destiny. It is not a product of some malevolent power, it is the product of my hatred. I have lost humanity, whatever that implies, and have but only one decision.

I accept.

My wounds are healed. My spine knitted. Feeling returns to every part of my body. I rise, standing erect, powerful.

I have been here an immeasurable time. I've seen the days turn to night and the months turn to years. I see the outside world I once called reality through a looking glass, watching those among

the living. And when it suits me, I bring them here and give them the tour while they dream. It is the extent of my power, the only amusement I can find, it is what I have become.

Whatever name I had before is lost, a triviality erased by the dismal abyss of this structure. I am Daragin now—Master of the Black House.

Life in the Real or the Transformation of a “Normal” Person Through the Void of an Enigmatic Existence

The DAY has passed.

It rolled in and over me, tearing my mind apart and jostling my benevolent body as a rag doll in a child's hands, leaving me with a head full of fog and a quivering composure. She sat next to me, and after giving me a look of seduction, sex and apathy, asked for the fifth time if she could drive. I repeated what I had been saying on every click of a mile, on every hour of the night.

“No.”

I had really only known her six hours—it seemed like longer, perhaps twelve, but then again I had been on the road near four hours; time viewed from behind the wheel can sometimes become distorted, sort of like driving through a long tunnel black as pitch—with blinders attached. She might have been my last girlfriend, a friend’s girlfriend, a shared girlfriend, a woman pressing a lawsuit for my ill behavior, or a woman I didn’t even know.

I wish to say I am not the kind of man who consciously chooses to immerse himself in self-credible or “occult-based” thoughts. I’d rather have no part of it. In fact, I like to think as little as possible, what with the world the way it is, if one is inclined to think about it, he would eventually drive himself crazy. So, in the interests of staying on my side of the fence, of not keeping myself shut off from the world, my friends, family and whatever, I find it best not to ponder—no matter what the circumstances. Though friends say to be an artist, a writer, you have to ponder, I’ll stay out in the light of life instead of shutting myself out—like most artists seem to do. And if I have to compromise, I’ll refuse the art, the ability, and the madness.

I was, however, never certain of the prospects of life, never certain of my position and my place, and powerless to act on my inhibitions.

Earlier in the evening, before I agreed to drive her to San Ramon, we had some drinks, a little food, heavily caffeinated sugarless sodas and generous amounts of concentrated powdered stimulants. My mind was keen, my body was jelly; she grinned from ear to ear and talked of her life in long phrases, the words turned sentences jammed themselves into my ears.

Earlier than that, before the arduous, godforsaken journey began, I met her at a sleazy pool hall—a place where all the lazars, losers,

no-lives, stoners, slammers and tweakers gathered—it might have been pure comedy if I hadn't realized fifteen minutes into our stay that I knew somebody there. I wanted to laugh but only hacked dryly which sounded more forced than accidental. She seemed amused.

Even earlier than that, I had my ear filled by another friend. Apparently he was in the midst of an emergency; a desperate, personal crisis was at hand. The world had fallen in, the pressure on his brain was critical, the stress would kill him at any moment. It was at times like this he chose to channel the crux of his annoyances onto the path of least resistance, to someone else, someone who was close and an easy target. And I was the chosen target this day. I had told him a couple of nights ago, as we were having beers, that if he needed anything, I would be glad to help him out just because we were friends, because I valued his company. He decided to cash in on the proposed favor. But as I heard his girlfriend in the background pleading with him to take her to San Ramon—a small, fairly pleasant town in the hills above the Bay Area, a distance well over a hundred miles—I had caught myself thinking twice about having made the promise in the first place, this favor was beyond the call, stretched beyond its limits. A “normal” person wouldn't...but I was a man of my word, one to live up to my responsibilities and to let friends down as infrequently as possible. I had to figure the time involved getting to San Ramon, one literally had no idea after considering all the variables of traffic, construction and weather that lay in the stretch between the valley and there. After offering me all the pleasantries, and setting up me as the officially sponsored ride, the officiator of good faith that he was requested if I could fulfill the task. I smirked and tried to back out of it—if there was any way

to, I had to find it without letting him down. I told him I already gave at the office.

“Hey, this is important,” he thinly pleaded.

I was sure it was, she was near tears, sniveling and whining. She was probably on her knees, which made for an interesting mental picture. I remembered it used to work on him, years ago. Now he was bored and tired of her—now he was immune.

I wished I had been so brazen, and not caught myself in a trap of my own design.

“Come over and we’ll talk about it,” he said. And why not? I was a patronizing guy in need of a good shafting—no lube of course. He was really going to go forward with it, and throw my promise into my face, if it came to that. Every part of me screamed not to go, but being a mediocre writer and adventurer, this could be fodder for creativity. If I only had known.

When I arrived, I came to realize it was a fine performance, one that required tens of minutes of rehearsing; she stood so close to me I picked up a mixed scent of perfume, sweat and fresh, stagnant sex on her. It made me think of my parents’ waterbed, my ex-girlfriend Lisa, her sister, several rolls of film, a box of condoms, a jar of honey, my cat Sam and two meters of twine. Lisa and her sister said it was kinky, I thought it was weird.

“Please,” she whimpered, “I need to go see my son, it’s been months.”

I watched her shuffle over to the fireplace and stick her face close to the fire. “I’m so stressed,” she said at last. “My mother’s going to take him away from me and I’ll have no one in the world—no one at all.”

That must've meant her boyfriend didn't count; he glared at her, mouthed 'not my kid', made obscene masturbating gestures and went off to the kitchen. After the sound of him rifling frantically through cabinets echoed through the house, he came back with a lone, helpless Ho-Ho and messily devoured it. His blank face was smeared with cream filling.

I gazed at the fire seeing the flames lick the blackened bricks. I pictured myself as a brick, the girl as the fire, and my friend as the mortar holding me in place. My good-natured, naive urge to help people being defaced by the flames. I wished I never saw the fireplace, or the girl, or my friend. I only had one prevailing thought...I wished I listened to myself and still lived in obscurity in the city, without friends, without colleagues, and without problems.

And before all that happened, I was resting quietly in my room, the walls a wash of tan and white, the ceiling a glimmer of specks, the insides of my eyes a kaleidoscope. My stomach wrenched, my appetite non-existent, insomnia overtaking, the cause of which unrenowned to me. When the phone rang, every fiber of my being chorused I not answer, that it would be certain death, the gun with a single bullet in the chamber aimed at my head. I smiled and opened my eyes, gazing at the phone, the receiver nearly jumping out of its cradle into my hand.

The clap of fire, the projectile lodged in the fall wall after passing through unshielded flesh. An aroma of gunpowder hung heavy in the air.

II

The highway leaped out before me, crouching into curves, tucking itself under bridges; sodium lamps screamed orange streaks casting eerie shadows on her expressionless face.

I used to toy with the idea I was losing my mind, but I had given it up years ago, after seeing what an emotionless bastard I had become—I had no choice but to. I hated myself. And almost died at my own hands. I had put all that negativity away, far away, where I could never find it. I blocked everything, and denied everything; slowly I had become a better person, more human. And now the muck was being stirred, feelings dredged up from the bottom of the black pool I was so afraid of. The old glove of assimilation into the void, was upon me. But why toy? Why even worry about it? Why fight it? Just admit to the fact I had lost it. Why spend so much energy prolonging the inevitable? I mean, here I was, exactly where I didn't want to be, with her, in my car, on the road, to a destination of great unimportance. I had lost the capacity for rational, reasonable thoughts indicative of self-preservation. I must have been out of my noodle. I had broken a branch in the hierarchy of the Tree of Life and fallen a great distance—all fingers pointed, all eyes stared, all faces laughed—I had to be insane.

“What are you thinking?” She asked callously.

“Oh, nothing.” I said and pulled the car hard into a curve, hoping the ditch would find me.

“Sure?”

“Well, no, that's a lie. But if you must know, I'm pondering...driving, flying, crawling, leaning; swallowing, spitting, chewing, licking; twisting, turning, spinning, whirling...Lisa, Bethany, Lyle and Oreos; breasts, buttocks, hemorrhoids and vices; a friend, an enemy, his wife and my car; life, death, lust and the Japanese...Dinah, Hiela, Maria and herpes; sex, fucking, love and inconveniences; high, low, never and a memory lapse; amphetamines, depressants, a bore and what I need right now.” In my mind I had said it all, and with-

out rehearsal. But my lips would have no part of it. If I let her know anything about me, then, she could manipulate her brilliant discoveries. She would incessantly keep her wandering eyes fixed upon me, looking for more worldly information in a vain attempt to familiarize herself with my psyche. And I was having a difficult time as it was remaining enigmatic, it was all I could do to keep from sliding completely into the seat.

...She sits next to me, her eyes on the road, her eyes on me...I'm finding it difficult to discern my erratic high from reality, I can't distinguish which is fact, which is fiction, and which is pure illusion. I look at her, her eyes meet mine. I follow the curves of her body: long, tangled brown hair, thin eyebrows, large hazel eyes, small nose and lips: her chin, her neck, her shoulders and breasts, her waist, hips, pussy, and legs...I fantasize...I see a movie of us having sex together...

But the sight of my friend pumping steadily into her awakes me, discarded shimmering silver Ho-Ho wrappers litter his bedroom floor.

...Later:

Near eleven, my thoughts slow, I shut the car off in a parking lot. She laid rails and I became the 10:53 Express, leaning to check my reflection. She decided on swallowing rather than breathing and winced as it went down. I wished to smile but found I couldn't, the phantom grin permanently wiped from my face. At 5:30 she was cute, at 7:00 she was adorable, at 9:15 she was naked, breasts perking out, her fingers probing between her legs; at 9:16 I purposely slammed my head into the door glass. At 10:00 she was irritating, at 10:20 I wanted to strike her, at 10:40 I wanted to choke her, at 10:45 I wanted to kill her and at 10:54, I loved her.

The sway of emotions, the turpitude of my thoughts and fantasies, didn't surprise me as much as the erection in my pants. I looked down at myself and was perplexed at what I saw—this odd bulge—it couldn't have been for her, I wasn't even attracted to her. She was plain, banal, dispassionate, and patronizing. It must have been from running on high octane, on pure reaction, on instinct, on fear.

"I like your hair," she said solemnly, trying to strike up a conversation. Not much had been said in the last hour. I had gotten used to the purr of the motor, the slipstream of the wind, the growling of the road pounding into my head. I had worked myself into a daze; a scenario: after a great cataclysm, after total annihilation of the earth and its components, I was the only soul left in the world, damned to pay for the sins of a wanton life by (endlessly) driving to a non-existent destination. And she was a figment of my imagination, the only company I could muster in the plight of my (doom, situation). And I was fond of talking to my imagination, believing it could manifest itself outside of my head. And apparently it had. So, with a complete blank on my face and a constant monotone in my voice, I nodded and replied with a proper,

"Thanks."

"That's a nice ring too. Can I see it?" The projection asked. I held my hand to its face, the gold caught the glint of the night.

"A gift?" > > "Yes." > > "Nice." > > "Thanks." > >

"From who?" > > "A friend." > > "Girlfriend?" > >

"I can't say." > > "Can't or won't?" > > "I really have no idea."

Silence. The banter waned. My imagination was staring to lose cohesion—to lose its imagination. I was desperately disappointed. The drive was endless.

In San Ramon:

Into town, up hills and down hills, around curves, dips, and inconsistent pavement surfaces. I was impatient and had been for the better part of sixty miles. Her directions were a maze of pernicious angles, disorganized and skewed, related to me in a tone that included questions she asked of herself: where the hell was she taking us, it's late and maybe her mother's asleep, what street was that, are we in the right town, she wanted to make it up to me on the way back, and she was lost.

I was thinking of what my friend told me before I left with her.

"Expect her to say, 'I'll make it up to you'. If she does (and she probably will), be sure you cash in before you drop her off—or else you'll see nothing of her promise. Oh, yeah, most importantly, play on her a little, she'll kick down, promise or not."

"Nah," I said. "She's YOUR girlfriend."

"She not MY girlfriend, just my Ho."

Like whore, harlot, skank, sleaze, Ho, or prostitute; like Ho-Hos, like the way the cream filling was lodged into the corners of his mouth. I, like the crumpled silver wrapper peeking out of the fingers of his clenched fist, screaming to be let free.

"But, you know, she has the tightest pussy. Even after pumping out a kid. You've got to find out."

Sighing heavily, I turned my back on him wondering why he had so little respect, so much anger, hatred and malice toward the small female. If I hadn't learned it then, I was to find out very soon. The had been trap baited and the prey snared; all that remained to be done—skin and devour the poor beast.

The truth was becoming painfully obvious. No sense denying it any longer. I wanted to...ahh...I wanted to...to...to...I want to...my

erection throbbed. It wouldn't go away. Hopefully she won't take notice. But, as precaution, I should have brought condoms.

But I didn't and that's good, it'll insure I remain unaffected by her, never mind all that. At any moment, I'll calm down. Let it be said, I have absolutely no intention to fuck her.

Could probably buy condoms at the liquor store we just passed, they always have a good supply of them.

"Not now or never," I whispered to myself.

Pretty cheap too.

I have better taste than that and I'm broke, besides HE had sex with her, Mr. Single-Speed with Reverse going out. And she LIKED it, she wanted it, and probably ANTICIPATED it. No way I could share the same space with HIM, I shudder at the thought, at the pictures in my brain. If I could only make myself physically sick, that would convince her I wanted nothing to do with her.

Although she's not bad to look at, even if her hair is a fright.

STOP IT!!

I sighed and felt a sudden silence in my mind, the facilities causing calamity in me shut down; quaint, piquant, aloof, nice. Even my imaginary girlfriend riding shotgun was silent, still. I breathed a sigh of relief. I thought back to my relaxing insomnia in my room at home and took reverie in the moment of retrospect. Calm. Peace. Passivity. The first time since...

Fluorescent ones only \$1.69 for a three pack...

"There it is!" She screamed, bouncing up and down while pointing out the window as if she were fourteen and looking into the monkey house watching the primates inspect their genitals. "Park here."

I pulled to the curb.

"Not here, down there. Somebody else parks there."

I bet they do.

“Now, here’s the story.” She turned and gave me details on what I was supposed to know and what I didn’t know. This sort of thing is usually labeled deception but too many hours and too many miles had passed, I couldn’t care less. Too much information had been input. Too many reactions. Too much stress, anticipation and anxiety. Shutdown had commenced.

But somehow, somehow I managed enough thoughtfulness to help her out of the car and to the front door; my noble reward a stumble over a hose the father of the child had left lying on the sidewalk.

Tripe details of our visit to her mother’s and the eye-wrenching, tear-jerking reunion of her and her son are hereby omitted. Save the father was nowhere to be found. And the mother was about as agreeable as a cat about to take a bath. Oh, yeah, everybody—except the two year-old—was on some sort of drug or another.

Okay, one sentence, fourteen words. An impression of the whole ordeal:

The only item I learned was that I should have less respect for her.

III

While driving, a lifetime could have expired.

Sometime during the small hours of the morning, on the trip back to the valley, she started speaking. I wasn’t sure if I had heard right, I was lost in the vacuous expanse that was once my mind.

She asked about love. > > I told her what I thought about it. > > She asked me how serious I get with a woman. > > I told her what I thought. > > She asked if I ever fell in love would it always be. > > I told her

what I thought. > > Was it deep? Was it passionate?
Was it obsessive? > > She knew the answer.

She paused, as if she were afraid of her next question; the silence a prickled cushion making even me nervous.

“Would you think about being in a relationship with me?”

I smiled and nodded but gave no response. I could’ve lied, could have spent the time fabricating a wonderful, poetic line as my friend inevitably had, but I knew my eyes wouldn’t be able to pull it off.

IV

It was daylight, the sun was lazily beaming through the clouds; I stopped before a house she wanted to be let off at. I was exhausted and had to get home, back to my room where I could be alone and think and meditate—my manners were nowhere to be found. She made motions like she wanted me to walk her to the door, as if I should attempt to cash in on that promise. I thought to but it remained as such, my body would not move.

“Well, I...” she started to say.

“Goodbye.” I sat, my eyes staring out the windshield. Her face in a pathetic pout, a disdainful frown, a devastating disappointment. Certain to cause great change in her, she would alter her ways so that she might be with me, to get herself up to my standards—right. That is a laugh, a joke, a spit into the face of human, a kick in the ass to the continuity and ability of life to sustain and replicate itself. Ironically, I had no standards and fell for just about everything that became available to me. But not this one, not in any lifetime. I knew too much about her although we had not spoken. I knew the ins and outs of her although we had not touched. I knew the fabric of her being without compromise, without prejudice, and without objectivity. She faded away, her face as indistinguishable as the

highway in the fog I had just traversed. The door slammed and I put the accelerator to the floor, not once looking behind me.

The DAY has passed.
Seconds to minutes to hours gone
A day never to have known
What hopes, what desires
Time being a thief.
Tis the NIGHT now.
Time to reflect, time to solace
My aching head and body
Time to find a quick resolve
That offers immediate pleasure.

My friend phoned and asked if I had indeed fucked her. I didn't answer him, not even wishing to speak to him, limiting myself to only thinking about it. Wondering absolutely nothing, wishing for naught; time spent viewing things in a less productive light.

I sat back and thought long and hard about what I had done and what I had allowed to happen to me. Let it be known, I had the absolute control of a deaf-mute over my environment. I had set me up and thrown myself to the whims of random chance, not my friend, not the guy who I thought should catch hell for setting the events in motion. In my own recently acquired fucked up way, I had cleverly masked my emotions, my desires, and my perceptions—all in the journey to some sort of enlightenment the Buddhists call nirvana. I had created a screwy cast of characters and analogous relations to better answer the questions of why: why I had kidded myself, why I had become disturbed, perhaps obsessed with present and past events, and why the whole affair had such a profound effect on me. The girl served as the curious side of me, my erection as

my limitations, the stimulants my way of altering reality and the Ho-Hos...well, I'm still not sure where those things fit into this whole mess. Do I blame myself? Do I pity myself? Do I hate myself? Do I think this changed me? No, no, uncertain, and maybe for the good but more for the bad.

But. . .

Glad the DAY is gone.

The adventure a wash

Clear memory now a peek through dirty glass. . .

No regrets. Not now or never. I wish to hide away, to be with myself, to impregnate my creativity, to birth a new me, and to disappear. Perhaps to a place unknown to even me. That's about it, I guess. Oh, yeah, to be more selfish, that would be nice, and to obsess even more on introspective thoughts. The comforts of which are invaluable and without horizon.

The Electric Cipher

I moved into the house on Cappuccino at the beginning of June. I was greeted by two people—a man and a woman—who assured me that the landlord would not ask any questions if I decided to move into the house, they had told him I was a “friend” and left it at that. I had known Frank eight months, we had met in the hospital; we weren’t necessarily friends but our company made the experience we had together bearable.

My room was in the back, an addition hastily slapped onto the rear of the house to accommodate another bedroom, to create another renter. Although I hadn’t met the landlord, I had a feel for where his priorities were; immediately I sensed I wouldn’t like him very much, if at all. But as long as I paid my rent and he left me alone, then things would be fine. There would be no conflict. No reason to get upset. And I couldn’t afford to become upset. I had come to the peninsula to relax from the stress of the city, where my job had taken its toll on my nerves; my patience was shot, but at least I had attained enough in disability grants—a post office box served as an address for the checks—to support myself for at least

six months or longer without doing any work. When the six months were up, then I could reapply if the problems were not resolved. I considered what I found myself in a blessing.

That night Frank, Marian, and I sat on the living room floor; I talked, they smoked pot. It was a housewarming, a newly kindled friendship gathering bent on promoting the good in us. I felt warm and secure.

“So what are you going to do now that you have the time?” Frank asked me.

“I don’t know,” I told him. “Maybe do a little writing. I’ve always wanted to since I was a kid, and I never had the chance. And since I seem to have nothing better to do.”

Marian laughed. She sat cross-legged on the floor, close to Frank. If I hadn’t known better, I would have thought she was Frank’s girlfriend. She was nice to look at: brown hair, brown eyes, fair skin, medium height, thin. She almost looked native American, but I wasn’t certain. If she was sleeping with Frank, I wasn’t sure why. He was overweight, had a bad complexion, and looked as if he needed a shower just after stepping out of one.

“Sounds like a good idea. More power to you.” He said.

Marian passed the joint to me. I smirked and handed it to Frank. She eyed me carefully, perhaps seductively, but I wasn’t in the right frame of mind to make a correct observation.

“You don’t smoke?”

“Used to, but now it would only interfere with my medication.”

“Medication for what?” Frank asked.

“Nothing important.” I smiled, hoping it would answer the question. It didn’t seem to, so I added: “Something to help me relax.”

“I see.” Marian said.

The evening waned. I was tired and didn’t feel like being around people any longer, but I had to be polite about an exit. I didn’t want to disturb the newfound “good feeling” we were experiencing.

“Look guys, I’m a little tired, and I still have to rearrange my room. Thanks.”

They shook their heads and I left them. I passed Frank’s room; the door was open a crack and I saw no furniture inside—not even a bed—only scattered piles of clothes. I pulled the door shut and looked down the hall. Frank and Marian were laughing between coughs. I thought to turn back, sit with them and spend the remainder of the evening conversing; instead, I walked into my room and shut the door behind me. My room was a shambles. I stood gaping at the disarray before me—a definite mess. No sense in trying to arrange anything; I practically had no furniture either, I had left it all in the last house. All I’d managed to take was a futon mattress and a stack of plastic milk crates that I could make a bookshelf out of. I put a couple of books away, stacked some clothes, unfolded the mattress, and lay down. The room was carpeted and warm; I would have to get a fan to keep it cool, to at least make it bearable. It was warm, so warm, almost too warm to sleep, but it was quiet, and that was a plus. Who knew what was going to happen at this house, but so far I felt okay with it. The diamond silver and black carpet proved to be interesting. I let my eyes wander over the pattern, it was the solace my brain needed to put me to sleep.

* * * * *

“So what are you going to do?” She asks me.

“I really have no idea.”

I am sitting with her in a coffee shop by the beach; the day is overcast and dreary, it is perfect irony.

“Are you going to live up to your promises?”

I look at her, tufts of red hair falling into her eyes. She is pretty while being unattractive. Maybe I’d had a good relationship with her, maybe we had been in love, maybe could have spent our lives together, but that’s all past now.

“I can’t, you know, I need some time to myself.”

“You’re flaking out of it, aren’t you? Do you know how much that hurts me? I don’t think you do. I have tried and tried with you. I tried to take care of you as best I could, but it’s not enough for you.”

I put my fingers around my coffee cup, the heat pressed into the palms of my hands.

“My father reserved the hall, and I shelled out nearly \$5000. You said only two months ago you still wanted to get married, now you’ve changed your mind...again.”

“Things have changed, I’ve had a hard time.” She never knew what I went through, how I felt.

She leans over the table and brings her face close to mine.

“I’m going to make you hurt for what you did to me. Really hurt, so you can feel like I do.”

“Don’t listen to her, she doesn’t know real pain like you do.” A voice whispers quietly, distantly, in my ear. I look in the direction of it and see a tall, thin man in an olive green suit and tie. He is sitting at the table next to us. His clean-shaven face is very long and his complexion dark. He has a frothing latte on the table before him, it spills over the rim of the glass. His glowing green eyes glance at her and then fix on me. I turn back to her and smile.

“You don’t need her,” he says. “She never loved you, she knows she can’t get anybody else.”

He gets up and puts his hand on my shoulder. His lips are close to my ear.

“I can show you real love.”

* * * * *

I shook myself awake. The room was dark. I cocked my head, all my senses awake, sensitive—I heard the slightest sounds, felt the faintest movements. Frank and Marian were in the room next to me. I could hear them having sex; someone’s ass was squeaking on the hardwood floor. At once I was sickened by the sound, it rang in my head. I placed my hands over my ears, but it did no good. Their breathing became louder and louder—Marian was panting and Frank was moaning. Almost as soon as the noises began, they stopped. I calmed myself and suddenly found what was going in the next room hilarious. I wished to laugh out loud, but I regained control. The sounds nearly ceased, became barely audible—I found I missed their absence. I knelt at the head of the mattress, on a stack of pillows, and set my ear to the wall so that I might hear.

About an hour later, I managed to get myself back to sleep and woke again late in the afternoon. The house was empty. I showered, washing myself of the oily residue on my skin—stale sweat from the dreams I’d had. I wasn’t sure if what I’d heard in my roommates’ room was real, it could’ve been part of my imagination. Time to focus on reality. I shook off the haze and popped open a sugary soda from the fridge. I had to go to the university today to see an old friend who was lecturing there, Steve Sanderson. He had come to see me while I was in the hospital after my breakdown in the lab. He told me if I ever needed to talk, to come on by. I felt it was time

to take him up on his offer. I knew I should probably go to see my therapist too, she had said if I started to have dreams about Judy, I should make an appointment. But I felt okay, although a little queasy. I'll survive.

Steve was in his office when I arrived. He greeted me, then offered me a seat.

"Haven't seen you in a while, Darrin. How have you been?"

"Okay, I guess. Moved into a new place. I'm in Burlingame."

"I heard. Nice there?"

"Yeah, I suppose. If you like suburbia."

"Did you want to talk about something? I have a class in twenty minutes and I need to review my lecture."

"I just wanted to see an old friend."

He laughed and tapped his pencil on his desk. "Here I am, you feel better?"

I laughed. "I don't know, had some disturbing dreams last night, can't make anything out of them."

"Maybe you should see that psychiatrist, that's what they're paid for."

"I don't like those headshrinkers, they play one huge mind game. Besides, she has this patronizing way of telling me things are all right. Know what I mean?"

He sat up in his chair. "No, I don't. You're the crazy one, remember? Sorry to cut it short but I've got to prepare. They've been cutting instructors again this year, listing those slated for redundancy, so I have to outshine my colleagues. It's a good thing you got out when you did, seems the whole place is succumbing to capitalists who think education is a business. Well, you've got enough things going on right now, you don't want to hear about it."

I looked blankly at him. He sat back in his chair, gritting his teeth.

“Have they been harassing you, the government guys from the lab?”

“No, I haven’t seen or heard from them.”

“Good, as long as they don’t know where you live. Don’t tell Doc or that bastard Niles. She might relay the information, and he’ll snitch—he’s been jostling for a promotion once they get rid of enough of us.”

“Okay.”

“Sorry, I really have to get ready.”

“Okay. Thanks, Steve.”

He stood up to show me out, we shook hands, and I left his office. He called to me as I was walking down the hall.

“Give me a call, maybe I can persuade the wife to make dinner.”

I waved to him with my back turned.

I wandered around campus for the better part of two hours. It was bustling with students rushing in all directions. I was thinking someone might remember me, but nobody did. It had been too long. I’d only taught two classes for a few years, spending most of my time in the lab, and I hadn’t been that social, not even with the students. I walked by my old office in the Physics building, it was still vacant. I didn’t have the mood to drop by the lab, I was certain someone would recognize me. I did, though, stop by one of my favorite vending machines and purchased a soda, drinking it rapidly on my way down the hallway.

The library provided some comfort. I read through some foreign newspapers, sat in a comfortable chair, and thumbed through a Soviet-era treatise on nonlinear mechanics. A few chapters in, I

thought to check my email but gave up on the idea immediately. My mind couldn't focus on anything, not even the interesting material in the book. I found that as soon as I set myself in, I was staring out the window looking at the unkempt grass that had expansive patches of brown and small piles of dirt that looked like large anthills. A class streamed out from one of the buildings. It must've been an elective course, they stood in a circle and held hands—maybe it was one of the new “psychological freedom” classes the university was touting. I chuckled quietly, so as not to draw attention to myself; I knew how easily distracted the undergraduates were here, none of them very motivated. It was frustrating trying to lecture to them on topics of quantum mechanics or even the basics of linear algebra. Their attention span was analogous to that of a dog sniffing out the nearest hedge to urinate on. Maybe that was why I got sick of it and had to duck out for a while; I needed some time to myself, to recover, to regain my senses and to find some sort of norm, if there ever was such a thing. And it's not like the work had anything to do with what happened to me, more like the inability to pass between this world and the one which existed in my head.

I slammed the book closed. I was thinking too much again. As I left the library, I heard a voice calling from behind me. I turned and saw that it was Niles. Oh shit. I took a deep breath. Niles and I went back to my earliest days at the university, back when I was doing my postdoc. He and I both worked in the same laboratory but I knew he was stealing my work, publishing results as if they were his own. That work caught the attention of the university heads and they awarded him a prize for it, of course leaving me completely out of it.

“Darrin, guy, what's happening?”

He offered his hand, I kept mine in my pocket.

"I'm tired, going home."

"Where are you living now? The peninsula, I hear."

I stared blankly at him. "I'm not settled yet, not settled at all. Actually, I'm thinking about going north or maybe to Europe to pursue my research."

"Great to hear you are keeping yourself busy. The work goes well then? You're still doing it? I mean, in your private time?"

"Not really. But you know how it always persists."

"Definitely. Hey, you want to grab coffee? I don't have a class for another hour."

I frowned and shook my head. "Really, I'm sorry, but I'm very tired. Another time, perhaps." I turned away from him and managed a few steps as he continued.

"Donalسد's been asking about you, hasn't heard from you since you left the hospital. You should let him know how you are."

"I don't work for him, nor do I care." I continued walking in a quickening pace.

"Hold on," he ran to me and grabbed my arm.

"He does really care about you, just like the rest of us do. Look I heard what happened, with the experiment and the accident. I told Donalسد it wasn't your fault, I said that I helped you calibrate the machine."

"And they didn't fire you?" I looked at him with a contorted expression.

"No. They promoted me. That's how important the work is. Come back to the university, come back to the lab, come work again."

I shook his hand from my arm. “Not ready yet. Not now.” I stared walking again.

“It’s not so easy when people think you’re a genius. They know what you can do, they know the kind of machines you can build. They know you understand how to bridge this world with the quantum.”

I started walking faster, almost running.

“Just think about it. I’m here for you, man.”

I didn’t look back. When I got to my car, I hastily opened the door and slumped in the seat. It was just starting to rain. I set the radio to an oldies station and let the music echo in my head. I whispered to myself over and over,

I’m no genius. Just a regular guy. I don’t know anything...

The rain came and went, then the sun came out. Evening was approaching and I realized I had spent at least two hours sitting in the car. The evening fog was rolling in, the temperature dropping; it was getting cold almost to the point of shivers, but I left the window down anyway. I couldn’t command my body to move, for it might disturb the tranquil state I was trying to get myself in. Relax, I had to relax, the pressure was trying to mount me, trying to take over my mind. So they want me back, huh? Back to the lab. I don’t think so. I’ve seen enough to know I don’t want to set foot inside the place. I had thought to destroy it, but they had found me out too soon, before I could do any damage; they said I was hysterical, mumbling incoherent things about some sort of this and that. They said I had gone through AND come back, unlike others who had met with a more violent end. No matter what, I’m NOT going back. I pounded my fist on the steering wheel until a sharp pain stung the bottom of my hand. Out of the corner of my eye I

could see some students walking by; they were watching me intently, the beady-eyed little bastards. Don't look over here, nothing to see.

* * * * *

I let a month pass before I decided to call Steve. He had seemed a little nervous about having me in his office; he wasn't sure what to do with me or how I might react, of that I was sure. I had to reassure him that my life was better. I told him I was settling into a new house with good roommates, the memories of Judy were getting further behind me, and the work at the lab a soon-to-be lost memory, more of an annoyance than anything else. Things were going along just fine; I spent most of my days walking around the neighborhood getting my bearings, occasionally driving south for a friendly dinner with Marian—she had asked me since Frank phoned saying he couldn't make it—and reading. No more physics, no more mathematics, just Dostoyevsky and Kant. I find a lot of truth in the latter, his thoughts are pure and clear, his language cutting a clearing through the wilderness of man's moral turpitude. Pure reason, something I can latch onto. Better than the sheer melodrama that was my old life.

Steve's wife, Daria, answered the phone. She had been a friend of Judy's. She was sorry things hadn't worked out between us. I didn't think she knew the extent of what had happened, although Steve did. She invited me to dinner the next Saturday, then handed the phone to Steve. Judging from the hesitation in his voice, I got the impression that the invitation he had extended to me while at his office was purely cordial without any intent of it actually happening. Sort of like an extension of his heart that didn't sit right with his logic. Emotion got the better of him, as he would say.

“Yeah, Darrin, if you are free to stop by Saturday evening, we’ll see you about...”

He cupped his hand over the receiver and yelled to his wife.

“She says around six-thirty, is that okay?”

“Fine. Are you still in the Marina?”

“Same place.”

“Okay. See you Saturday. Bye.”

I hung up and heard someone come in the front door. I left the kitchen and met Marian in the living room. She set down her purse on the coffee table and plopped down on the couch I had bought only a few days before. Since I had more money than they did, I didn’t mind buying furniture. She smiled at me.

“How was your day?”

“The usual.”

“Work was hell, my boss is such a jerk. He told me yesterday there was a screw-up and I might be fired over it, said there were these corporate types coming in to investigate. Turns out there was no screw-up. The suits were only there to tour the office.”

I shook my head.

“They say he’s going to quit or be transferred or something. Hope it’s soon. That was my day.”

I sat on the couch. She snapped the television on.

“I hope this doesn’t sound weird, Darrin. If you don’t mind me asking, how old are you?”

“Thirty-six.”

“Frank and I had a bet. I thought you were twenty-seven, he thought you were forty or older.”

“What a guy. Guess it’s because of the white in my hair.”

She gazed keenly at it, as if noticing it for the first time.

“Ahh, that’s why.”

“Why what?”

Her attention was drawn to the television. “Why he thought you were older than you are.”

Her eyes started to glaze over. I looked to the screen but didn’t know what program it was. She sat up on the edge of the couch and leaned toward me.

“Do you feel like having a bowl?”

“What? Oh, no, no I don’t.”

“You don’t mind if I do, do you?”

“No, go ahead.” She pulled a small box from her purse which contained a glass pipe. It was turquoise and its edges were smoothly rounded. Thin, white stripes ran through it making it look glossier than it was. She reached under the couch and pulled out a bag which contained her marijuana. Using her long nails, she pinched a chunk of bud and stuffed it into the pipe. She watched me, as I watched her, lighting the pipe.

“I really love this stuff,” she said while holding her breath. I don’t know what I’d do without it.”

She exhaled slowly, the musk of smoke tickled my nostrils. Her attention was back at the television.

“What are we watching?” She snorted. I turned my eyes to the screen. “I mean what is that guy doing?” She lit the pipe again, then ashed it in a small cup on the coffee table. “You know...” she said, “I can see you are a nice guy.”

The smoke seemed to have an effect on me. I was drifting away. “Okay.” I said not taking my eyes off the screen. She packed another bowl.

“Did you hear me?”

I snapped out of it. “Um, sure, nice,” drifting back again. She laughed. Time passed.

“I’m tired of watching TV. I’m going to take a bath.”

“Okay.”

She got up and I heard her slide into the tub some time later. The program ended and I casually flipped through the channels. I hated TV, it not only had a way of draining what was left of my brain, but also suppressing any new thoughts to refill it. I snapped it off and went into my room, leaving the door open. The new furniture in the room consisted of a frame for the futon, a real bookshelf, a desk, and a small wooden filing cabinet. I had few papers to put into the files; most of the writing I had done prior to my breakdown had disappeared—Judy had probably thrown it away. I sat at the desk and gazed at a pad of paper that had a few lines scribbled on it, much of nothing it was. I wanted to buy a typewriter, an old one, and maybe get back to the book I was working on before, but a non-fiction book on quantum physics in the realms of mysticism seemed too trite for me now. And owning a typewriter would be too intimidating, it would force me to work—the damned machine staring up at me, keys winking, stark white blank paper glaring. Better than writing on a computer, though.

“Darrin, could you come here for a minute?”

I get up from my chair. I think to shut the computer down, but I figure Judy won’t need to talk to me too long. She likes it when I walk in on her while she’s bathing or dressing; she says she likes having my eyes on her, staring at her vulnerability—her breasts floating in the bath, nipples firm.

“Do you find me attractive?”

“Yes.”

“Do you think I’m sexy here in the tub?”

“Yes.”

“What are you thinking about?”

“Making love to you...my hands around your throat.”

“Darrin...”

I rubbed my eyes. The pen was in my hand; I had drawn a series of skewed circles on the pad.

“Darrin!”

“Yeah.”

“Could you come here for a minute?”

It was Marian’s voice. I shook my head. I had been lost again. That smoke did a number on me.

“Be right there.”

When I got to the bathroom, she was standing before the mirror, wrapped in a towel.

“Are you doing anything Saturday night?”

“I’m having dinner at a friend’s.”

She combed her hair, peering through the steam on the mirror.

“Anybody I know?”

“No, you wouldn’t.”

“Oh, that’s too bad. I was hoping we could have another nice dinner together, like we did on Wednesday. Frank’s not going to be around.”

I pulled at my lip. “Are you guys going out or something? I’m not sure of the situation between you two. When Frank first mentioned the living arrangement, he said there was another roommate, but he didn’t say it was a girlfriend. So I don’t know.”

She looked at me. “How did you meet Frank?”

“I met him a couple of months ago, through a friend. Um...”

I stared into the mirror. I couldn't, for the life of me, remember who the friend was; in fact, I didn't remember meeting Frank at all. The memory of my life then seemed to be surrounded by an impassable thick cloud.

"What's wrong?"

"I don't know where or how I met Frank."

She seemed surprised and changed the subject; she went on about work again. I massaged my forehead, trying to think. Nothing.

"When did *you* meet Frank?" I asked her.

"We used to go out, a long time ago." She abruptly walked past me into her room.

"But we don't get along too well, that's why I have a separate room. In some ways we need each other, but we agreed to go out with others, although he's not too fond of me doing it."

I turned and looked into her room. She had left the door open, and by a mirror on the wall, I could see her dressing. The blank, it was still there. It was as if the knowledge of Frank had been implanted, because I couldn't remember the actual experience of having met the man. I felt very strange and found I was starting to worry.

"That's the way it is," she came out of her room patting her head with the towel. "If you can't make it Saturday, maybe we can do it another time."

"Yeah, maybe...maybe in a few days or so." I was starting to get a headache.

"Don't worry about it." She walked to me and kissed me on the cheek. I touched the spot, it was warm and moist from her saliva.

After lying in bed for nearly three hours, I managed to sleep fairly well, only one dream I could remember. It was of the man

who first appeared in the coffee shop. He and I were in the lab, on the bottom level. The walls were made of cinder blocks, they were painted, splashed with black. The paint had run; it had dried in pools at the bottom of the wall.

“Come on,” he said to me. “I have something to show you.”

I followed him, down a stairway that wound around a corner. The light was feeble; I could barely see, but I felt as if I knew where I was going.

“This is something that will shock the hell out of the world.” He smiled. “And fuck ’em if they don’t like it. We’ll shove it down their goddamned throats!”

We came into a room that was expansive. There was a single light in the center the room, illuminating a table. On the table lay a staff mounted into the top of a stone pyramid. A metal ring, shaped like a zero, was attached to the top of the staff. There were large generators behind the table, and an oblong circle was drawn on the floor. I knew what it all meant. I backed away.

“Take it easy, just one more experiment and we’ll be successful.”

“No, no, I...I...I can’t.”

His green eyes glowed vibrantly, he stretched his arms out toward me.

“You must...”

I shook myself from my sleep, to find daylight streaming in through my window. I sat up and the light of the sun caught my eyes. Alive! Alive again!

I went to the kitchen and put my hand on the phone. I thought of calling Doc; she had said if the dreams started again, I should call her. I could handle it. I survived. The dreams, they’re vivid phantoms screaming through my brain, revealing the atrocities of a

life gone un-recollected. I needed help, but not hers; she couldn't understand what I'd seen, how it had and will affect me and how it will all come to a climax where no one shall remain.

* * * * *

I arrived at Steve's house a few minutes after six. His wife was all smiles as she opened the door.

"Hi, Darrin. Come in."

Their flat looked just as I had last seen it, over a year ago. Nothing had changed: same furniture, same pictures, same family. Steve and Daria had been married almost nine years. I felt sorry for them having to live in the same place all that time, without any hope of ever leaving, but they were so comfortable in the familiar, with no taste for the extraordinary. Steve greeted me in the living room.

"Darrin, come with me." He grabbed me by my arm and led me into the hall. "I invited another guest for dinner, he says he knows you. I don't think you know him, but he works at the lab."

I yanked my arm away. "What?!"

"Take it easy, he's only been there a year. He started right after you left, so he doesn't know what happened. Besides, he's a friend of mine, so be nice to him."

I let out a long, quivering breath. "Okay, okay."

"He's really anxious to meet you. I talked to him after I saw you on campus. I thought since you were going to be here, you wouldn't mind meeting him."

"Yeah, I'll deal with it."

"Splendid."

He led me into the kitchen. He looked at his wife, who was putting the finishing touches on dinner.

“Where’s Sam?”

“In the bathroom.”

“Have a seat in the living room. Can I offer you anything? Soda?”

“No, thanks.”

I went and sat on the couch. There was a loose string of fabric on the arm; I tugged at it. There were sudden voices in the kitchen, one I thought I faintly recognized, neither Steve nor Daria, still familiar, from somewhere distant, like a voice carried on the wind. Then he came in.

He was tall, thin, his skin dark and his hair jet black. His eyes were a deep hazel, almost glowing; his pants were olive, his shirt black, buttoned to the top. I knew him in an instant. He was the man in the coffee shop dream and in the lab dream. I stared, frozen, with my eyes wide and my mouth open. He smirked and gave me a perplexed look.

“Darrin?”

His voice was exactly the same, down to the intonations, pitch, accent, and pronunciation. I couldn’t conjure a word or gesture to acknowledge him. He walked over and stood next to me.

“I’m Uncler, Sam Uncler.”

He extended his hand, and after a minute or so, I followed. My palms were wet. After we released, he looked at his hand, then at me.

“A little nervous, are we?”

He sat next to me.

“I’ve heard a lot about you back at the lab, you’re quite a celebrity, famous I might put it, been following your work. Now I have the ultimate pleasure of meeting you, the genius behind it all.”

I flashed a facetious grin at him. He pulled out a cigarette and put it into his mouth.

“Smoke?”

“I quit.”

“Oh,” he searched his pants and shirt pocket. “I hate it when that happens, I lost my lighter. Excuse me.”

He quickly got up and went into the kitchen. He walked over to the stove—I watched his every move as if anticipating the dreams to recur—he looked back at me and smiled. He flicked on the gas burner and bent over it, extending the cigarette over the flame. He looked at me again. I was still staring. He lifted the corner of his mouth as if to silently say something.

“Sam!” Daria yelled.

“Sam, if you needed a light, I have one.” Steve said.

“I got it. You have an ashtray? I don’t want ruin your couch. And I have your guest to talk to.”

He returned and sat next to me again—this time closer. He had a faint scent of cologne on him.

“Sanderson’s a great guy, all manners and British etiquette, Daria too. But you can’t know two better people. Don’t you think so?”

I resumed tugging the loose string on the arm.

“She’s making her specialty, Veal Parmesan, my favorite. Nothing like eating sick young cows. Makes you feel really alive, eating the misfortunes of those lesser than you. Superior, that’s the word I’m looking for, makes me feel superior.”

“Yeah.”

He was suddenly quiet. I could hear him taking long draws on the cigarette.

“You don’t say much, do you?” He said without looking at me.

I turned and gave him a surprised look. “What?”

“Silence, the absence of speech. You seem to have cornered the market on it.”

Daria dropped something in the kitchen. I looked up to see Steve running to her. Uncler was smiling, almost sadistically.

“She might need some help...” I started to get up. He put his hand on my leg.

“She’s a big girl, she can handle it. Besides, that’s what the husband’s for. Don’t worry about it.”

I sat back down slowly, eyed his hand on me; he retracted it.

“You feeling a little edgy?”

“Not really.” I looked at the string, but left it alone.

“Seems like it, it’s what your profile says.”

I glared hard at him.

“I’ve read it several times, you know, had to. Donalسد, Niles, Sanderson—they all say you’re dangerous, could go off at any second, like a powder keg, boom!” He made the motion with his hands. “But they insist despite that you’re an absolute genius. To me you just seem a little edgy, but that’s all—uncomfortable around strangers, anti-social and all that. I can understand. Ah, don’t worry about it, I’m the same, it’s the damn work at the lab. Can drive you up the wall, if you know what I mean, but I think you already do. That’s what the profile says, but my curiosity got the best of me, I had to see for myself. But you don’t strike me as the murderous type, not at all, you seem perfectly passive sitting in your little corner of the couch pulling on that damn thread. Perfectly passive.”

I looked blankly at him.

“Yes, your defense mechanism. Pretend you know nothing, good idea, it works for me, especially as far as the government’s concerned, but I’m not here to talk politics.”

“What are you here to talk about?”

“I think you know.”

Another blank expression. He shook his head.

“You’re the man behind the Cipher Experiment, the brain of the operation—I’ve spent the last year intently studying your work. I wanted to meet you sooner, but they wouldn’t allow me to see you at the hospital.”

Another blank expression.

“This is how we’re going to play it, huh? Fine, don’t say anything if you don’t want to. Hell, you probably don’t remember any of it, anyway. The profile says you’re a vegetable up here,” he tapped the side of his head with his finger, “and maybe they’re right, who knows? Only you do.”

He pulled at his lip; the cigarette burned between his fingers, smoke gently curled away. He took a long drag and snuffed it out in the ashtray on the end table. His gaze fixed with mine.

I get the distinct impression that you think you know me, but can’t place the face.”

“Maybe.”

“No bullshit. This is the first time I met you. Well, in person anyway, your reputation precedes you, you ought to be proud.”

“Really.” I looked at the string again. The temptation was too great; I started tugging at it—he noticed.

“Look,” he moved closer, put his hand on my leg again; he brought his face close to the side of my head. I felt his breath on my neck. “I know what happened at the lab.”

I snapped my head around and faced him. “You don’t know anything.” I relaxed and turned back to the string. “Don’t know anything at all.”

“Is that what you think? If so, you have grossly underestimated me.” He eyed my progress at nearly pulling the entire thread out. “But I do know one thing for certain, if you tear Sanderson’s couch apart, he’ll be upset about it.”

I cracked a smile. Steve walked into the living room.

“Dinner’s ready.”

Uncle and I exchanged glances, simultaneously got up, and walked toward the kitchen. He stopped me.

“Let’s try to be friends and we’ll go from there, okay?”

I nodded, and sat at the table; a plate had already been prepared for me. The veal was breaded, a thin tomato sauce covering it, a piece of cheese swimming in all of it—maybe floating. A bowl of noodles was beside the plate; they were cooked, but had no sauce. I wasn’t sure if I was supposed to pour the noodles over the plate, or scoop pieces of veal and soup into the bowl. I decided to wait and see what everybody else did. Uncle looked at me and smiled; he unfolded the napkin and placed it in his lap. I did the same, he nodded.

“Sanderson.” He stood up with a glass of red wine. “A toast, to Darrin. May this be the first day to lead to the rest of his life.”

“Here, here.” Steve and Daria raised their glasses. I had no wine, only water. I gripped my hand around the plastic cup and lifted it.

“Great.” Uncle drank deeply from his glass, then sat back down. No more words or glances were exchanged, and the rest of the meal was taken in silence.

I arrived home close to eleven; Marian was up watching television. Frank was nowhere to be found.

"How was your dinner?"

"It was okay. Nice to see friends."

"I wish I could get out once in a while. Frank never takes me anywhere."

"You should ask him to."

She laughed. "Yeah, right."

"By the way, where is he?"

"I don't know, he wasn't here when I came home, probably out with his white-trash friends. Out drinking beer, belching, farting, you know, all that male bonding nonsense."

I laughed and started to walk to my room. I thought of asking her about Samuel Uncler, but there was no way she could possibly know him. A nagging feeling told me to ask anyway, but I ignored it.

I got to my door and she yelled down the hall.

"What are you going to do?"

"Settle down and read, I think. Not much else to do. Too early to sleep."

There was silence, and I went to my room. The futon was comfortable. The room was warm from the heat of the day; I threw the window open and lay down. I had books, a lot of books, most of them unread. They had looked good in the bookstore; I'd bought them because they seemed interesting. Maybe someday I would like to read a particular author, and when I did, I didn't want to have to go through the agony of not having their work on hand.

I must've dozed off, a knock on my door startled me.

"It's Marian, you awake?"

I looked at the clock. It was well after one.

"Yeah, I'm awake. Come in."

She threw the door open and knelt on the bed. "I thought I heard something downstairs."

I rubbed my eyes and yawned. "We don't have a downstairs."

"Yes, we do. There's a cellar under this room."

"A cellar?"

"Come on." She pulled me off the bed and onto my feet. I followed her through the kitchen to the patio door in the back. She opened the door a crack.

"Listen, do you hear that?"

I looked around the yard, to the wooden fence that enclosed the grounds. There wasn't a sound.

"I don't hear..."

"Shhh..."

There was an indistinguishable sound of something crying. It was coming from under the wooden stairs below the patio door. Faint scratching echoed. She grabbed my arm.

"What is it?" She whimpered.

"It's probably a cat or something. There's a cellar under there?"

"Yeah, lift the stairs."

I went to a drawer and got a flashlight. Marian shrunk back and sat in a chair; her voice was quivering from fear.

"Oh, shit..."

There was more crying and scratching, now more fiercely. It sounded like someone or something was trapped in the cellar. I rifled through another drawer and pulled out a steak knife. I didn't know what good it would do, but it gave me a small amount of security.

It was dark outside—no light from the front of the house would illuminate the back—I flicked the switch for the kitchen light, but it was burned out.

“Go to my room and turn on the light.”

It did little good, it only cast shadows, since the cellar was around the corner from my room. Although I stepped as lightly as I could on the stairs, they creaked from my weight. The crying ceased. I stood before the stairs and placed my fingers under the edge of them; I looked at Marian.

“Straight up,” she whispered and gestured with her hands. I quickly pulled and the whole unit lifted up, hitting the wall hard and coming to a rest. The crying began again; it came in soft long cries and short sobs. My hands were shaking, making the light bob before me. I clutched the knife tightly.

Setting a foot on the first concrete stair, I started my descent. I had to duck, and I noticed the stairs curved around to the left.

“Great.” I couldn’t see the cellar without first rounding the narrow corner. I crept slowly, moving with the pitch of the cries—my instincts had taken over. I reached the corner and, shining the flashlight around it, peered into the depths of the cellar. The walls were painted black; the floor was moist, small patches of fungi growing out of the cracks. The walls were constructed of cinder blocks. I shined the light around and noticed it was silent. The room was small, not more than eight meters square. I couldn’t see anything, so I continued down the remaining three stairs. I was standing on the floor, my footing unsure; I found I was standing in a patch of fungi, the moisture soaking my socks. There was a water heater in one corner, a series of pipes overhead, and junk in

another corner. A small, overturned wooden box lay behind the water heater, a piece of plywood leaning against it.

The light went out.

“Great.”

I shook the flashlight as hard as I could, but it didn’t respond. I looked behind me. I was in pitch-blackness.

“Need a light?”

I freeze. It’s a familiar voice—too familiar.

A feeble light glows, increasing until I can see. Uncler is standing in the center of the room, holding a staff with an oblong-shaped piece of metal mounted to the top of it. His olive drab suit is electric; his hazel eyes shine emerald green. He has a wide grin on his face.

“Tired of the world bothering you, Darrin? Tired of them crying to you when they have problems? Tired of being blamed for everything? Even tired of getting all the credit?”

He extends his arm out and points to the wall. He turns the staff, illuminating the black blocks. Judy is chained to them. The handcuffs and length of chain holding her drip rust. She is struggling to get away; she is gagged, whimpering long, soft cries and short sobs.

“We did it once a short year ago, nothing’s stopping us from doing it again.”

He grips the staff tighter, and the light from the cipher glows to a blinding glare; a soft hum emanates. In the corner where I had seen the water heater, there is a generator; it is rocking violently, pumping out juice.

“So many places to see, so many people to meet.” He looks at me and extends his hand. “Come with me.”

I shake my head, my mouth open, drool trickling down the front of my shirt. He focuses on Judy; she is hysterically flailing herself, desperately trying to get loose from the bonds that hold her to the wall. Uncler leans the staff towards her; a flash of current comes out of the generator, and a rod of light shoots through the cipher. It penetrates Judy, she screams. The sound echoes in my brain.

“Darrin! Darrin!!”

I felt someone shaking me in the darkness of my mind. My back was moist, my skin saturated. I was too fear-stricken to open my eyes.

“Darrin, can you hear me?!”

The shaking: my head fell back and forth, striking the concrete. Slowly, slowly, fear dissipated and I wedged my eyes open. I saw Marian staring down at me.

“What the hell happened? First thing I know is you go around the corner, then the light goes out, I hear you scuffle with something, then nothing.”

She lifted me up and sat me on the bottom stair. She turned my face toward hers; dried foam was glued to my chin, and drool covered the front of my shirt.

“Oh my God, I didn’t know you were epileptic.”

I was regaining my senses, able to sit myself up. She took off her shirt and patted my face with it; she wiped away the grime, trying to clean me up.

“Jesus, I had no idea.”

The cry. I heard it again, like a far off echo of Judy screaming—I could see her body contorting, head twisting into odd shapes, face deformed, red hair falling out in large clumps. The cry—I heard it—is seared into my sickened soul.

“What the...”

Marian looked behind her, gripped the flashlight, and shined the beam into the corner. From behind the water heater, a cat slunk out. It cried sharply, then mewed softly. It’s coat was fire-orange.

“Oh,” she set the light down and picked up the cat. It purred in her arms and looked intently at me. It meowed.

“You must be hungry, huh?”

Her attention was focused on the cat. All of a sudden, she realized I was still incapacitated on the stairs.

“I’m so sorry, are you okay?” She knelt and looked into my eyes, searching for something.

“I’ll be all right. I told you it was a cat.”

I had her shirt in my hand. She had only her bra on, the cat tucked next to her small breasts.

“I’ll be fine.”

I showered. It was a long one, must have been an hour. The hot water relaxed my frazzled nerves. I put on my robe, went to the living room, and sat down; my head ached. Marian went to feed the cat in the kitchen. She opened a can of tuna; the animal purred loudly between bites.

“Marian.” I had to call her twice.

“What?”

“Do you have any cigarettes?”

“They’re on the table. I thought you didn’t smoke.”

“I don’t. But I *need* one.”

I inhaled as deeply as I could. The first time I coughed violently; the second, less so; the third, even less; finally I got the knack of it and my body stopped reacting. I shut the light off and sat in the dark, watching the ember from the cigarette glow brightly. It

relaxed me. I heard Marian coming down the hall. She opened the door, closed it, and sat down next to me; she had put on a bluish, flowered sweater. She lit a cigarette and we smoked together; I felt at peace and wondered why I had quit in the first place.

“You okay?”

“That’s the third time you asked me. Yes, I’m okay.”

“Just checking. You scared the hell out of me. I had no idea.”

“I don’t like to advertise it.”

“Does it happen often? Do you have any medication for it?”

“No. And I haven’t been taking it lately—I find it depresses me too much, and I already feel too tired.”

“I won’t tell Frank. It’ll be our little secret.”

I chuckled. “Thanks.”

“Besides, he doesn’t deserve to know. He’d think you were a retard or something.”

I looked out the window. A car slowed before the house; Marian stared at it until it took off.

“Probably one of his friends looking to party. Glad you turned out the light.”

The cigarette tasted good.

She quickly exhaled smoke. “He’s so chicken-shit, he never would have gone down there.” She affected a playful tone. “You’re so brave.”

I extinguished the cigarette and leaned back—she followed. She ran her fingers through my hair—I responded.

“That feels nice.”

She rubbed the back of my neck, leaned over and kissed my ear. “So brave.”

I kissed her on the lips, they were soft and warm. She pulled back and looked at me, trying to figure out why I had done it. She shook her head, then kissed me, her tongue probing my mouth.

“I have an idea,” she said between kisses. “How about a back rub? I think you could use it.”

“Sounds wonderful.”

I led her to my room. I lay on the futon; she straddled me and worked at my back. There were many knots, a lot of tension; if she only knew.

I woke late the next morning with a splitting headache and despair in my heart. I felt as if I’d had dreams during the night—so many, in fact, they had left my body weak; my hand quivered as I went to pull up the window shade. It occurred to me that Marian had gone. In my groggy state I hadn’t realized she’d left. I sat against the wall, then I noticed I was naked—I never slept without clothes. I found myself in a state of panic, remembering nothing save the back rub. Had I actually screwed my roommate? This was not a good way to develop platonic relations. Why couldn’t I remember? I tugged at my lip and looked around the room for a sign as to what might have happened; everything appeared normal, although a little scattered, as if somebody had torn around.

The clock next to the bed read eleven-thirty. I found two cigarettes and a small note tied together with a string. I read the note.

“Relief for my rehabilitating roommate.”

I smoked them back to back; if I’d had a whole pack I would’ve kept smoking until I had finished it. Doc had warned me that as soon as the dreams started, I would be experiencing blackouts again; she had said because of the mild epilepsy and the trauma I had

endured at the lab, it would only encourage repeats in the future. I reached for the phone to call her. I had to dial three times before I would let the line connect, and even then I had to force myself to ask for her.

“Darrin, I haven’t heard from you. I’ve been concerned.”

“Seems like a lot of people have.”

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“Steve called and told me he saw you. You had dinner at his house?”

“Yeah, just last night. Word travels fast.”

“He’s worried about you. He phoned this morning and said I should have you come in to see me,” she laughed. “I don’t mean it like that. I like it when you keep in touch with me.”

Immediately, I noticed she had that patronizing tone again.

“I don’t have your new number, so I can’t check up on you.”

“See, I’ve been busy. I don’t have a lot of time.”

“Would you like to come by and talk about it?”

I thought of saying yes, but something held me back. I let the silence drone on.

“Darrin?”

“Yeah, I’m sorry. Yes, let’s make an appointment.”

“I’m free this afternoon, would that be okay?”

“Yes, that’ll be fine.”

“At three o’clock?”

“Three. Yes.”

“Let me have your number in case I get held up.”

“I’ll see you at three. Good-bye.”

I hung up on her. Something was going on and I knew I was not being paranoid—a definite plan was in the works. I wandered around the house, got dressed, had a glass of milk, and sat at the table. I noticed the stairs to the cellar were still up. I paced to the patio door, opened it a crack, and gave the stairs a good shove—they crashed onto the concrete with a resounding thud.

There were two messages on the machine, both were for Marian. I saved them.

I sat on the couch and turned on the television; nothing much was on. Over the low volume, I could hear the cat we'd found in the cellar gently scratching the inside of Marian's door; it mewed softly. I thought of letting it out and allowing it to run free through the house. I ignored it and returned to the television.

At three I was at Doc's office. I had to wait for her in a pallid room adorned with framed lithographs of Austrian landscapes. The secretary gave me a peculiar glance; I thought to mimic her, but didn't. I wished to smoke, but had no cigarettes.

Doc walked in at three-thirty. She offered me the couch; I opted for the chair—it seemed more ironic. She sat behind her desk, opening my file.

"How are you doing, Darrin?"

"Okay."

"How are you really doing?"

"I had a blackout yesterday."

"Have you been taking your medication?"

"No. I find it depresses me."

"Taking it will do more good than harm. Be sure that you take it."

"Yeah." I stared off into the room.

“Something you need to tell me?”

I rubbed my forehead, a headache was coming on.

“The dreams...they’ve started again.”

She leaned back in her office chair. “I knew they let you go too soon. I told them you hadn’t fully recovered.” She was angry. “Darrin,” she got up and held my hand. “Would you like to go back to the hospital?” I looked into her eyes and realized her expression was patronizing, as if she only cared about my well-being because she was being paid to see to it. Like a demon that had been awakened, rage built within me. I mimicked her patronizing gaze and tone.

“You mean the asylum, don’t you?”

She let go of my hand. “Darrin, it’s not an asylum.”

“Don’t tell me what it’s not. They won’t let you out. That means it’s a place you stick people who are behaviorally intolerable.”

“I’d like to see you get some help. You seem to still have a lot of anger. Maybe you would be more comfortable with someone other than myself.” She got up and lifted the phone. “I can give you a referral to...”

“The hospital? Where they’ll give me a lobotomy? I don’t think so. Put the fucking phone down.”

She was surprised and shocked, but didn’t heed my warning. “Would you get me the number for...”

I grabbed the receiver out of her hand and yanked the phone across her desk; it slammed on the floor.

“I told you to put it down, but you didn’t listen to me! Why?”

“Darrin, take it easy.” Her voice was quivering from fear.

“Quit patronizing me, dammit! I’m fucking tired of it!” I was screaming. I quickly composed myself.

“You know Doc, sometimes when I look at you, you remind me of Judy.” I touched the side of her face; she reeled back. “I loved her, I honestly did, but she made me so angry. I was forced into it.”

She pinned her back to the wall. She was cornered, her expression that of an animal caught in a snare; she was petrified. I smiled, tapping my fingers on the desk.

“Well, I think I’d better be going, got lots of things to do.”

“Darrin, let me help you. Else, I will have to call the police.”

I slammed my fist on the desk.

“Will you shut up, for once!”

There was silence, beautiful silence, even in the outer office. I knew they had heard me yelling; soon security would be all over this place and they would force me back into the asylum.

“I’m outta here. Thanks for the clever conversation and the advice, Doc.”

I made a quiet exit; she stayed in her spot on the wall. The receptionist was deathly still. I returned her frightened stare with a Cheshire smile. I was certain the authorities would be coming for me soon.

The drive home, instead of lasting half an hour, turned into four hours. The landscape, passing by at freeway speed, was a comfortable blur: the houses and businesses, the putrid bay, the smog-choked airport, the square yuppies with their loosened ties and blank expressions, trying to pretend they had an intense problem getting home because the road was over-capacitated with commuters. It was their fault, the assholes, they had chosen their occupations, subsequently applied for jobs, and gotten them; they had known what they were getting into, but still insisted they had the right to honk and swerve from lane to lane, each trying to move the fastest

in a beast of their own creation. If I hit any of them, I didn't give a shit. If the car still ran after an accident, I would keep on driving, even if I had badly injured someone. All that was waiting for me was the hospital—no matter what I did. Even if I sat home all the time and did absolutely nothing, the hospital would still be waiting. The CD player was on the fritz, the radio was filled with banal commercials; if I were more paranoid I'd say there was a conspiracy. I wished I had my own music player. Why is it that when one station has a commercial, so do all the others? Coincidence? Ah, I don't know. Maybe I'll go buy one. No sense getting twisted in the problems of the world; ordinary, "normal" people—I hated them. And if they glare at me because I'm not driving like they are, because I'm not riding someone's bumper when they cut in front of me, I'll give them the bird.

The house was dark when I arrived home. I had no idea where Marian and Frank were. I opened all the windows in the house—it was uncanny how it held the heat in—my room was the worst of all, the tiny window doing little for air circulation. I opened the door and turned on the fan in hopes the cat was in Marian's room and wouldn't wander into mine. I had bought a large pad of paper, some pens, and a ribbon for the typewriter somewhere in along the drive—where I had realized (perhaps discovered) I'd driven too far. The mall had been cool, and the people wrapped up in looking for something to buy, or deciding what they and their young friends wanted to do. I sat down, flipped open the pad to the first sheet of paper, placed the pens within reach, and waited for darkness to settle in.

I liked the night. It is far better than the day. The temperature is bearable and when it gets into the morning hours, I come alive.

That way, “normal” people are asleep and they can’t contaminate my thoughts. The clear sky is a wondrous sight, and when the morning sun appears over the horizon, it is the most beautiful thing imaginable. The feeling of staying up all night is indescribable, especially so after intensive work. I liked writing and drawing, toiling over a creative design, honing something out of nothing; I know it takes a special sort of person to do it, and I hoped I had what it takes to achieve a semblance of greatness—but I really didn’t much care if I had “it” or not, I had to create in order for my mind to stop nagging me.

I didn’t pay attention to what was going on in the house. I had the radio on and couldn’t hear if anybody came in or not. I was far too involved in what I was doing to be bothered with concerns about nobodies. I was drawing some interesting pictures. Someone—I don’t remember his name—had tried to teach me in the hospital; through the lessons I had tried to listen, tried to duplicate his art, but the damn thing never worked out. I looked at what I had done, flipped a page on the tablet, and drew again. After trying to draw the same picture three times and failing all three, I drew another. I lay my head against the paper; I couldn’t get the image in my head onto the tablet, the transfer from mind to hand wasn’t working. Uncle was in my thoughts; I was thinking about him and realized I had been doing so most of the day. I found it odd that he had made such an impression on me, usually I didn’t think about anyone so...

The phone was ringing, distant and quiet.

I answered it. The line was silent.

“Hello...hello?”

The slow inhale and exhale of someone smoking a cigarette. A strong image was chiseled into my brain.

“Uncler?”

“How are you, Darrin?”

“How’d you get this number?”

“Don’t worry about it.”

“I see.”

I brought the phone into my room and locked the door. I set the pen to paper. I started drawing a square room with a high ceiling and a round table in the center.

“Heard you made a mess of things at Doc’s.”

“How do you know?”

“Sanderson.”

“Figures. He’ll probably tell everybody.”

“Always has.”

“Do you think Donalsed knows?”

“That’s why I’m phoning. Doc had somebody follow you. She’s reported you to the authorities. You’re dangerous and they will probably take you back to the asylum. I don’t know when they will pounce on you.”

I almost dropped the phone. “What am I going to do?”

“I’d say get out of there. And fast.”

I was sweating, nervous. I didn’t want to go back to the hospital, or the lab, no matter what the cost. *Why did he call it an asylum?*

“Where to?”

“Come to my place. They won’t think to look here.”

“What? So you can turn me in?”

“Turn you in? That’s not my style. But I don’t care about all that, I just want to make sure you’re safe. Besides, if Donalsed gets a hold of you, there’s no telling what he’ll make you do.”

“Yeah, but . . .”

“Now, get out of there and drive to the city. California Street and Sixth Avenue. Number 137 Sixth Avenue. Got it?”

“Yeah.”

“Leave now and don’t bother packing, you don’t have the time.”

“Okay.”

I slammed the phone down and shoved my keys into my pocket. It was then I noticed I had a smear of black ink on my hand; I wiped it off as well I could and found I had snapped the pen in half—the ink had splattered in several large blotches, covering the paper. I heard the far-off wailing of sirens and figured they were coming for me. On my way out, I accidentally kicked the cat—stupid animal—got behind the wheel of the car and drove away as fast I could. Approaching, two police cars and an ambulance sped past me as I headed for the freeway.

“You’re one step ahead of them,” Uncler said to me as I pulled up. It was well past midnight when I arrived. He was standing in the doorway of his building. He opened the garage and directed me to put my car in it.

His apartment was large; it was a flat on the fourth floor, done entirely in art deco, with heavy black curtains covering the windows. My attention focused on a blue neon clock, which was mounted on the wall.

“Like anything to drink?”

He was in a casual shirt and khaki pants. His hair was slicked back.

“Um, I think I’ll have...”

“I’ll get you a shot of whiskey, it’ll calm you.”

He left the room for several minutes. I sat on the couch with my hands clasped and sweaty, trying to think of what I was going

to do, where I was going to go. Maybe I could hide out at my parents' house up north; it was near the Oregon/Washington border. Donalسد wouldn't think I'd go that far, then again, he'd probably figure it would be the first place I'd flee to. I sat back and tried to relax. I was over-analyzing; my brain was overtaxed with anxiety and there was no way I could have a single clear thought. Best to have somebody else do the thinking for me.

Uncler came back with two crystal shot glasses and a bottle. He poured into both glasses and handed me the more generous of the two. He smiled slyly and swallowed all of his shot in one swift motion. I sipped at mine—it had been a long time since I'd had anything stronger than soda to drink.

"All at once and don't suffer over it." He lit a cigarette.

I dumped the whiskey into the back of my throat, it burned as it went down. I coughed, almost heaving it back up. He patted me on the back.

"Pretty good. When was the last time you drank?"

"Can't...remember...when." I hacked dryly.

"I understand. Let me pour you another."

"No, no," I waved him off. He put the glass in my hand.

"The second goes down better than the first, believe me."

I took the whole shot. It didn't taste as bad as the first, but still bad. He sat next to me.

"That'll help you relax. Look, it's late, why don't you take the bed and I'll stay on the couch." He put his hand on my leg. "Unless you'd feel more comfortable out here."

"I don't think I can sleep, I'm too wound up in what's going on." I attempted to stand and fell back to the couch. I rubbed my eyes. I felt groggy. I looked at Uncler; his face was like a watercolor,

blurring at the edges. I couldn't focus the skewed lines. He spoke. His voice was a distant echo.

"Sleep, Darrin. We'll talk in the morning."

I saw a black pool open at my feet. I dove in headfirst.

* * * * *

I woke. I didn't know what time it was. The apartment was dim, the curtains were drawn; I lay on the couch, with a blanket covering me. I was still fully dressed, my shoes on the floor.

"Oh, crap," I sat up and tried to shake the remnants of sleep from my head.

"What was in that drink?" I tried to stand, sat back down—my legs refused to support my weight. The neon clock glowed blazing blue on the wall across from me. I watched the second hand sweep around the red numerals; I could see the minute hand slowly moving. I concentrated on it as hard as I could, trying to find some sort of continuity. It was working; my mind was clearing as each minute passed. Soon I could stand. The next task was walking. There was a haze in the air, almost like smoke, it wouldn't go away, even when I tried to fan it with my hand.

"Okay legs, walk." One step at a time. I made it to the clock without stumbling, much. Then back. On the third trip, the smoke dissipated; I cracked a smile and congratulated myself for having beat it. I tried to remember how I knew to do what I was doing to get over the effect of the drug. I assured myself I must've learned it in the hospital; I had faint memories of doing the same activity while locked in my room—they had given me dynamite drugs. My long-term memory was coming back; soon I believed I was starting to recall why I had been put there in the first place. Hazy details were all I had, and I wasn't sure if they were correct—maybe it was

a plot of a book I had read or something. In time it would all come crashing back to me.

I felt brave enough to put my shoes on. I noticed it was almost four. I also noticed the flat had been quiet the whole time I was awake, which meant Uncler wasn't home. I assumed he was at the lab—probably talking to Donalsed or Niles. At any rate, I thought it best I make a quick exit; Uncler had been kind to show hospitality to a desperate man, but drugging me wasn't exactly a confidence builder—it didn't inspire any kind of trust. What he had in mind for me was unknown, but I was sure it wouldn't be, as Doc would say, in my best interest.

I buttoned my shirt, tightened my belt, tied my shoes, and threw on my jacket. I headed for the door. The phone rang, the second ring yielding to the answering machine; a droll greeting, a beep, then a voice. My hand was on the knob.

"Darrin. Sam. Hope you're feeling better today. More relaxed? Good. If you can hear this, don't bother trying to leave. I have you dead-bolted in. They can't get to you now. The windows have key locks and if you perchance to look, you'll notice you're fairly high up, so don't worry. I'll be there in an hour with dinner. If you're peckish there's some odds and ends in the fridge. I'll see you."

A dial tone. I tried the knob; it turned, but the door wouldn't budge, the deadbolts moved by key only. The door was heavy, no way I could break it down. I had flashes of the hospital. The circumstances were the same; better taste in decor, but I was still trapped like an animal. I decided to sit and wait it out. And he was wrong about the fridge—nothing but a bottle of water, soda, and some stinking Chinese take-out.

Time passed. I sat on the couch where I had been sleeping and watched the neon clock, it's second hand passing the glowing red numerals. It hypnotized me.

I heard the bolt turn in the door. I didn't bother moving.

"Hope you weren't too bad off, pal." He smiled cordially as he slammed the door behind him and fastened the deadbolts—the key went into his right pants pocket. He had a paper bag tucked under his arm. "I hope you don't mind, I have to protect you. I don't want them changing you."

"Yeah, okay." I smirked and glared at him. It was after six.

"Oh, don't take it too hard." He threw his coat on a chair and sat next to me. He put his arm around me. "Your profile says you are a big baby, is that so?"

I said nothing. He smiled and put his face close to my cheek, nuzzling my ear.

"Look what I've brought for dinner."

He tore open the bag. This display was all a game to him, I was his child at Christmas.

"It's from the Chinese place down the street, some chow mien, some rice. Chicken or beef?"

I remained silent and stared at the clock, watching the second hand sweep. The brilliant blue neon with tinges of red glared, perhaps pulsed.

"You really should eat, since I imagine you haven't all day."

"Beef then."

He handed me the box.

"I think you have some of these left over in your fridge."

“Been snooping have we?” He dipped into the chow mien, the noodles like worms squirming off the end of his fork. “A biological experiment, nothing to worry about. How’s yours?”

It was more fun to play with than to eat. “Okay.”

“Eat, eat. Please.”

“Maybe later.”

He looked at me sternly. “Eat, you need your strength.”

I dug the fork deeply into the box and took a big bite, rice falling from my mouth. He leaned back.

“Much better. I also picked up some drinks. Beer.” He handed me a bottle. “Indulge my friend, soon we will have work to do.”

“What kind?”

“I’ll explain later.”

I drank deeply from the bottle, almost finishing it. He smiled at me.

“How’s the old memory doing?” He tapped his index finger on the side of my head.

“Better.” I was suddenly uncomfortable. On the end table beside me was a photo of Uncle and, I imagined, his wife and daughter. I hooked my thumb at it. “Who are they?”

“Family.”

“Where are they?”

“Gone.” He said without expression.

“Where?”

“Divorced. She left me. She thought I spent too much time at work. You should have heard what she said about me in court, that I was crazy. You and I have more in common than you think.”

“Oh?”

“Everybody says we are crazy, but we believe in ourselves, in our work. It is our life. She left me after I nearly completed my time experiments.”

I choked on my food. “What?! Time dilation experiments...” I chuckled. “That’s fucking stupid.”

He slowly set his food down and looked into my eyes, scanning from one to the other. He’d probably heard the line a thousand times before and had a well-rehearsed response. “Time is irrelevant in certain quantum states. Of all people, Darrin, you should know that. All one needs is a bridge to this universe.”

“A magnetic-resonant field is one such bridge,” I retorted. “But you can never get it to properly synchronize for it to do any good at dilating the flow of time.”

“That’s where you come in. I’ve read all your publications and managed to get a copy of your work diary. You achieved synchrony. The only person I know who has.”

He got up and left the room. I picked at the tasteless remains of the food and set it down. He strode back in, carrying a bottle and two glasses of whiskey, his fingers dipped into each. He handed me one. I thought about the night before, and the drugs he had given me.

“A toast: To failed experiments, may they torment us until we are forced to succeed...as long as they don’t permanently kill us.”

I eyed him carefully. “Let’s exchange glasses.”

His expression was one of perplexity. “Why?”

“Guest’s privilege.”

“Fine.”

We switched glasses and I downed the liquor. He slammed his glass down on the table, upside down. He left the room again. I

relaxed, safe in knowing that he wouldn't get the best of...oh, no, not again. Feeling groggy...the world twisting into a haze. This time, it seemed strangely familiar.

He had his coat in his hand and he threw me mine. "C'mon, we're taking a little trip."

He took me under my arm. I remember going downstairs to the garage. Getting into a car. The slow acceleration of his take-off. Then, nothing more.

"Hey. Hey, Jensen. Hey, c'mon, wake up."

Uncle was slapping my face. My eyes opened onto bright lights. I tried shutting them again, but he continued to slap me. He set me upright. I felt the cold prickle of a needle going into my arm—the hospital, no—when it was withdrawn, the world seemed to clear. A person on each side lifted me to my feet. They pulled me across the floor, my feet dragging behind me.

"In a few minutes, you'll be fine," Uncle said to me. "I gave you something that should help with your memory block, and maybe make you more social."

He and another man laughed. The voice was familiar. They set me in a chair, it was padded and comfortable. I slowly opened my eyes. Something struck in my memory: the painted black walls; the expansive, smooth concrete floor; the monolithic generator in one corner; the triangular box, encrusted with panels of gauges and knobs, on a table in the center of the room, with an electrode dangling from above. And all the wires. I had to be at the lab, my instincts wouldn't fail me. It was the odor that did it, that queer smell; a combination of burnt hair, salt water, jasmine, and the faint ozone from high-voltage. But I thought they destroyed everything.

"Strike a chord, old boy?"

I looked in the direction of the voice. It was Niles. His self-satisfied, oafish grin was filled with teeth. Uncler put his hand on my shoulder and whispered in my ear.

“We need it to work again. We’re so close to a breakthrough. What aren’t we doing right?”

I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

Niles spoke. “Want me to rough him up?”

“Leave him alone. Listen, Darrin, you have to remember. I need to know. What’s the secret? I’ve run the machine using your equations, having rebuilding it at least seven times over. But I can’t get it, I’m not the genius you are. I know the answer is in that head of yours.”

I rubbed my brow. “I don’t know. I can’t think. I don’t even know what this place is or what all this equipment is for.”

“He’s lost it, Uncler. They cut all of it out of him. He has no answer to give.”

“Shut up. Give him another dose.”

The needle in my arm again. I was defenseless. The cool elixir coursed through my veins. My heart pounded harder, my throat swelled, I swallowed dryly every second breath. I coughed. Uncler walked off, returning with a greyish-silver ring. It looked like a zero, an oblong oval not more than two meters in diameter. He placed it in my hands. I rubbed my thumbs over it, the metal was cool, synthetic.

“Is that the correct material? It cost a fortune to make it.”

“No.”

Uncler paced before me. He snapped his fingers. “Niles, set it up and turn it on.”

Niles snatched the ring out of my hands, put it on a staff and slid the staff into a channel in the top of the machine. Uncler knelt beside me.

“Watch. This has to help. Focus on the ring. Remember. I’ve set the currents to flow asynchronously between the internal and the external compartments and have cooled the core to near absolute zero. I can see the distortions around the edges, but that’s as far as I can take it. What is the secret? I have to know. There are so many things we can do with this, so many lives we could enhance, we could travel long-distance, so many places so far away we could never reach conventionally. What are we doing wrong?”

Niles flicked on the high-voltage generator; it uttered a low hum that gradually became louder. I could feel the current it was generating. The power cumulated in the dangling electrode. Bluish streams of electricity jumped to the ring; it glowed with supernatural light.

In the cellar, Uncler with the cipher on a staff. His smile. The whirl was loud, becoming deafening; the hairs on the back of my neck stood on end. Judy chained to the wall, how she struggles to get free.

* * * * *

The machine was screaming an incoherent and wholly penetrating language. The pyramid-shaped body seemed to want to spin, to jump dimensions, but remained still. The pitch pierced my ears; I tried to shield them with my hands, but I couldn’t move.

The light, streaming out of the cipher into Judy, she screams of pain. The pyramid whirling uncontrollably, lifting itself off the floor; the cipher remaining to keep the circuit connected. The gateway opens, the link established; the pyramid near the wall unfolds away

from itself. The doorway, a blinding light emanating; I can see others, they want to travel into this world. I cannot let them, they wish to destroy, I must shut it down. Turn off the generator, cut the power, shut it down, too much, can't turn back, destroy the cipher, knock it out of balance, disrupt the frequency, close the door, danger, great danger, too late, too late, shut it down before it's too late.

“SHUT IT DOWN!”

“SHUT IT DOWN!!!!”

I screamed. The words stuck in my throat; my head seemed to open, my brain finally recovering lost information, retrieving data—it will not stop—I have seen them, they have seen me, they know me and are coming for me. I've seen their world, I've traveled to their space. They know I can open the gate, they are sending out their signal to match ours, they want me to help them. They need me, so they can come to us, so they can travel, explore, destroy, devour. Their faces are alien, features contorted, insect-like. Their expressions are contemptible, their intentions evil—I can feel it. My mind, it will not stop, they have entered me, violated my thoughts, contaminated me; I have seen their universe, stop it, stop them, must stop them, no matter what the cost. DO SOMETHING!!

Darkness. My feet on the smooth, wet concrete, shuffling slowly toward what's left of Judy—her body withered like a raisin, her once beautiful red hair burnt off, the outer layer of her once milky-white skin gone, the muscles tight around the bones, her face frozen in an expression of great anguish and fear, her eyes merely sockets. She saw their world and did not return.

A distant voice calling to me...

“...Darrin...can you hear me? Darrin, it's Sam...Darrin...”

I am being shaken. I open my eyes carefully. My forehead is cool, my skin saturated with sweat. Phlegm sticks in the back of my throat.

“...Darrin..?”

I answer, a garbled croak exits. My vision slowly focuses...Sam is looking down upon me like a bug under a glass. His face shows streaks of worry.

“...Darrin, you okay..?”

I raise my hand and touch his shoulder.

“...Darrin..?”

I shake my head. “Darrin’s not here.”

“Come back. You can’t leave just yet. Not without me. I want to travel. I want to see them and their universe.”

I laugh. My frame quivers. My chest hurts, but I cannot stop. I am nearly hysterical.

“I nearly lost you.”

He sets me upright. We are back in his apartment. My head aches. He hands me a shot of whiskey. I refuse.

“Take it, there’s nothing in it. Trust me.”

I smirk at him and down the drink. My throat burns.

Time passes.

I am coming to my senses—slowly clearing.

Time passes.

Feeling better. Aspirin and more whiskey. Several cigarettes.

Time passes.

I felt awful. I knew I was a wreck. My shirt was covered with crusted drool and spots of blood. I ran my finger along my gums; they were sensitive and bled as I touched them, an iron taste on my

tongue. More whiskey. Sam sat next to me, stroking my matted hair.

“You scared the hell out of me. It was quite a task getting you out of the laboratory and back here in your state.”

“What did you expect? You knew what would happen.”

“I only had a faint idea. I needed to know for sure.”

“Satisfied?”

“Yeah.”

He whispered something inaudible under his breath and looked away. He knew I was watching him. He glanced back at me and flashed a Cheshire grin.

“Why don’t you take a shower? Clean up. I’ll get you some clothes.”

I stood and held my balance. He led me to the bathroom, set a towel on the sink, and closed the door. I peeled off my clothes and drew a hot bath—soaking seemed like a much better idea.

Steam clouded the mirror, filled my lungs. I settled into the water, rubbing the soap over me.

* * * * *

A sharp pain. Judy holding hands with them, her body charred, their expressions twisted.

“Ahhh!” I grabbed the sides of my head and squeezed.

Uncle rushed in and knelt beside the tub. He pulled my hands down and put my head to his chest.

“It’s okay, relax, all gone now. Gone, gone, gone.”

He kissed the top of my head, brought my face to his. He lightly kissed my forehead, my cheek, my nose, then my lips. I didn’t respond. My expression remained stolid, but it didn’t seem to

matter much to him; he continued kissing me—his tongue probing my sensitive mouth, the taste of bile and iron.

He finished bathing me. The images of Judy and the others, they were gone. Sam was a great comfort. I was helpless and he was strong; his energy and desire were overpowering. He massaged my broken body, pushed away the hurt, and brought feeling back into places that I had thought were long dead, places Marian had tried to stimulate, but failed. He seemed to know exactly what to do; a warm feeling started in my stomach, moved up my chest, down to my loins. I kissed him back, hard. My breaths were rapid, my desire awakened. A thought tugged at me. I didn't think I found him attractive. He was so different, despite the sameness of our sexes, but it didn't pose a hindrance, couldn't stifle the feelings I had in me.

He dried me and had me stand on the bath mat. He ran his hand down my back and reached for my penis; my hard-on formed in his hand. He smiled and took me in his mouth. I lay my head back. My thoughts were non-existent; a pleasant emptiness enveloped me. My brain was quiet and for once didn't bother me; desire was all I knew, flaming desire.

He brought me to the point of near orgasm, then stopped; he stood and, with my fingers, undressed. He was already erect. I wanted to reach out and touch him, but stopped myself. Although everything that was going on was completely unfamiliar, I had faint recollections, memories like a watercolor in the rain. I was doing what I could to open the floodgates in my brain.

He grasped my hand and guided it over his body. I wrapped my fingers around his erection; he squeezed his hand around mine. I

could feel him throb, the heat he emanated. I released him and, with my hand in his, he led me to the bedroom.

He positioned me on all fours facing the headboard; the dark wood was carved with many intricate designs. I let my eye wander through them, allowing myself to be lost in the patterns. I was trying to occupy my mind with simple tasks. I was nervous, unsure of what was to happen, anticipating, hoping—I was shaking. I felt his finger probing me, pulling on the tender ring of muscle, stretching it so it could dilate enough to accommodate him. I massaged myself, pulling on my testicles; he whispered to me.

“Turn on the table lamp, in the drawer hand me the small bottle you see.”

I did so. He squeezed out a portion and put his finger back in me. He tossed the bottle on the floor and brought himself close to me.

“It may hurt at first, I’ll go slowly.”

Pain wouldn’t bother me—I had known so much, nothing else could compare. He slowly worked himself inside me. I must’ve given some resistance, at first he put only a little in, moving it back and forth before he slid his entire length in me.

I let out an uncontrolled yelp—a little pain, yes, but I could handle it. His motions were slow, then he moved more rapidly. I was masturbating.

Time moves slowly when you are unaware of it, it quickly passes you by. He pulled himself out.

“Lay on your back, Darrin.”

I did so and he reentered me from the front. I continued to jerk myself off, my orgasm building quickly within me; I sensed it was happening for him, too. Only a few minutes after he had entered me, we both came.

* * * * *

I pulled the sheet up around my neck. I was cold. Sam sat up against the headboard; he was smoking, the cigarette hanging lazily out of his mouth. I tried to get his attention by staring at him, but his mind was somewhere else.

“Sam, can I ask you something personal?”

“Shoot.”

“Why did your wife really leave you?”

“I told you: the experiments, the work, the insanity.”

“Was it because of someone like me?”

He looked at me and drew on his cigarette. “No.”

I stared at the ceiling, I was experiencing an overwhelming sense of peace. “I guess they destroyed my mind at the hospital.”

“What do you mean?”

“What do you know about it? The truth, I mean. I need to hear it.”

He exhaled slowly, smoke drifting off. “I heard they tried to destroy your mind. Rumor has it you lost it, had a habit of raving about some ‘others’ from another dimension. Ranting about how they’d violated you and how you needed to shut them out, so the doctors fixed you. Fixed you up good. No more ‘others’. So who were the ‘others’?”

“What I can scarcely remember is they are from the other place, on the other side of the gate. I remember their faces, I remember seeing them, the terrifying feeling of not being in my body, being in an alien one. But, I don’t know any more. Sometimes, I think I see them, or else they see me, but maybe I’m looking at myself from myself. It’s hard to talk about it.”

“Which place are they from? How did you discover their space?”

“I don’t want to talk about it. It has a bad effect on me.”

“You’re in the company of friends, Darrin,” he put his arm around me. “You can trust me. Now you know me a bit better, I think.”

“I know enough to know you know more than you let on. You know what the machine in the lab does. You just can’t get it calibrated properly. It opens a gate to another dimension, a whole other world, an entire race of people. Where they are from relative to us I don’t know, but I imagine they are far, far away from our solar system.”

He looked pensive. “I first heard about your temporal dilation hypothesis in one of your publications. It immediately grabbed my attention. To be honest, I was rather surprised they published it at all, from the commentary which followed. From that day on, I’ve been obsessed with the idea. Then about a year or so ago, I heard about the experiments you were undertaking at the university, trying to prove your hypothesis. I mean, really, a machine which allows an object, a person, to travel such long distances instantaneously, over such a vast expanse of time and space. It’s utterly insane. Only a genius could not only have thought it up by creating the mathematical context, but to also build an experiment which demonstrated it! Whoa! I had some connections at the university and after a year of lobbying, they let me into your laboratory, giving me a copy of your notebook. Some of the pages were missing. I assumed in those pages was the secret of the detail, since the machine never worked simply by turning it on according to the procedure you outlined. Something vital was missing.”

“Flesh.”

“What?”

“Flesh, live flesh. Life-force is the catalyst that facilitates the gate.”

“Huh? I’ve never heard of such a thing.”

“Sure you have. You just won’t admit it.”

“What does that mean?”

“What I didn’t write in the notebook was a myth I my father had discovered while doing archaeology in mezzo America. It was he who discovered a series of pictographs, along with a small codex which described the use of an apparatus which did something similar. In their case, to facilitate their ‘gods’ arrival in this world. It was an amazing find, a fifth codex.”

“You mean like the Mayans? But that dates to the first millennium. They didn’t have any form of electricity, as far as we know.”

“Certainly. But they had the capability to generate vast intensities of magnetic fields using a smelting process on a unique collection of materials.”

“You’re saying the magnetic field is the key?”

“No, not by itself. But by energy transport in magnetic resonance.”

“Similar to quantum tunneling, then?”

“More akin to signaling, but with large quantities of power, in the manner of an Einstein-Rosen bridge. See, for it to work, there *has* to be someone on the other side generating a signal of the same characteristic pattern but with a rotational vorticity which is opposite to allow attraction of the polarized resonant fields.”

“A wormhole.”

“That would be the laymen’s term for it, yes.”

“Which means there is a collaborator on the other side.”

“Exactly.”

“And you think your father discovered these collaborators, back in the Mayan times?”

“Yes. Time is only valid for us in our universe. It is the ocean that we swim in. Across universes, time has less meaning. There are only resonance points, like addresses, which can be connected. Certain conditions favor some over others.”

“So that means they are performing this feat of traveling now? Just to us, it is in the past.”

“Whenever a machine, calibrated properly, exists, that allows the potential of point-connection and therefore travel.”

“Which implies *they* could be anywhere, even here?”

“Once in our universe, they are subjected to the flow of time like we are. In order to be in the future—relative to A.D. 450—they would need another point of connection.”

“Any you posit they are looking to travel here?”

“They already have. But that’s where my memory stops. I faintly remember *seeing* them, *meeting* them, in fact. But it’s gone from me.”

“So let’s go back a minute. What’s this thing you said about flesh being the facilitator?”

“Yes. Live flesh. Like people.”

“Live people? Really?”

“Yes, people.”

“That doesn’t make any sense at all.”

“Scientifically, no. Mystically, yes. By its design, the cipher can only operate with someone ready to lose their life.”

“Yeah, but human sacrifice is a cultural thing, it has absolutely no bearing on scientific exploration.”

“My father discovered glyphs from walls in the Temple of Inscriptions, in Palenque, and copied them. The codex lie in a chamber just beyond it. It was written that the machine had originally been kept in Teotihuacan and rituals performed in a secret chamber in order to travel to the city of Xibalba. The cipher would be used to try to contact the ‘others’. Priests wanting power wanted to travel to the Underworld to accost these others—the Lords of Death, noted in legends—in order to achieve immortality. In our language, to exist in a place without time moving from place to distant place. That is what the cipher is for.”

“You call it *cipher* but the apparatus doing the work looks more like the number ‘9’.”

“When connected to the circuit, yes, if you include the connection leaving it. Which makes sense as Xibalba is divided into nine distinct levels. Some of these levels were the place where human souls were kept. One soul was required to travel there to allow a bridge created by the cipher.”

“So in the legend it is these ‘Lords of Death’ who facilitate travel, but something else is going on, then.”

“Yes. The myth is one thing but the cipher actually does quite another, in terms of physics.”

“But I’m confused, then, about the need for human sacrifice to make it work. In the frame of legend, sure, but how do you reconcile it in terms of physics?”

“That’s where my intellect became lazy. I was desperate to make it work. So I followed the formula to its exact description.”

“I see. That must be what is contained in the missing pages of your journal.”

“But what you don’t see is that the one who is sacrificed receives redemption and is the guide for the traveler.”

“That is quite an explanation. I see you are not the genius I made you out to be.”

“Let me have a cigarette.”

He handed me one and lit it for me.

A long pause ensued. I could tell he was thinking deeply, intellectually digesting the story I had told him. I had nearly finished smoking when he sat up.

“So that’s it, then. The catalyst is a human victim.”

My heart suddenly leaped. “You’re not thinking of actually continuing the work, after what I just told you?”

He quickly looked at me, smiling furtively. He stood up. “No. No. In fact, I’m going to go to the lab tomorrow and destroy it.”

“I’d like to go and...”

“You had better stay here. It’s too dangerous. Besides, they are still looking for you.”

“But...I...”

“You’ve had enough strain. Rest.”

I laughed, the thought seemed immensely funny. What should have been an inner monologue I expressed verbally: “I guess being caught between two dimensions while trying to destroy the cipher takes some time to recover from.” A headache was just starting to come on.

“So *that’s* what happened to you? You were caught *between* spaces?”

I looked up at him. “As far as I can remember, when I tried to stop the cipher’s operating cycle, I did it when my body was already inside the gate.”

He thought intensely. "So that means a part of you is still in Xibalba, in one of those levels, suffering from torture?"

"That could be a proper explanation for my predicament." The headache was intensifying. It made me feel cold. I lay down on the couch.

"Poor guy." He leaned over and kissed me on the forehead. "Sleep. We'll talk some more later."

* * * * *

When I woke at some point in time later, he was getting ready to leave. I kept my eyes closed, pretending to be still asleep. The key he used for the deadbolts he stored in a drawer next to the door. I saw him set it in there as he pulled the door shut. I quickly got dressed, ran a comb through my hair, and left. I let him have a twenty-minute head start to insure he wouldn't return and catch me. I was quiet as a mouse. I figured I would arrive at the lab after him and give him at least an hour to see if he really intended to destroy the machine—if not, then I would personally do it.

I hit the button for the garage and the door slid up. Luckily, I still had my car keys. I turned on the radio, the music and static making an eclectic background. The road blurred by, the sun a steady strobe as I cruised below an overpass. No dreams the night before, how about that. In the comfort of Sam they had vanished, but through my insecurity and vulnerability, he had used me. I wanted to hit myself for having been stupid enough to tell him everything about the cipher...but even he, as manipulating as he was, didn't have the stomach to add the final ingredient.

The roadway folded before my eyes, the lane dots twisting into disheveled shapes. The putrid smell of exhaust, burnt flesh, and ozone seared my nostrils; I heard voices, faint voices. I snapped off

the radio, but the voices continued; I perked my ears, trying to listen to them. The language was alien, but I understood it with perfect clarity. One voice, then many; I saw the lab, Judy, her soft red hair, her smile, her beauty—she quickly mutated into the decayed heap I had seen lumped on the floor. She reaches out for me; she wants me to join her in Xibalba.

The car swerved; I nudged another car into the center guard. A quick right onto the off-ramp and I was heading toward the house on Cappuccino. I parked in the back, trying to hide myself. I needed to regain control; I was going to get out and walk, although I wanted to stay in the car and drive off—my actions were not my own. I was a spectator.

The clock read three. Marian usually came home around five-thirty.

Wait.

I hid in my room, kneeling before my futon; my senses were keen, my ears tuned to the slightest noise. Activity in the neighboring apartments, I could see them in my mind through the wall; a car going by on the street, my mind's eye watched it. Marian, come home.

Waiting. Five-thirty-three.

Many things happened at once. I know it all. But order to make sense, I must filter the out unimportant details.

Harsh scratching at Marian's door. It was from the inside—the cat. It was furiously trying to get out. With a grin, I rose. I went to the door, opened it a crack; the cat's orange-red coat was standing straight up. It growled, then hissed at me. I knelt with a facade smile. Its green eyes were electric, teeth bared—small fur ball, you're no match for me.

It suddenly calmed. It sat and stared at me with wide pupils. As I lay on the floor and looked into its face, it displayed its teeth and formed its mouth to simulate speech. A voice came out of it. Nothing surprised me any longer.

“You stupid bastard, Darrin. You promised to marry me...” I reeled back, it was Judy’s voice. “Backed right out of it. Now you send me there and plan to give an encore.”

I sat with my back to the wall. The cat grinned and paced toward me.

“Comin’ for you.”

It leaped for my face. I blocked and it tore into my arm. Drops of blood fell to the hardwood floor. I shook my arm and the cat sailed across the room. It ran under the bed.

“Come here you.”

It wailed, as it had in the cellar. I shut the door and window; I pulled the sheet off the bed. With one hand, I flipped the bed upright. The cat made a mad dash for the door, but didn’t realize I had shut it. Its claws scratched the floor as it tried to make a quick turn. I threw the sheet over it and pulled the corners together, cinching it closed—it was bagged, and struggled violently. I was smiling again, ignoring the pain in my arm.

“Gonna take care of you.”

I drew water into the bathtub—ice cold—filled it to the rim. I lowered the bag into it.

“Bye-bye.”

It struggled. Air bubbles rose to the surface. Less and less it fought, until there was no movement—nothing. I pulled a heavy book out of my room to hold it under for good measure.

A few minutes later, a car parked in the street in front of the house. It was Marian. I quickly rushed to her room and straightened it, put a fresh sheet on the bed, shutting the door. I locked the bathroom door. Marian was still at her car, digging through it. I had just enough time to wash my arm, bandage the cuts, put on a long-sleeved shirt, turn on the television, and situate myself on the couch before she came in. She looked surprised to see me.

“Darrin, haven’t seen you in a while.”

I pretended to be into the TV. “Been busy.”

She went to her room. I hoped she wouldn’t notice anything amiss. She came back out; she hadn’t.

“What have you been up to?”

I snapped off the TV. “I was thinking, we haven’t had dinner out lately. Let’s do it tonight, my treat.”

“I’d love to, but Frank and I already have a date.”

“You know him, he’ll flake. Go with me.”

“We’ve been getting along better, he won’t flake.”

“Are you sure?”

“Of course not.”

I stood and grabbed her arms. “Marian. I need to talk and it would be better over a meal. Please.”

“Okay, okay, let me leave him a note.” She scribbled on scrap paper dug out from her purse and set it on the coffee table. “I need to go to the bathroom.”

My eyes darted to the door, then to her. “Something’s wrong with the toilet, it overflowed. I already called the landlord. Can you hold it?”

“I suppose.”

She walked in front of me and looked back.

“Have you seen Max?”

“Who?”

“The cat you found in the cellar. He wasn’t in my room.”

“He’s probably wandering around somewhere. I just saw him before you came in. He seemed all cooped up, so I let him out.”

“Okay, but I’m not sure if he can find his way back.”

“If not, when we come back later, I’ll help you look for him.”

“Okay.”

A smile was on my face. Soon the experiment would begin again.

* * * * *

I drove at blinding speed, toward the lab.

“Where are we going?”

“A great Italian place near where I used to work. I’ve been meaning to take you there.”

“Kind of far, isn’t it?” She seemed nervous. I wasn’t sure why.

“Not at all. We’ll be there shortly.”

We were nearing the university. I needed one more excuse to get to the lab. “Oh, shit!”

“What? What?”

I looked at her. “Would you mind terribly if I stop by my office and pick up some papers? I must finish them tonight, I’m going to see a client tomorrow.”

“I didn’t know you were working again. I thought you were not allowed to work at all.” She gazed out the window.

I was suddenly caught by what she said. “How do you know about that?”

“You must have told me when we met.”

"I could have," she seemed more nervous. She must be connected with Doc, to keep an eye on me. I decided to diffuse the tension. "Perhaps I forgot, seems like that is the story of my life these days."

I laughed, she laughed.

"Are we close?" She asked.

"Very close."

"Good, because I'm getting pretty hungry." Her voice seemed to be shaking from nervousness, almost as if she were keeping a secret that, if found out, would be the death of her. Ironical, I must say. We arrived at the gate. It had a guard posted, which was usual for the afterhours. He leaned his head out the window of his cabin.

"Can I help you?"

"I want to get in."

"Name?"

I was beginning to think this wasn't the best idea, going right into the laboratory when they were looking for me. But here I was, there was not turning back.

"Professor Darrin Jensen."

"Professor Jensen?"

"Phone Dr. Samuel Uncler, he can vouch for me."

He looked at Marian, then at me.

"She's okay," I snorted.

He smirked. "I gotta check it out."

He returned to his cabin and picked up the phone. He nodded several times. Marian was fidgeting in her seat. Only a few more minutes, relax, almost there.

"Must be a new guy, I don't recognize him." I said snarkily. "The rookies are so into following protocol to the letter."

The guard waved.

“Go on through, Professor Jensen.” He opened the gate.

The lab was housed a small distance off-campus within a series of nondescript buildings on the hillside. I followed a winding road to the very back one.

“Have you ever been here before, Marian?”

“Uh, no. Why do you ask?”

I knew she was lying.

“Well then, I can give you the grand tour.”

I parked the car. We got out and walked a short distance to the entrance. The main entrance was unlocked and the secretary who usually manned the post was nowhere to be seen. Strange.

“I used to spend all my time here,” I waxed lyrical. “It really disturbed my family life. I really don’t like coming here.”

“But you said you work here?” She asked. “You don’t like it now?”

“Well, no one *really* likes their job, do they?”

“No,” she shrugged. “I suppose not.”

We walked down long hallways and many vast open spaces behind windows to number 19, my old laboratory. I was expecting to run into Uncler somewhere along the route. The door was locked. I took my set of keys, unlocked it, and flung the door open in a dramatic fashion. Uncler *and* Niles were toying with the machine. Surprised and shocked, Niles walked over to me.

“Jensen. Hello. Nice to see you again.” He cast a look at Marian. “What is SHE doing here?” She withdrew into herself. Sam walked over, glaring at both of us.

“Kathy, you’re supposed to keep an eye on him. Not let him traipse around.”

“Kathy? Your name’s Kathy?! Who’s Marian?”

“Calm down, Darrin.” Sam put his hand on my shoulder. I shook it off.

“Fuck calm down.” I said.

“You should have stayed put.”

“Well, I wanted to see if you were good at your word. I see that you aren’t.”

“How can you blame me? Such a fabulous piece of work. My intellect is not so lazy, I’m going to figure the last steps out.”

“That will take too long.”

“Take it easy, Darrin,” Niles snorted. “We are readying a new calibration. Uncler’s had a bit of inspiration.”

“Only because he learnt it from me.”

“We’re going to try it momentarily, if you’ll allow us to finish.”

“If you insist,” I went to the workbench in a corner, pulled out two chairs, set Marian in one and took one for myself. Sam and Niles continued what they were doing before I interrupted them. When they seemed satisfied with what they had done with the machine and the alignment of the cipher, relative to the pyramidal case and surrounding rings, Niles went over to the high-voltage switches. Sam drew the Faraday cage around the apparatus and motioned to Niles to turn on the power. Slowly it ramped up, soon a corona appeared on the cipher coinciding with a series of smooth, slow arcs between each segment of the outer rings. Sam motioned for Niles to engage secondary power and the pyramid started its rotation, slowly at first, then speeding up until it was only visible as a blur. The third and final power switch was thrown and the machine lit up, exploding with the noise and smell of ozone emissions. But it did no more than a perform a fabulous light show. Sam was becoming frustrated, his patience wearing thin. He yelled at Niles to ramp it down by

reversing the switching sequence. In a few minutes it was quiet again. He then turned to me, eyeing Marian.

“Okay. I give up. Show me what you did.”

I sat smug in my chair with my arms folded. “Is that how you ask nicely?”

“Darrin.”

“I’ll need some convincing first, the three of you have been very rude to me.”

“Darrin, please,” Marian said. “Let’s go and forget about all this.”

Niles shot a look at me; I glared at Niles and at Uncler. ‘Don’t listen to her,’ Niles said. “This experiment is worth more than anything you need to do to make it successful.”

“You really don’t have the stomach for it, either of you.”

Sam came over to me and knelt beside me, close to my face. “Please, Darrin. Show us what you did to make it work.”

The room was deathly still, no one moved, no one breathed. In that moment, I was happier than I had ever been. No noise, no sounds, the thoughts in my head quiet and people around me anticipating my next move. I enjoyed it as long as I could.

“Fix Marian and Niles a drink, Sam.”

He nodded, went to a small refrigerator and came back with two shot glasses. He filled each with a shot of whiskey he had sauced me with. He handed each of them one and held the bottle in his hand.

“What about you?” Niles asked.

“I can’t drink, Niles. It doesn’t mix with my medication,” I winked at Sam.

I watched Niles and Marian drink their glasses and to my surprise, Sam took a deep drink from the bottle. I was never able to figure

out how he snuck the psychotropic drugs in that manner. Seems I miss the most important details of a story. Doc probably gave him some guidance.

“I don’t feel so good,” Marian said. “What was in that drink?” She passed out, collapsing into her chair.

Niles stared at me.

“What’s the matter, tough guy? Can’t handle it?”

“I’ll manage.”

He looked to Sam, who nodded. He dragged her out of the chair and draped her over his shoulder. I dug in a drawer at the table where I was sitting and found a generous length of non-conductive nylon rope. I looked toward the machine looking for the iron rings I had installed just behind it, but didn’t see them.

“Have you modified the arrangement?” I asked. “I don’t see the iron rings.”

“I removed them,” Niles said sheepishly.

“Well, put them back!” I snapped. He went to another table in a corner of the room and came back with the four iron rings. He placed them in the wall behind the cipher. Niles and Sam lifted Marian from her chair and stood her at the intersection of them. Sam and I tied her arms and legs, suspending her a foot above the floor.

“Just like us, huh? The two of us, willing to do what it takes to see it through.”

His face seemed sad. “I’m just following your lead.”

“Get a wooden step to support her weight, Niles. We don’t want her body to touch the floor.”

Niles returned with a platform and put it in place. Uncler had a faint smile on his face; I returned it.

“Now we shall have success. I promise you.”

I found a hydrometer also in the drawer and checked the humidity of the room.

“We need to increase the moisture level. Niles, hose her and the wall behind her down. And close the Faraday cage, we don’t want to fry ourselves.”

I jumped into the chair by the panel and whirled around in it, like a child in a park. On my third or so revolution, it occurred to me the settings were *way* out of whack, like novices having set the positions of the knobs in the hope it was correct. I put them into their correct positions. Niles shut off the water and went to the high-voltage switches. Everything was in place.

“Sam, take a hold of the pivot which changes the angular position of the cipher.”

I was in control of the ignition sequence for the electrode, Uncler was ready to pivot the cipher at my command. A flick of a switch by Niles would start the procedure.

“Ready?”

I pointed to Niles and he threw the first switch, turning the generator on. I watched the gauge on the panel. The amperes rose at a steadily.

“Level it off at eight thousand volts. Then, when I engage the electrode to the cipher, throw the second switch. Wait for my signal.”

He nodded.

“Sam, on my cue, set the angle at 17 degrees.”

“Got it.”

“For now, set tolerance at 25 degrees, frequency 125 MHz.”

“Got it.”

The generator whined as it built up current. For the first time in quite a long time, excitement throbbed within me.

The needle on the gauge increased steadily: 6, 7, 7.5, 7.8, 8.0. The capacitors were charging well. I was proud how she still worked as the day I made her. The voltage leveled. I turned a knob on the panel and set the electrode into position.

“Two centimeters above. Niles, throw the second switch.”

Blue streaks of lightning playfully encircled the cipher. The pyramid started its rotation. I pointed to Uncler, he pivoted the cipher and stopped it exactly at seventeen degrees. Through all his nonsense and posturing, this part was the truth, he had followed my notes to a ‘T’ and had practiced the experiment perhaps dozens of times. He was good, but not good enough to know how to run the panel.

“About two meters before the cage, that’s where you’ll be able to see the gate, boys. It will open like a flash.”

My finger was on the switch, it trembled terribly. One flick would power up the pulse current through the cipher which was in synchrony with the magnetic field at the rings. I could see the pattern in my mind. I think I drew it in my notebook once, it was quite a thing to behold. But Marian still needed to be connected to the circuit. Once Niles threw the third and final switch, it would be closed. Once in that state, I would engage the rotational vorticity of the rings and it would be ready to open the gate. I looked at Marian, the deceitful little spy; she was slowly moving back and forth while unconscious, as if in a trance. Uncler’s psychotropics were much better than the ones I had used on Judy. At this point, she was starting to wake up as the magnetic field began saturating her body. I watched the level rise, doubling as the sequence was

supposed to be: 0.5 Teslas, 1, 2, 4, 8. It was nearly show time. Hairs on my neck started to stand, the field was leaking from the cage, there must be damage to the cage. No time for that now. No time for anything else.

“Ready, boys?” I yelled above the whir. “Niles, throw the third switch.” He did and I immediately after turned on the pulse current. The cipher ebbed with brilliant greyish-white light. The gauge measuring current climbed quickly to nearly the top of the scale. Suddenly a wave of force struck out, it nearly knocked me out of my chair.

“Darrin! There!” Niles pointed at the cipher. It discharged a bolt of light that contacted Marian. She screamed, painfully, and excruciatingly but it was barely audible above the electrical noise. The gate, where was the gate? Waiting: Seconds seemed hours.

A flat light appeared on the floor before the cipher. It rose oddly as a cube—it didn’t do that last time, or am I not remembering correctly? Yes, that was correct, it was not spherical, but cubic—soon the gate would be opened. Niles stood gaping while Uncler had stepped back from his position to get a better view of what was happening from my viewpoint. Marian’s screams had ceased. I made a mental note—these psychotropics are *much* better than the old.

The cube rose, its shape was still odd, it seemed to be fracturing into a more complex octahedral form, which I knew could *not* be correct. A six-sided form represented a stable dimensional link, a clean resonant transport, any deviation meant an error, which is why it *could have never* been spherical. There must be a problem with the flow of current, it was surging. The leak in the cage. I needed to compensate for it. I adjusted the pulse rise time to clean it

up. That did the trick. The cube continued to rise; at the height of two meters, I would have to stabilize the cipher's resonance—having to set it perfectly. Almost there.

“Sam, adjust the pitch to eighteen degrees.” I noticed he was standing toward the front of the machine staring at the cube. He's going to mess up the whole experiment.

“Sam! Eighteen degrees, now!” He ran back to his position and set it thus.

I was still having trouble with the current leakage. The ammeter was starting to bounce, the cube looked almost liquid. Something was definitely amiss.

“Sam, nineteen degrees. And do it slowly.”

I adjusted the pulse fall time, but it didn't seem to help. A cloud of smoke and a buzzing from the panel. The overload warning indicator was flashing. The ammeter was jumping all over the scale. The cube started to dissipate. The generator had overheated, smoke enveloped it. The cube quickly dropped to the floor and disappeared. A sick metallic grinding sound, and the generator came to a dead stop. The sequence automatically terminated, system automatically shut down. The light extinguished as if it were a candle that had just been put out.

Silence. The cipher glowed with a slow pulsing supernatural light.

I slammed my hand on the panel. “Shit!” I rubbed my forehead. It had to be the damage to the cage, the leaking current, there was not enough containment of the resonant energy, it was like a bowl with a hole too big to hold water long enough to drink from. I leaned against the panel, trying to think. Uncle and Niles joined me. The smell of burnt flesh and ozone hung in the still air.

“The generator’s blown, Niles said. We’ll need to fix it and probably add a few more transformers to stabilize its output.”

Uncler nodded. “I agree. What happened Darrin?”

“There is some damage to the Faraday cage, it’s leaking. Which one of you geniuses fucked it up?”

Niles looked at Marian’s burnt body with disgust and opened the cage. A hinge on the right side lay askew. “I didn’t notice this before. Looks like the damage is recent.”

I stood from my chair and paced over to Marian’s body. Her arms had separated at the wrists, her body lay in a twisted, blackened, indefinable heap. She had been too fragile; it was possible that when she had separated, the circuit had been broken, thereby overloading the generator. The cage was one thing, but I was certain the adjustments I had made with the pulses were compensating, by the frequency enforcing containment. Quite possible. Uncler walked with me. He tapped me on the shoulder and handed me two tablets in an aluminum wrapper.

“Next time it’ll be easier with these.”

I thrust my hand into my pocket. “So *that’s* your secret to making friends.”

We both had a good laugh. Niles looked on confusedly. I didn’t care about the particulars of the scene before me, especially the dead body, that was not my problem. That was Uncler’s. I was consumed with the failure at hand. I *really* wanted it to be over.

“I need someone with a stronger frame for the next go.” I looked to Uncler then setting my eyes on Niles’ stocky build. He was sickly pale, anxiously looking at the gauges on the panel. “And replace the nylon rope with something more robust—leather please, but be sure there is no conductivity whatsoever.” I tugged at my lip.

My mind was racing a mile a minute—I was *so* close to finishing. I could feel the old obsession consuming me as it had before. I should have realized that continuing this work would be dangerous, but I didn't care. Three years ago I had *finished* the work, seen their world and they mine. But I chickened out and tried to short-circuit the whole thing, leaving a part of myself in their universe, fracturing me. How stupid, to having partially gone through before deciding to turn back and close the gate without the proper procedure—I panicked and now a part of me is a part of them and vice-versa.

Uncle cracked his knuckles. "What's the plan?"

The problem nagged at me, beating a continuous monotonous rhythm.

"We need to fix the cage and install the new transformers like Niles said. Somebody has to dispose of the body." I paused with a maniacal spirit. "And we'll need a new connection in the circuit."

"Yes, I agree," Sam nodded, a blank expression on his face. "But we need to clean up around here. He looked around to a set of wooden boxes in a corner of the room which was used to ship the large transformers and electric motors the laboratory used.

"We could put the body in one of those boxes and then it would be easier to dispose of it. In its condition, I don't think anyone would be able to recognize it *as* a body. Then we could take it to the chemical waste storage facility in building seven and dissolve it. You go back to my place, Darrin. Niles and I will take care of the body."

"What about the next set of experiments? I mean once the cage is repaired and the transformers installed? We'll need another participant."

Sam looked at Niles and eyed him up and down. He stepped back.

“No, not me!” He exclaimed.

“I know, don’t worry,” Sam said. “We need three of us to operate the machine.”

“Definitely no. I want to be *sure* we can keep the connection solid. We will need an oversized person.” I immediately thought of Frank.

“You have any ideas, Darrin?”

“I think I might.”

“Well, don’t do anything without discussing it with us first.”

* * * * *

It was almost four in the morning when I arrived home. Yes, Sam told me to go to his place, but I wasn’t in the mood to heed his advice. The house was dark when I arrived—not a single light was on. Marian’s note was still on the table. No Frank. In fact, I couldn’t remember the last time I had seen him. There would be more waiting, but I could be patient. Scientific success is a hard-fought battle won by the accomplishments of genius—soon, very soon.

Time passed. It was nearly dawn. I had stopped checking the clock a long time before. I was tired, but still obsessed with my plan. If I could just catch a few hours’ sleep, then I would feel better, and perhaps Frank would be back by morning. I laid down to settle to sleep and closed my eyes. Instead of peaceful blackness, I saw many brightly colored lights; they flashed before my eyes like a carousel. I concentrated on them, trying to form shapes—if I could tire my mind, then maybe I could sleep. I saw Uncle’s face, his expression twisted, his smile malevolent. I thrust open my eyes. I heard a

sound similar to the hum of the generator powering up to activate the cipher. The sound changed in pitch and grew louder; I gritted my teeth and held my hands over my ears. Stop. Stop. Louder and louder, my eardrums felt ready to burst.

“Leave me alone! I’m doing all I can! Look, I know, I take responsibility that I planned it badly, but next time I promise it will be successful.”

I felt as if they were torturing me, at least a part of me. I felt as if stuck in a room which was constantly humming, vibrating my entire form which was driving me crazy. The hum steadied, as if to acknowledge my recognition of it. They were trying to manipulate me and I knew it. The others, they were keen to see the gate opened, properly this time. Frank still wasn’t home. Anything that could be done without him would render inefficacy. Still, the hum continued with piercing amplitude.

Relax, cease the noise, control. You are here and not there. They were trying to drive me out of my mind. They knew how, knew very well, but I was stronger. I was the one in control. I performed the experiments. I opened the gate.

“You have to wait, you fucks,” I laughed loudly. “Kiss my fucking ass, I’m the master, and if I decide to scrap the cipher, then you’re fucked.” Torture me all you want, keep me cold, keep me hot, cut me to a thousand ribbons, I don’t care, *you cannot control me*. I laughed again, this time at the top of my lungs.

I must’ve fallen deep asleep sometime after that because I don’t remember anything until I noticed a feeble light in my eyes. I opened them and the sun was streaming through the dirty little window in my sordid room, but the scene was wavy, like the heat was turned way, way up, although I didn’t feel it. The phone rang.

“Darrin, what are you doing home?” It was Sam. “I told you to go to my place.”

“What? What are you saying to me?” The room was starting to shake and quiver as if bobbing at the end of a tether.

“Well, I’ve got some bad news, the transformers have to be made and it will take a week. We’re shelving the project until then.”

“What did you say, a week?”

“We need those transformers, right?”

“Yes, and what about the cage?”

“You’ll have to wait it out.”

“Why are you so fucking nonchalant about it? A delay is out of the question. I thought you were as obsessed as I?”

“What gave you that idea? The machine, your theory doesn’t work. It’s but melodramatic way to murder people.”

“What? This isn’t Uncler. Who is this?”

“You know who. I don’t want to see you around the lab. You’re insane, brutally so, fucking bonkers. Don’t contact me and don’t come by the lab anymore.”

“Sam..?”

“If you do, you’ll be arrested at the gate, charged with first-degree murder, and thrown back into the loony bin, you fucking psycho.”

“Sam, what the hell is going on?”

The phone went dead. I stared off into the bleakness of the kitchen. The walls started to melt and the floor switched patterns as if in a kaleidoscope. I fell to the floor.

* * * * *

In the blackness of the mind you don’t have any bearing on reality. This must be what it’s like for people who are in a coma. I heard sounds and I felt movements. I heard the faint mewing of

animals and people rousing in a theater. I remember seeing the world from above, as if floating, trees and landscape below. A world without people. My back felt hot, the back of my legs warming slowly as if mounted on something dangling over an open flame. While comforting at first, the pain started becoming unbearable. I could feel my eyelids. I needed to open them.

The sun hit my eyes and I was blinded by it. I raised my arm to shield myself from the light. My body ached and I couldn't feel my legs, other than the feeling of hot. I slowly managed to sit myself up and noticed I was in my own bed. As I realized I must be awake, I rubbed my eyes and tried to focus my vision. I noticed that I had trashed my room—at least I *think it must have been* me. All the books were thrown to the floor; the crates serving as a bookshelf lay across one of my legs, cutting off circulation. With my free leg, I shoved it off the bed. I managed to get myself to stand and waited for the feeling to return to my leg, which now felt like pins and needles. I hope it hadn't been cut off from blood circulation too long, I still needed it to get around.

It was a colossal task dragging myself to the kitchen. My thoughts were on the call from Uncler. I was trembling violently from fear, fear that I wouldn't be able to finish my work and see the cipher to completion. I didn't want to end up like my father, broken and disheartened, desperately trying to hold onto life, only to end it by my own hand.

I tripped over the corner of the baseboard and fell to the linoleum. I reached for the phone cord and pulled it; the receiver fell from the counter to the floor. I dialed the lab, the number engraved in my memory. I got Niles.

"Is Uncler there?"

“No. He went home to get some sleep. We managed to clean everything up this morning. The transformers are on their way and should be installed later today. I managed to weld the hinge back onto the cage, so that is repaired. We should be ready to go by tomorrow. I suggest we meet then.”

“Where?”

There was a long pause and I heard an audible sigh. “Here, stupid.”

I rubbed my eyes, my head was full of confusion. “What day is it?”

“Thursday. If you don’t mind, I suggest you come here tomorrow, Friday, at eleven in the evening. Most of the staff will be away for the weekend and we’ll be able to conduct the experiment without distraction.”

“The experiment?”

“Of course. What else?”

Something was going on, at this point I wasn’t sure if the conversation with Uncler took place at all. I couldn’t trust my senses, couldn’t trust anything that was going on.

“Listen, Niles, if he comes in, have him call me. I have one more detail to clear up here, and I’ll meet you tomorrow evening with the new participant.”

“So you have that item taken care of? Uncler said you would.”

“Yes. And by the way, who was that Kathy woman?”

“Never you mind. Goodbye.”

He hung up. I pulled myself to a standing position. During the call, my leg started to get feeling back in it. Apparently the circulation was not cut off too long. I walked one step at a time to the bathroom. I needed a shower, or better yet a bath. When I

reached the door, just before grabbing the knob, I remember the cat I drowned in it. I'll need to bury it in the yard. More work to do. I grabbed the knob and the door was unlocked. Strange. I slowly turned the knob and peered around the door, opening it carefully, as if not to make a sound. The cat was gone. The water had been drained out of the tub, not even a trace of a smell. I wondered where my book I used to hold down the cat had gone to. I checked my arm for the scratches, yes they were there, the wound looking terrible under the bandage. I showered—no patience for a bath—disinfected the wound, put on a new bandage. Once I cleaned it, it didn't seem as bad as when I first saw it. I shut myself in my room and waited.

It was well after ten that night when I heard a car pulling up. It was an old car, with loud exhaust. It rumbled in the driveway after being turned off, the sick sound of dieseling of the engine. The front door was thrown open. I sat up like a shot and frantically dug through my pants pockets, searching for the tablets Uncle gave me. I set them under the futon. I heard Frank mumbling incoherently in the kitchen, rifling through the refrigerator and placing something in the microwave. I straightened myself and went out.

"Frank? Hi, haven't seen you in a while."

"Yeah, you neither. What's up?" the microwave bell rang and he pulled out a burrito. It steamed on the plate as he placed it on the kitchen table. I noticed a beer was sitting beside it. He sat down and began eating ferociously, as if he hadn't in some time.

"I need to talk to you."

"Go ahead. Talk."

"What are you doing tomorrow evening?"

He shoved a third of the burrito into his mouth and talked through his chewing.

"I was supposed to go to a party, but it was already last night. I haven't slept at all. You want to come?"

"I was thinking we could do something else."

"Like what?" He took a long drink of his beer.

"There's something I want to show you. Then afterwards, we could go for a drink or something. We haven't hung out in a while, you know?"

"True," he belched loudly, smiling in satisfaction. "That could be fun. If we get bored, we can go to that party I've been invited to. There'll be lots of girls, I'm sure you can meet somebody."

"What about Marian?"

"We don't go out anymore, in fact, I haven't seen her in a week. Have you?"

I shook my head. "No, me neither."

"She's got her own life." He finished the remainder of his burrito and downed the beer. "I'm tired. I want to go to bed." He got up and stumbled past me. "Night."

"Good night, see you tomorrow."

I heard him in the bathroom and then slam his bedroom door. His heavy frame came down on the bed, it shrieked in protest. I stood in the kitchen and sat at the table across from the remnants of food he left at his place. The light from the single bulb above the table burned my eyes. What to do until then? I got up from the table, turned out the light, and went to the living room. I snapped on the TV and sat on the couch. Got time to kill. I sat for an unknown time staring at the screen, then noticed the cup on the coffee table. The marijuana, that should keep me occupied. I reached under the couch and found Marian's stash, there was a lighter on the coffee table, but no pipe. It was probably still in her

purse, or, maybe in her room. I stood up and went to her room, passing by Frank's hearing him snore loudly and searched for it, no luck. I then remembered the tablets Uncle gave me. They were wrapped in aluminum foil, if there was enough material, I could make a pipe out of it with a pencil. Innovation and I were no stranger! I went to my room and took the package from under the futon. I unwrapped the tablets, dumping them on the bed and unfolded the foil. It was just about the right length and width to do the job. I took one of my drawing pencils and made a pipe. I used a mechanical eraser to neatly fold the edges—it was ready.

Back in the living room I sat packing small amounts of marijuana into the pipe smoking and smoking as images unfolded on the TV. Soon I didn't seem to mind the ludicrous stories or the pedantic comedies. I was laughing, silly at first, then I started to feel better. Good, in fact. Better than I had felt in years.

Soon the entertainment value of the TV waned. I started flipping the channels one to the next, nothing was on and I was getting bored. As I was ready to turn it off, I saw the note Marian left for Frank on the table. I'd been sitting here for hours and hadn't noticed it. Luckily, neither had Frank. I snatched it up and read what it said.

'Frank, going to dinner with Darrin. Let's catch up later. Love, Marian.'

Her handwriting was incredible, neat and cleanly-spaced cursive letters. A mark of a tidy, highly-intelligent mind. I could never write so well, my handwriting was so bad, I couldn't even read it, which makes me wonder how Uncle could have understood *anything* that was contained in my experimental notes. Maybe he was able to interpret the meaning from the drawings and pictograms. It was all

starting to make sense how he could know so much about my work, yet know so little. I neatly folded the note, put it in my pocket, turned off the TV and went to bed.

It wasn't until breakfast time the next day that I realized I slept like a baby. No dreams, no nightmares, no voices, no pain, no anguish. Nothing but pure bliss in blackness and nothingness. It was getting on toward noon when Frank came out of his room. Saying nothing, he went to the bathroom and I heard the shower running. He came out dressed in fresh clothes and went to a cabinet, then to the refrigerator.

"Fuck. I got a wicked hangover. I can't go to work today."

"I feel pretty good. Found Marian's stash last night. It's dynamite."

"Tell me about it. She gets *the best*. I cannot figure where she gets it. I've smoked nothing like it." He made himself a bowl of cereal bringing it and the milk container to the kitchen table across from me sitting in the same place he had the night before. I had picked up the mess he had made.

"What time you want to go out tonight?" He asked.

"Oh, about nine-thirty. The place is about an hour's drive from here. But I'll need to stop by and pick something up before."

"If it's far, my car won't make it."

"We'll take mine."

"Excellent." He finished his cereal and put the empty bowl in the sink. The milk carton was still at the table. "You want some coffee? I'm going to make a pot."

"That sounds good, perfect in fact."

We sat together for a bit of time drinking coffee and talking about the funny chaos that used to go on at the asylum, although Frank

insisted constantly on calling it *the hospital*. As the conversation started to wane and topics became exhausted, we started to talk about them from the beginning. I never spoke about what I did, Frank never knew my work at the university or the laboratory.

“This is great fun, like the old days,” he chortled. “Hey, you wouldn’t happen to have any of that weed Marian had, would you? I would *love* a joint right about now.”

“Certainly, let me go get it.” I went for the living room and I heard him getting up from the table and going to his room. When I came back to the kitchen and sat down, he arrived with some rolling papers and a lighter. I had my aluminum pipe and the bag of marijuana from under the couch set on the table before me, next to my empty coffee cup. He glanced down at it and resumed sitting across from me.

“That’s a great idea, but I like rolling my own.” He opened the bag and took out a portion, breaking in into smaller bits on the table before him. I took a portion for myself and did something similar, except my bits were not as small as his. When he’d finished rolling, we sat staring at each other, he with the joint, me with the aluminum pipe stuffed in our mouths each of our hands containing a lighter.

“You ready?” He quipped. I nodded. We lit our respective smoking apparatus simultaneously taking a deep drag while watching each other. It was a ritual from those times, a means to connect. Then we did it when we were given our pills, now it was a different kind of medication. When he’d finished inhaling, he took the joint out of his mouth and inspected it carefully.

“Man, Darrin, I *love* this stuff. I have no idea where she got it.”

I couldn't imagine either, soon the feeling had me drifting away from the problems which plagued my mind.

"I could smoke this all day," he continued. "I don't have anywhere to be today."

And so it was. We sat in the kitchen and smoked. We went to the living room and smoked. We even went out to the back yard and I showed him the cellar where I had found the cat. We laughed and laughed and laughed. We laughed about our lives, we laughed about the hospital, we laughed about what set of emotions put us there, we laughed at the television, and we laughed about nothing. Soon it was getting to be evening. We ordered a pizza for delivery, then smoked some more. All the while the clock approaching the time to leave for the laboratory. At seven-thirty I decided to stop smoking while Frank continued. The bag was getting to be empty, we probably smoked five grams between us. Soon the clock edged to nine.

"We have to go soon," I noted. Frank nodded.

"Okay, I'll go get on some decent clothes." He went to his room and I did the same. A fresh set of clothes would set everything right, the last set if I was lucky enough. The day was one of childhood wonder, emotion, and imagination. This was why I really liked Frank when we first met. He was so easy-going despite having very intense body issues because of his size. It didn't seem like he ate that much to cause such weight, but something biological, or glandular, as he would say. But we never stayed on topic of what made us crazy enough to be committed, that would be too much. We just wanted to forget about all the troubles of the world and enjoy it as if it was our last day.

We left the house at nine forty-five. Frank took his papers and the remainder of the bag with him. We left a bit late but there would be no traffic, I hoped. Late Friday night, who would be out? Not many, but an accident along the way kept us stuck. I was starting to become nervous and Frank seemed to notice. We stopped talking, he looked out the window into the darkness and the streetlamps passing one slow one at a time as we crawled our way to the university. As the traffic started to lighten up, I suddenly realized a grave mistake: I had left the tablets Uncle gave me on the futon in my room. My mind started racing to find an alternative solution.

"This is taking too long," Frank said. "I'm going to roll one up."

While he was rolling, the solution presented itself. I remembered a meter's length of thick PVC pipe I had on the floor behind my seat. I always kept it there in case of problems while driving. I made it a short time after leaving the asylum, when I was accosted one day while driving. The experience shook me so much that I would feel better with a defensive weapon. I never had a chance to use it, though. Frank lit his joint and took deep drags from it. He handed it to me. I shook my head.

"No." The smoke smelled divine, it reignited the feeling I had earlier, but I had to keep it together, tonight was very important. "Open the window, though," I told him.

Soon Frank was laughing hysterically in the car beside me. The marijuana had a more intense effect on him than me. I sure would have enjoyed one, had I not been driving. But I was busy nevertheless, my mind rehearsing over and over how I would execute plan 'B'. We arrived at the gate when my watch read twelve-thirty. I wasn't sure how it became so late so fast. The guard eyed me carefully. He

knew I had come in with Marian the night before, but he never saw her leave with me. At least this is what I was thinking. I smiled broadly.

“Be cool. These people are not cool like you and me.” Frank nodded trying to contain himself.

“A little late, isn’t it, Professor Jensen?” I didn’t act surprised.

“If you live in ordinary time, I suppose it is. But not for us.” Frank started laughing again. The guard looked sternly at him.

“Yeah, sure.”

“Phone Dr. Uncler again, he can vouch for me, if you don’t believe me.”

“It doesn’t matter what I believe. But you need to get a proper entry card the next time you come in. This will be the last time I do it without one.”

“Okay.” I said calmly. He walked back to his cabin, reached for the phone, then stopped. He raised the gate and waved me on.

“Go on through.”

We drove on the same way I had with Marian, stopping at building nineteen. Uncler and Niles were outside when I pulled up to park. Sam threw his cigarette to the ground stuck his head in the window and looked at Frank across the seat, he was cross and his breath reeked.

“You’re late. Who’s your friend?”

“I’m Frank,” he stuck out his hand across me and Uncler shook it.

“Nice to meet you. Darrin, pull around to the back.”

Frank started laughing again. Sam smiled. “I see those tablets have a different effect on different people.”

“No,” I said looking at Frank, then to Sam. “This is a different medication altogether.” The three of us laughed. I drove to the loading dock at the back of building nineteen. It was pitch dark on this side, no light was visible on the building. When I killed the engine and snapped the headlights out, Frank and I sat in complete darkness.

“So who is that?” Frank asked.

“An old friend from before.”

“He’s not going to the party with us, is he? I don’t like him.”

My hands gripped the wheel. “No, Frank. He isn’t.”

A door on the loading dock opened. Uncler and Niles stepped through it. I rehearsed my plan ‘B’ one last time in my head.

“I need to stop in and pick something up. You want to come with me?”

“Yeah, my legs have fallen asleep sitting in this car so long.”

We both got out of the car. I stood by the car door, window down, and Frank next to me. He raised the remainder of the joint to his mouth and puffed on it. Sam paced over to us, his body language was that of irritation of having been made to wait. Niles remained on the dock. I’m sure they wondered if I would show at all. I probably shouldn’t have.

“If you follow me, gentlemen,” Uncler quipped. Frank puffed one last time and dropped the remainder to the ground, stepping on it. While he was looking down, I leaned back in the car where my fingers found the length of PVC pipe. Frank started walking ahead of me, a few paces. I removed the pipe from the car taking it firmly in my hand. The only light was being cast from the half-open door on the dock. When we mount the stairs, that’s when I’ll strike.

“What is this place?” Frank asked.

“A research facility,” Uncler retorted. I was getting ready to extend my arm for the strike. Frank turned to look back at me.

“You never said you worked in research?” I could see in the darkness he face looked confused. He turned back and continued walking. Uncler mounted the dock stairs and approached Niles who was looking as confused as Frank did. He mounted the first stair, I pulled the pipe out from behind my back and extended my arm for the strike. As his foot reached the top stair, I brought it down full force on the back of his head. He yelped.

“Wha..?”

Before he could turn, I hit him again. Harder this time and with a succession of quick blows. He fell onto the dock. Uncler and Niles came rushing over. Niles knelt over Frank’s unconscious body and Uncler shook his head.

“That was *your* plan?”

I shrugged my shoulders.

“He’s enormous, you think I could have handled his dead weight by myself?” I asked.

He eyed his girth. “No, I suppose not. But it will take the three of us to lift it and put him in the machine.”

Niles fetched a gurney and a blanket. With an effort more significant that I had imagined, we lifted Frank onto the gurney and placed the blanket over him. As we hustled the short distance to the lab, I had an odd feeling in me. It felt as if my whole being were light, without weight, like air; I had experienced the feeling once previously, when I had performed the experiment on Judy. Like before, it was as if I knew I would be succeeding, and had to prepare for the consequences. My body as I knew it would not be able to withstand the transition into the other world. The feeling had been

frightening then, and fear gripped me now, for this time I would not disrupt fate by destroying the machine. I promised success. For the sake of the others and, I would let the process come to completion. My head started ringing, the happy effect the smoke put on me had left me the second I struck the first blow to Frank. As we walked briskly through the hallway, the ringing became more intense. I started feeling as if there were a thousand people following us.

The three of us wheeled Frank into the lab. Everything was ready and in order: the floors polished smooth, lights dim, panels cleaned, and the machine prepared. The generator had an extra compartment attached to it to accommodate the new transformers, and the leather ties had been installed. I also noticed a video camera near the control panel where I was to sit. Niles saw me looking at it.

“Donalsed insisted.”

“He knows?”

“He has to be kept informed.”

“About everything? The participants?”

“No, not everything. Not right away, anyway.”

“Hey Sam.”

“Yeah.” He uncovered Frank and prepared to hoist him up.

“Thanks for the call last night.”

He wrinkled his nose. “What call?”

“You know.”

“What are you talking about?”

Niles became interested in the conversation. I was starting to feel hostile.

“Oh, don’t give me that shit. You woke me late and said the project was scrapped.”

His face was blank. “No, I didn’t. That’s your brand of crazy talking.”

“Save it.”

Niles was smirking.

“What the fuck are you looking at?”

“You’re cracked, Jensen. Hell, I bet you dreamed it up just like all the other minutia in your twisted banal life.”

I shot a look at Uncler. He shrugged his shoulders.

“Fuck you, Niles. If Frank doesn’t work out, you’re next.”

Uncler was tugging at Frank’s body, he started moving. He went to the refrigerator and came back with a vial. He had a syringe, drew a portion from the vial and injected him in his arm.

“Now if the two of you can help me, that would be great.”

I bit my tongue. Once again, I found my mind in a whirl; this time not on the experiment, but in the tangled briar patch of my inept emotions—they had my full attention. I analyzed all the relationships I’d had in my life—the break-ups primarily—trying to figure out if I had been in the wrong and, if so, what had brought me to it. I thought of everybody I had been close to, focusing on my father and Uncler. In time I noticed that I was performing the experiment as mechanically as if I were washing the dishes or mowing the yard. I had rehearsed it so many times in my head, I was ready. Niles didn’t look at me as the three of us set Frank into position. It was a bit of an effort, but Niles was stronger than he let on. The experiment, I had to concentrate on it; a monumental task was at hand.

Frank was in place, his head hanging lazily to one side, his shirt covered with sweat. I sat at the control panel. Uncler, seemingly pleased with the setup, tilted his head at Frank.

“Where’d you find him?”

“My roommate.”

“Well, at least you didn’t have to travel far,” he quipped sarcastically.

I looked into his hazel eyes; they were soft and warm, as they had been that night in his apartment. I could sense my body wanting to repeat the encounter, but my mind was back. I had full control of all my faculties—the cipher called, I needed to finish this. I smiled and patted him on the shoulder. “Thanks for your consolation. Thanks for everything.”

He nodded and stared at the cipher. He took his position, as did Niles. I motioned for the first switch. The slow whirl began.

“Remember, level the voltage input at eight thousand.”

“I got it,” Niles said.

My finger was set just above the switch to power up the pulse current. My eyes were glued to the gauges: 7, 7.3, 7.8, 8.0—it steadied. It was definitely smoother this time, Niles did a fine job repairing the damage to the cage.

“Sam, set the pitch directly at nineteen degrees. Niles, throw the second switch.”

“Roger,” they simultaneously chimed.

The magnetic field intensity was rising: 0.5, 1, 2, 4, 5.5, 6.2, 7.1, 8. I felt no effects of the field at my position. Yes, an excellent repair job. As the whirl became resonant, I felt my head oscillating with it, as if the energy and I were in synchrony. I suddenly had a vision of my father. On the night he died, I found a note written by him.

‘After I’m gone, burn my notes, destroy the things that lie in my workshop. You must do this or all will be lost.’

Then he'd calmly gotten into his car and driven off; the wreck was found the next morning. What always bothered me, what I used to obsess over what this single question: Why hadn't he destroyed his work himself? I was never able to answer it. Later I figured it was an indirect way of telling me to continue. So here I am.

Everything was in perfect placement. I looked at Frank one last time in his present form. It wouldn't be so bad for him—at least he and Marian would be together. I wondered if they were in love. She *did* write 'love' on the note for him. I felt the outside of my pocket, the note was still there. Apparently I hadn't changed my pants, just my shirt. But if they actually *were* in love, they could endure the eternity together in the spaces without time. Just like I was going to be with Judy.

"Niles, throw the third switch." He did and my finger engaged the pulse current. The cipher ebbed with tempered greyish-white light. The gauge measuring current climbed quickly to nearly the top of the scale. Starting lambently, the light increased to a blinding wash of white and grey. Frank was a silent participant—his body convulsing, being thrown sickly back and forth, like a child's doll. I watched as his face contorted, his jaw moving to one side, twisting the whole shape of his head—nose folding over, eyes turning clockwise, hair and skin melting away, spine being pulled extremely forward, resembling a skewed T-square. But he kept the circuit connected, and that's what mattered the most.

The flat light appeared. It rose quickly and, in a matter of moments, it reached a height of two meters, a perfect cubic form. I quickly checked the gauges—no surge of the current, frequency at resonance. The machine was operating perfectly. Niles moved away from the generator, staring into the steady cube of light, frothing

with patterns bristling within. In his haste, he forgot to make minor adjustments to insure the current stability. I was able to do it from my panel, but it took all my attention—I wasn't able to watch what was going on in front of me. I suddenly realized the camera.

A low, reverberating moan came from the gate. It froze my spine. One last setting, the pulse current wasn't leveling; instead, it was fluctuating. The gate was drawing more energy to sustain the opening than we could produce. The new transformers had helped but it wasn't quite enough. The whirl and the spinning pyramidal body of the machine emitted a deafening sound. I yelled to Uncler. No response. I knew if I took my eyes from the gauges, something would go awry; the resonance could shift and the gate would decay.

I managed to do my best and looked up. Niles was only a few meters from the cube, Uncler farther back. Their gazes were fixed; they were mesmerized. I yelled to them. Nothing.

The low moan again. I looked toward the gate; several specks of black had appeared in its energy pattern. My heart seized; it was them, the ones I had seen when I'd had my body through the boundary. I felt the other part of myself coming out with them to rejoin me—to make me whole again. The need to stop the machine became overwhelming; the need to adhere my tattered soul was even greater.

Donalsed came rushing in. He stood by Niles and they both gaped wide-eyed.

The specks grew in size, the moan became clearer. A chorus of voices, hordes of travelers all speaking at once. There must have been hundred, if not thousands of them in there. Niles was at the threshold, ready to put his hand through. A massive grin spread across his face.

"It's beautiful," Niles gloated, then noticed Donalsed beside him, "We've succeeded. We can go anywhere in the universe through this." He put his arm over Donalsed's shoulder.

The moan for a second became laughter, I'd swear to it. Uncler turned and looked at me, his face stricken with confusion. The laughter echoed, I felt it coursing my body. The specks were nearly the height of the cube—ready to exit. The moans became distinct voices; chanting, calling in their alien language, but I understood them. The link was established and gate had been opened. The power drain seemed to stop, as if from the other side, power was being projected in order to stabilize the link. They were also doing the experiment, from their side, soon they will be free to enter and destroy what they could of this world. I swallowed dryly.

"Destroy? Do you think we want to destroy you?" A voice muttered into my ear.

The panel buzzed, red lights flashed, then it appeared that everything was malfunctioning at once. The current failed, then recovered. The cube flickered and the vibrations fluctuated, but the gate seemed to automatically hold itself. I looked around the lab. I couldn't see Sam anywhere. Behind me, he was at the main panel, randomly throwing switches and dials. Niles had his hand through the gate.

"I want to see what's on the other side, let's go!" I heard Niles say to Donalsed. I jumped up from my seat and shook Uncler. I was yelling, shaking him as hard as I could. "What are you doing?!"

"It's too unstable, it'll suck the whole world into it. Look!"

The lab was a wash of white and grey, as if it was inside the cube. The gate appeared translucent, by its optics, Uncler could be right.

"What?!" I exclaimed. "This was your idea!"

"It's a crack in our reality. We're all in danger!"

A wave of anger filled me, the other part of myself was almost through, I could see a figure walking in my gait among the black lines and Uncler was trying to prevent me from being complete. I couldn't let that happen. I squeezed his shoulder, hearing his collar bone break. He screamed, pitching his neck to one side. My strength, it was either magnified hundreds of times over else the energy was disturbing the molecular cohesion of our bodies. I shoved him away, using a mere gram of my energy. He slid across the floor and struck a wall. I laughed. Not this time, you *will* see this through.

"Come, come friends. Let's begin a new chapter between us." I stood before the gate just behind Niles and Donalsed.

A chorus of voices chanted in elated agreement. My senses were heightened, I could feel the thoughts of the people on my side of the gate: I felt Niles' gleeful infatuation with the gate turn sour, horror had taken him. He backed away slowly, looking at the hand that had crossed the threshold; his skin bubbled, muscles gleamed—he had begun the transformation. Donalsed seemed less enthusiastic; in an instant I knew his treacherous soul.

"Enter. Go see what is on the other side. See your true self," I said to the both of them.

Niles smiled, seemingly elated in his horror. Drool dripped from the corners of his mouth, blood from his hand; both pooled black on the smooth floor. A figure exited, its stark black silhouette stretched toward me; a sable hand reached out from the horizon. I stepped past Niles and took hold of the hand.

"Welcome."

I pulled on the hand. My first thought was to have the hand pull me in but instead I found I was pulling at it. My newly granted strength made it easy. It stopped moving mid-arm. An

electric spasm shook me. The cube was vibrating, its energy pattern sporadically shifting with an accompanying shift in the voluminous noise. It was Uncler. He was at the control panel, trying to disturb the pulse current to initiate the automatic shutdown sequence.

“Stop what you are doing!”

I released the hand. I noticed despite Sam’s efforts the cube automatically corrected itself to his shifting pulse duration, rise and fall times. We were locked in resonance, the gate could not be shut down. I regained my grip with the hand.

“Darrin!” Uncler cried. “Niles.”

In my focus on the hand, the focus on my missing self, Niles was readying himself to breach the horizon. The thin black lines in the pattern of the energy stood at our height and only a few centimeters before us. I stepped back to one side, and he jumped in. His form vanished into the cube with no more than a pop.

“What about you,” I yelled to Donalsed. “Going through?”

He stared at me, wide-eyed and shook his head in a way that told me no, although I already knew what he was thinking. I could feel Niles on the other side, his glee at seeing other worlds and new people; new ideas and new experiences.

“I think you should,” I used my free hand to grab Donalsed and I pushed him through the horizon, his form disappeared through the gate. A black silhouette was at the horizon, it became imbued with light the closer it came out. I saw its facial features, it looked human but different. It seemed to be smiling. I heard its thoughts. They were scientists just like us, curious about other people in other vast parts of the universe. They were not a threat, only travelers on a quest for knowledge, for the truth about this space we call reality. I heard the form say I had been right, my theory was always right.

It was only our fear that set roadblocks for ourselves so that we could not achieve anymore than we allowed ourselves to.

"We have to shut the gate! Now!" Sam yelled.

"No, you have it all wrong. Come over here and see." I motioned with my free arm. I heard him thinking he wasn't going to, he was afraid I'd push him through like I had Donalised.

"Darrin, don't. Let go."

I grinned, it was Cheshire. I felt my face expand to accommodate it. His fear was welcome to me, he was horrified by the changing molecular structures, how my body contorted and shifted like the pattern of energy at the horizon. I fed on it. I *used* to be afraid like that, but I never will be again.

"I'm sorry, Darrin."

Uncle went to Niles' station and opened the third switch. He was opting for manual shutdown. The power on our side was starting to reduce exponentially, too fast for the others to compensate. The hand starts to recede again. No, I will *not* be broken, desperate, and disfigured any longer. The cube is shrinking, reducing in height. I still have a firm hold. I could hear the thoughts from the other side, I am being pulled inward.

"We'll be able to repeat this experiment with your knowledge. Leave your world and come be with us. Let us show you the wonders of the universe."

In a flash I saw all the people I knew during my lifetime, those good memories and those bad. I felt ashamed how I treated myself and how I interpreted myself in relation to this experiment. I am the one, *true* genius, not because I could understand the problem more thoroughly than anybody else alive, but because I had the courage to see it to the end and at the end, had no fear. This is

what my father must've been trying to tell me. It wasn't the work that needed to be destroyed, it was myself.

"Let go! Darrin! LET FUCKING GO!"

I can hear Uncler yelling. He keeps repeating what he's saying. He really *is* a good sort, despite what he thinks about himself. But I see he is not ready for the truth, like I had been. I completely understand him, but I cannot go along with him anymore. What we had could have been special, had he not chose to take advantage of me rather than love me, as he so professed. The same could have been said about Marian and Judy. Frank, though, was a *true* friend, I could feel the love from him in the gate. Together in the spaces without time, eternal and complete. Sorry Sam, I've had enough division, enough strife, and enough nonsense. In a rapid snapping motion, I am pulled through the gate, my vision a hot flash of alabaster, then the cool ooze of onyx.

The Flashback

On this day in California, it was long and hot, much unlike the cold climate of the Midwest I knew so well. The heat was unbearable. I had been sweating; stagnant water reeked on me. She was ahead of me, in the distance, her brown hair and black eyes hypnotizing me. She was a native of the state; I was not. She was pure and innocent with love in her heart; I was blackened, a soul of ash, empty, abandoned, ready to strike and sate my desires. I should be dead; a part of me is, but the rest has yet to catch up, an irony to end all ironies—it is a fate I have learned to accept.

It was early in the new year when I first met Valerie. She struck up a conversation and I mostly listened. I didn't mind so much; she seemed to have a lot to say, and I liked to keep my life a mystery. She rambled on about her job: how it was such an intolerable place to work, the annoying customers, the demanding boss, etcetera. We both worked in a bank; it was a branch of Sanwa and the only one in Oakdale, a town stuck in the expanse of the San Joaquin valley. She was a loan officer and I a teller. I didn't particularly like the

job, but I supposed it supported me and it was the only place I could tolerate.

We were standing outside near an old drive-up window. It was late in the afternoon and finally starting to cool off.

“Did you see the way he looked at me?”

“Who?”

“The old man who came over to my desk, about one o’clock.”

I smiled and lit a cigarette. “No.”

“He just stared at me, like he didn’t know where he was or what he wanted. He said some really strange things. Something like ‘fire destroys but water consumes’...something like that.”

“Could be he was hot and wanted a glass of water, maybe it was his way of asking.” I laughed.

She hit my arm. “Not funny. He really scared me.”

I deeply inhaled the smoke. “Oh. I’m sorry.”

She waved her hand, fanning air on her neck. “It’s so strange to have such weather in February, it’s usually not this hot until summer.”

I took a long drag on the cig and exhaled it slowly, watching the smoke curl away. “Indians call it early summer, season of the flames. A time of drought.”

She smirked and fidgeted with her dress. “Sounds interesting. So do you like working here?”

“Yeah.”

She paced, smiling. It was quiet between us; I smiled back. She nodded and took a quick glance at her watch. “I’d better go in, break’s over.”

I watched her walk away. I looked up at the sun and flicked the spent cigarette at it. I wished for it to be cooler, snow perhaps,

something different. That was one of the problems with living in California—no change of seasons. It was so unlike Illinois where we used to live, my parents and I and the occasional housekeeper. In February, the temperature would be near ten below—snow up to the porch, caps on the pines, the lake frozen over, the old steam heater on the far wall uttering a steady hiss, the windows fogged. It was such a pleasant time. I wished it could have gone on forever, but as things go, something always comes along to adulterate it. I couldn't remember, but whatever it was, it changed me forever. An accident perhaps, the careless housekeeper, so much like the others, she never did know how to light the oven or the boiler when the pilot went out. It was fate, I suppose. I heard tragedy makes one's character strong, maybe it's true. It gives one the insurmountable strength to carry on, to possibly one day have relationships with others.

I met up with Valerie again later in the month. She looked better; she had dyed her hair, put on her make-up differently, wore thin frame glasses instead of the cola bottle type, and dressed better, wearing more flowing dresses instead of fluorescent shorts with sharply contrasted, plain, button-down shirts. I must admit, I had never really taken much notice nor much cared for her, but now there was something awakened that drew me to her. Perhaps it was the touch of rouge on her cheeks that lit up her face, or maybe it was the pleated skirts. Her renewed energy stirred something deep within me. I had no explanation for it. After work, I walked her to her car.

"I tell you, I didn't think I'd make it through this week. It was so hectic and the boss, he's so damn impatient," she tugged at her now darker brown hair and gazed at me with her black eyes. "I

don't know how much longer I'm going to work there, I'll probably get fired soon since I haven't been balancing lately. I'm supposed to be a loan officer, not a teller, I'm not supposed to be helping those customers. That's more your job."

I laughed and looked off into the distance. The sun was just beginning to set. It was a little cooler that day, as it had been for the last few days, but it still felt too hot for me. She opened the door, put the key into the ignition and turned on the radio. 'Chicago' by Graham Nash came on.

"Don't worry about it, Valerie, everybody makes mistakes."

The song echoed through the car...'won't you please come to Chicago, we can make a better day'...I stood and listened. Her mouth moved as if she were speaking, but I didn't hear the words; I was back in Illinois where I first heard the song, where my fantasies frequently converged with reality. I saw the fields of snow stretched all about me, reaching, clambering over the entire land. I was a surveyor, an archaeologist gazing at the spectral white, trying to find a hint of civilization—if I could only grasp a remnant of life. Just to know I wasn't alone in the barren world would be a comfort. No sound, nothing. Something reached out and shook me.

"Are you okay? I thought I lost you for a minute."

"Yeah. I'm okay. I was marveling at the sunset."

She turned and looked. "Uh huh." I rubbed my brow as if anticipating a headache.

"Maybe I've lived here too long, but all I see in the sunset is the smog."

"Like the sky is on fire."

"I suppose."

"It's beautiful, isn't it?"

I pulled out a cigarette and lit it. She looked at me with her black eyes, her deep black eyes. So clear they could have been tiny lakes, so similar to the one behind my parents' house.

"Do you have any family?" She asked.

"No, they're all," I looked again to the sky. "Gone. Dead I mean."

"I'm sorry, I shouldn't have asked."

"Don't be, there's no reason to." I smiled at her.

"Well, let's go get a drink or something, instead of talking out in this heat."

I inhaled smoke. "Sounds like a good idea."

We got into her car and she drove downtown, which consisted mainly of paltry one and two-story buildings coated in beige, sometimes an occasional light brown or faded blue. I figured the buildings were painted to match the colors of the surrounding hills, sort of a blend-in effect. I thought it was quaint; she wondered why I paid so much attention to the little things, why I cared so much for details.

"I guess ever since I was a kid, I wanted to be an artist and do something spectacular with reds and yellows."

"Did you ever?"

"All the attempts resulted in failure."

"You're too hard on yourself, I think."

"No, my parents were."

And she left it at that.

We stopped at a bar. It was early and the crowd was light. We could converse without having to shout. But as we settled down for cold beers and she opened her mouth to speak, I didn't feel like talking. I felt like listening, letting her stories wash away mine. Maybe that was why people I have run across, like Valerie, always

preferred to have drinks with me—they could spew their life stories without having to feel as though they were putting somebody out. I sat back and relaxed, drinking one beer then another. In the middle of one of her sentences, a glare from her glasses reflected into my eyes. In the blinding instant, I could see the landscape of Illinois, snow-covered and flat, the air chilly, a light breeze hanging in the air. A glint of light sparkled in the snow, it looked as if something was partially buried in it. I left the table to see what it was. I knelt before the object and tried to dig it out. The snow was cold on my hands; it gave me a start. I closed my eyes only for a moment, almost a blink, and the landscape was gone. I found myself outside in the parking lot, tugging at the locked door handle of her car. I stood for a time trying to shake off the sick feelings, then turned back to the bar. As the table came into sight, I saw myself sitting there, looking closely at her. I glared at the figure that had imposed itself as me and quickly sat in its place. Valerie was within inches of my face. I slowly leaned back in my chair.

“What? Is something wrong?”

“No, no.”

“So,” she smiled slyly. “What are you thinking about?”

“Not much.” Which was a lie.

“Oh,” she said in a disappointed tone and gazed off into the depths of the bar. People were filing in and I found myself wondering what she had been talking about, exactly who she had been talking to. Who knows what may have been said, no telling how long I had been gone. It was quiet at our table while the noise steadily increased around us. She turned back to me.

“You’re not saying anything. You sure nothing’s wrong?”

“Not at all. What makes you think that?”

“A minute ago, you were very talkative, we were having a good time. And now you clam up.”

She figited with her glass, tracing her finger along the rim. I stared blankly at the bar.

I heard a distant voice whisper in my ear, cool and calm; the pronunciation was hard, almost English.

—Talk to her.

“I’m sorry. I hope I didn’t put you off. I get so easily distracted by people sometimes. I get so wrapped up in watching them. I try to see into their souls, I’m curious what they’re thinking about. I do it at work, too. In fact, the other day, I had a run-in with a customer, I mean this guy called me an idiot after I got stuck on the computer. It wasn’t my fault, the damn thing. So you know what I did?”

“No...”

“I told him to screw himself.”

“And you still have your job?”

“As far as I know. But I did apologize to the boss. Shouldn’t have done it, but I said I was sorry.”

“I had no idea...”

“There’s a lot of things you don’t know about me.”

“I bet. When did this thing at the bank happen?”

“A couple of days ago.”

“What day?”

“I think it was Tuesday.”

“I was working then. I didn’t see anything.”

“You should have. It was pretty dramatic.”

“Hmm...wait, it could have been Wednesday. I called in sick.”

“Yes, Wednesday. That must have been when it happened.”

“Funny. All the action goes on when I’m not there, and nobody tells me about it.”

The voice whispered again.

—Why don’t you go to the bathroom?

At first I resisted, trying to ignore it, but as the voice reverberated in my head, echoing within the recesses of my mind, I found its request undeniable.

I only wanted to stay in the john a short while. I was anxious to get back to the table, to say the things I had been thinking since sitting with her. I wanted to tell her what I truly thought of her, to talk as though I had known her for a long time. I felt as if I were becoming accustomed to her. I splashed water on my face, towed it dry with paper, and left the crumpled mess by the sink. As the door closed behind me, I noticed that I was again already at the table. This time I was leaning across, kissing her. I stared at the figure; it broke from her and looked at me. It said something to her, then got up and strode toward me. The eyes of the stranger studied me carefully; his arm reached out for me, fingers clutching.

“To the bathroom.” I was pulled in. The door closed. I stood facing myself, but it wasn’t myself, it was someone who had taken over me. We were physically identical in every way, but he spoke differently, with an English accent. His speech was heavily pronounced.

“Look, don’t be an ass. Let me handle things from here on in. I promise I’ll let you participate later, in fact, I won’t even bother you. You need help and you’re damn lucky I’m here. You’re going to ruin everything, so I want you to shut up. Understand?”

“I, I said shut up.” He smiled, looked in the mirror, and straightened his tie. “You don’t know the first thing about women. I like the stupid story you told her. It was an obvious lie, I hope you

know. She knew it. Yes, she did. I can't trust you to do anything. I'm taking over, as I've had to before. I'll handle her, then you can do the rest."

I shook my head. He didn't cast a reflection in the mirror. He turned to me and grinned.

"Don't worry, friend," he put his arm around me. "I'll make things right, as always." He seized me, drawing me to him as if to embrace. I looked in the mirror, wet my hands, picked up the used towel, and patted my face. I fixed my hair and straightened my tie.

"Much better."

I turned to leave. She sat watching me as I made my way back to the table. Her eyes stared, wide and searching, following me as I sat down. We sat not saying anything, just staring at each other. I did as instructed. I became lost in the pools that were her eyes. I saw the black lake behind my parents' house, a lake whose water was so dark, so murky, I could never see beneath its surface. I often wanted, while growing up, to jump into the lake and immerse myself in the black water. I'd stand on the bank and gaze down at its mirrored surface, seeing myself peering into it, watching as my features changed with the ripples in the water. And there were nights when the waxing moon was high in the sky, when my whole body didn't look right. I appeared contorted—my head warped, listing heavily to one side, shoulder lifted, one arm twisted behind me in a sickening fashion, a low moan coming deep from within me. I wished to turn from the lake in fright, or maybe kick at the water to make the shape change, but I did neither. I was too fascinated, too wrapped up in the horror of the sight. I let the images immerse themselves in my brain.

—Jump in. It looks inviting, doesn't it?

Yes. I smiled at Valerie and we left the bar.

Nights were long. My parents continually warned me, sometimes with physical punishments, to stay clear of the black lake. One day my father hoped he could get enough money together to fill it in. They would lock me in my room to be sure I was kept away from it. But from my window, I could always see it. I'd gaze out, watching as the trees seemed to part just so I might catch a glimpse of it. I knew I was a part of the lake and the lake was a part of me. We shared an existence completely dependent on each other. I was born here, in this house, knowing only the land, my parents and the life we lived in this countryside. I belonged to every part of the landscape.

The room was dark and hot. I could hear a chorus of voices whispering. I opened my eyes. Valerie sat on the edge of the bed, her eyes fixed with mine, her clothes falling to the floor, shirt removed, bra unhooking—her body was tight. She felt warm, comforting against the cold of my skin. Her hand caressed me, slowly moving up and down my leg. Her mouth pressed to mine—the taste of alcohol, the smell of stale cigarettes. The heat was building within me, heat like the sun's; shaking, quivering, anticipating. I ran my hands over the length of her back, pressing into her spine; she tensed, then relaxed, tense, relax. Her breath quickened. I could feel the heat that emanated from between her legs as she ground herself into my thigh; I wanted her, more than I had ever wanted anybody before. She was different, new, in control—I was anxious to know what she was like, how I would feel sharing her. She smiled a wide smile, teeth gleaming; she mounted me, her hand sliding as she put me inside her. Waves flooded my body. Only the long walks on the shores of the lake could compare to the ecstasy I felt—only a dip

into the lake itself could surpass it. I was completely out of myself; I could smell the heat of passion and the pleasant cool scent of the pines. In her lips, I could taste the black, stagnant water of the lake. As our excitement heightened, I became lost between the two worlds. I tried to regain control, but lost my grip. The energy of our lovemaking escalated. I was poised inside, ready to snap, ready to sate my desires.

In a final burst, I was cast far from myself, the emotions springing me away.

I was standing before the house I grew up in. Its weathered facade glared vacantly down on me. In the feeble light of the moon, I could see its charred outline. In the distance, water lapped sickly against a putrid shore. A hand rested on my shoulder. Valerie nuzzled my ear; we locked our hands together. We walked beside the remains of the house, toward the direction of the lake. We laughed, we talked and kissed; I was in love. Our walk meant more to me than anything else she could have done for me. I was no longer cursed to wander this place alone. Pines stretched themselves above us, sweet dew dripping from the needles, giving the impression of rain. As we cleared the house, the lake came into view. Valerie stopped. She said she had gotten something in her shoe. She balanced on one leg, searching for the object. The familiar, accented low voice whispered in my ear.

—You know you have to give her to me. It's as we've always done. We share everything.

I spoke softly, so Valerie couldn't hear.

"But I love her. I can't do it."

—All the better. I will love her too. But love or hate, you cannot deny me.

“Why?”

—We share, we coexist. No more talk. You must put her into the lake.

She got up and we embraced. She felt so good to my pallid body, so kind and warm, she smelled sweet from the dew. But I knew I couldn’t deny myself. If I did, I would die...

—Or at the very least, wish for death.

With my parents it had been so simple—I hated them. Throwing them into the lake had been an easy matter. Easy, but not painless for them. My father had screamed as his body was dissolved, inch by inch, flesh to muscle to bone. His screams sometimes still echo through the pines. I didn’t want her to go through the pain, the suffering. She wasn’t deserving like my father was. I hated him. I love her.

We were before the lake.

—You know what you have to do.

I resisted. I didn’t want to send her. I didn’t want to share her. I wished to keep her for myself, that’s what I want. In my reflection in the water, I saw the figure disguised as me. She is in his arms. He is lifting her, ready to throw her in.

“No!!!” I snarled. “*I* will do it!”

I held her tightly, kissing her one last time. She smiled softly; all I felt was love. I couldn’t let her suffer alone. We both went into the lake, our shapes dissolving into the water.

The world is a dark, shapeless void; I walked, alone, hands searching in the blackness. I felt moist, moss-covered walls hewn out of live rock. I negotiated my way slowly, desperately searching for an exit. My breath became heavy, my anxiety increasing. I stopped; my feet started to sink into the mucus-saturated ground.

I broke free and ran into the darkness, unmindful of what I might encounter. Not far ahead, a dim light emanated. I kept running, running toward an end. Through a baroque archway and I was in a room. It was the basement of my parents' house. The light came from a flame—the boiler. I ascended the stairs.

Out the front window I saw an object glistening in the snow. Quietly, I pulled open the front door. I paced out and knelt before the object; my hands dug through the snow, my cold fingers wrapped around a polished brass candlestick. I looked up, thinking it possibly could have been thrown from one of the upper-story windows. I picked it up and a jolt went through me. I smiled sadistically, for I knew in an instant the nightmare was just beginning.

I searched the house for any living being. Upon finding the family dogs, I bludgeoned them, their silly gleeful expressions still fixed to their faces. The cat eluded me, but the taciturn housekeeper wasn't so fortunate. I planted the candlestick into her skull, then tore open her throat. She fell without so much as a breath. I heard rustling upstairs. I found my father in his office. He was sitting in his chair. His speech was thick, heavily accented, just the way the voices always sound.

"I knew I should have filled the lake in. But it's fate that this day has come. As it will eventually come to you."

I rushed him. Blood, warm and comforting, sprayed on my face. He fell to the floor, twitched once or twice, then was still. I set the blood-drenched candlestick down and dragged his body to the lake. A long, smeared stream of crimson trailed behind us. As he splashed into the lake, his eyes shot open. He let out a scream so terrifying and painful, I had to shield my ears. I watched him dissolve, as though his body were in acid, piece by piece. The shrieking cry

echoed through the pines. His skeleton floated momentarily, then was devoured by the lake.

I returned to the house to retrieve the housekeeper. I saw my mother coming out of the front, apparently following the trail of blood I had laid. She ran back into the house, locking the door behind her. I stood back from the door and smiled. She, in her hysteria, ran upstairs to her bedroom, grabbed a suitcase, and pointlessly started throwing clothes into it. I watched as the black figure paced closer to her. She went to the dresser by the window; I saw her looking down at me. Her expression was comically twisted and fear-stricken. The figure moved closer, its hands only inches away. I turned away and pulled my jacket tighter around me; the frigid chill was biting. A crash of glass caused me to turn toward the sound. There in the fresh snow lay her tangled body, the housekeeper next to her. A slight steam from the melting snow rose from around their bodies. I felt strong, indescribably strong.

—We share everything. Do not forget.

One at a time, I dragged them to the lake and threw them in. As they sank into the water, I saw an image of the basement. The pilot was out, gas filled the room. The black figure now disguised as me had a box of matches in its hand. He extracted one...flint touched striker...a spark...I was thrown; my body struck a pine tree. The pain was excruciating. The flames hissed, then silence.

I felt warm and wet—as if sweating in the blazing sun, as if touched by fire. I am lying down, the noise of the flames has ceased. All is quiet.

I opened my eyes and caught a glimpse of a ceiling. A faint light emanated from behind me. The bed was soft and warm. I tried to move; my arm rested against something solid. I managed to get up

and sit on the edge. I put my face in my hands and tasted iron—the iron found in blood.

She was sprawled out on the bed beside me. A dull brass candlestick protruded from her back—she appeared as if she were some child’s wind-up toy. The scene appeared amusing, although I didn’t have any heart left.

Cold laughter echoed from an open window. I rushed toward it. The air was warm. Through the glass, I saw in the distance the black lake with its sad pines crouched around it. I saw the figure disguised as me climbing out of the lake, drenched and blackened. Valerie was screaming. She was dissolving; many hands were on her. She was pulled under—a gurgling sound and air bubbles rising to the surface sickened me. I smiled at myself, teeth gleaming.

The Itch

Steven Lovan Cord, after greeting the last invited guests to his retirement party and refusing to accept a continuing role as an adviser to the Company, fell into a heap before Mrs. Donalsed on the floor. Boagaphish, Cord's grey and black tabby, whose attention had been on a balloon string wafting up and down, watched with awe and curiosity at Cord's convulsions. Near the scene, Mrs. Donalsed's looks of trepidation shot through the gathering crowd. Never had she felt more a mix of fear, loathing, and horror than when she heard the details of the news when her husband, who had been director at a University laboratory, died in a mysterious accident there. Boagaphish, cutting a swath between many sets of towering thin and thick legs covered in pressed black and blue cloths, stood over Mr. Cord's face.

Gazing intently at his wincing expressions, she sniffed his cheek angularly. Such a curiosity it was seeing him like this lying on the floor. Most of the time she found him engrossed in reading a newspaper or reports for the Company while sitting by the fire in the den. Other times she would find him in bed reading a book.

She would hop on the bed and lie next to him, snuggling just at his side, purring intently. Between turning the pages in his book, he would lay his hand just next to her and stroke her.

Jacobs, the servant, pushed his way through the crowd and knelt down beside him.

“Mr. Cord, can you hear me?” Cord had stopped convulsing, and Boagaphish could hear his breathing becoming more rhythmic. She mewed softly.

Jacobs, who had arrived five years ago, was the head servant of a staff of six. He was entrusted by Cord to his personal effects and had the most Herculean task of watching over the CEO of the most valuable technological company in the world. He delivered reports, answered the telephone, and showed in streams of people in suits and briefcases and organized Cord’s strewn documents while he was away. Soon, however, he would be taking his new role as caretaker of the man who ran the company that built the true A.I.

“Go on, cat, go away!” Jacobs swatted at Boagaphish. She meowed accusingly and sauntered to the door to the hallway stairs, pausing to look back at Jacobs talking into a mobile phone. Others in the group pulled out their phones, and the scene became a wailing chant. Boagaphish decided she was hungry. She made her way along the wall, down the stairs, and to the kitchen.

Jacobs used to be nice to Boagaphish, a day far in the past, it seemed to her. It was winter, and snow covered the grounds of the estate; a time when she did not go outside. She bored quickly of ducking into open cabinets, racing up stairs, or peering into holes. She liked to sit in the window and watch the few birds there were resting in the swaying barren trees. When Jacobs was in the room with her, he would talk to her, pick her up, and pet her. She once

found his caresses meaningful. He would feed her, making sure her water was fresh and cold and dumping out her stale food. But since Cord had started to change, everything was different. When Cord was restless and intensely emotional, Jacobs was distressed. At times Cord would be calm and witty, but the next moment he would yell throughout the house in incomprehensible rants.

This had gone on only for the past several years, ever since Cord relented that he had become an old man. After his retirement and relinquishment of his power, his mood shifted into shades of darkness. Boagaphish seemed to understand, his mind was atrophying and he was drifting away from life. He was forgetting his theories, his equations, his adaptive programs, and his passion. His life's work realized in himself, had given him long life far beyond what he had anticipated. He was aged and tired. The notion of Boagaphish, who used to be of great comfort, slowly became an irritation, a reminder of what he had done to himself. It didn't matter, he was forgetting everything save her.

A few morsels lay in her dish and she quickly ate them. She licked her face, washing an eye with her paw, then paced down the hallway to Cord's room. As she approached, she could hear the flurry of activity in the room. She peered around the door and slid into the room to a corner where she could watch. Cord was lying on the bed, his hands placed over his chest, his eyes were fixed to a point on the ceiling as if he were watching a dance of invisible black shadowed creatures. His eyes moved to and fro, his lips pursed in a muted smile. For now he seemed at peace and the conversation in the room dwindled. The guests had been escorted out, and the servants sent to clean up. Jacobs set a blanket over Cord and left the room.

Boagaphish walked to the bed and jumped to it in a smooth, gliding motion. She tucked herself under Cord's arm where she could watch his expression. His face didn't flinch, and he didn't move. Only his eyes closed, as did hers. In her dream she saw Cord as a young man. In the beginning there were only the two of them. They were in the tiny flat in the old city. Cord's room was filled with equipment, computers, various sorts of hardware, and devices. In a closet hung wires, wires she loved to play with while lying on her back. If there was one striking detail about the past she knew much about, it was wires. She twisted herself up in them, chewed on them, and chased them around the flat. Sometimes she dreamed of wires.

Her dreams drifted to pleasant times and pleasant things, to long pastures with tall grasses adorned with yellow flowers and butterflies and insects which she could endlessly stalk, chase, and pounce upon. The butterflies would always get away. Then, after such an exertion, she could lie down in the grass with sweet smells in her nose. She would sleep peacefully and dream. Her dreams were like a series of photographs devoid of any emotion, as if she were at the window thinking of herself outside. Had she been in the pasture or the garden? She didn't know. But memories are an emotional volley never linear; she only knew what she knew, her feelings the substance of her life. She knew nothing else. In her dream a strange sensation came over her. It started as a tickle in her side, like a small jolt of electricity, and soon moved down her leg. It was as if an insect was crawling into her fur and biting the skin underneath.

Cord stirred, Boagaphish awoke. He moaned softly, and she purred trying to comfort him, snuggling in a little tighter. His arm

moved from his chest to her back where he stroked her gingerly. She could feel his emotions, his shifting state from calm to fear. His caress became weak and distracted. The end was coming.

“Mr. Cord, can you hear me?”

Cord opened his eyes, they focused on Jacobs.

“Yes...”

“How are you feeling?”

Cord coughed and sighed. “As if the end is finally coming.”

Cord hacked dryly. His side where Boagaphish lay was contracting violently.

“The itch...it’s getting worse.”

“Let me get your medication.”

“It’s too late for that.”

“It can at least make you feel better.”

Cord clawed at his side and his leg.

“It’s getting worse, sir. I’m getting the medication.”

Jacobs left the room and Cord turned his head to look at Boagaphish. The strange sensation from the dream came over her. It began in her hind side and moved down her leg. She gnashed at the spot. She frantically tried to quell it. Cord placed his hand on her head and stroked her fur. The itch slowly subsided.

“My lovely Boagaphish,” Cord croaked.

She sat up and peered into his eyes. His skin was deathly pale, his eyes the look of shattered crystal. Once his eyes gleamed brightly, now he was only a remnant of what he once was. She could hear his breathing, the heaving of his chest was slow and erratic. She could feel what was going to happen, her sense told her Cord was going to die. She hung her head and mewed softly. Cord managed his arm up and stroked her ears. She purred.

“I’m sorry to have done this to you.”

He slid his hand down her back to her side where his fingers probed the itch. She turned her head around and gnashed into the place. She gnashed again, but it wouldn’t stop. She raised her leg to scratch but the sensation wouldn’t go away. She was possessed trying to put a stop to it. She had to sooth herself, to stop the itch. Nothing she did, no matter how hard she tried, would put it to rest. She saw her leg as a blinding swipe, moving so quickly it appeared as a blur. She was pressing her claws deeper and deeper into herself to no avail. Soon, fur was coming off in large clumps, stripped away to the tender skin but the itch wouldn’t subside. She bit into her leg tearing into the flesh, pulling away layer after layer of skin until she discovered a curious sight within. Metal, she saw metal, like the shiny material she had remembered seeing in the old flat. It was now in her leg. Multi-colored pieces of string were wrapped around it, they were hard and when she bit into it, she got a shock. She did not understand but feared what she was seeing. Although the pain and shock gradually decreased, she continued to tear into herself.

He began slowly. “I should have let you die,” he said in a low tone. “I have been at his game too long. And I see you have, too.” He stroked her as he had in the dark past, perhaps he could comfort her and express his love for her before it was too late.

“An unfortunate side effect to living past your time. I feel the itch too. It is a sign that death is coming. I am no longer afraid of death, I have used my feigned intelligence to extend my life by replacing my dying organs with artificial ones. Now no one can tell which part of me is human and which is machine. The real Boagaphish died half a century ago. I consumed myself in replicating her and a year later you were born. The necessary evils of such work, perhaps I

should not have become a Cyberneticist. The programs, the devices, the wires that run through you run through me.”

She stopped scratching and suddenly looked at Cord.

“If only you could understand me. But you can’t, can you? I can’t stand it any longer, the itch has taken over my entire body. I am powerless to stop it. If I could...but Jacobs won’t let me. It’s not his fault, he’s just doing as he’s told by the Company. Don’t hate him for it.”

He continued to caress her. The itch that had risen to such intensity abruptly subsided. They lay together as the room became dark. His breathing became slow and less deliberate, his body twitched and his face winced. Her gaze never left Cord’s eyes and as the last glimmers of brightness left him, she closed her eyes and dreamt of wires.
